WTF Ep# 16 | What character "flaws" make the best entrepreneurs? Nikhil ft.Ritesh, Ghazal and Manish

[Speaker 3] (0:00 - 2:05)

Whenever a young 21-year-old boy or girl wants to know what makes startup founders, people like yourself, successful, they get generic ****. We don't want to know what you've said already, so the intent here was to ask you non-usual questions. Okay guys, welcome all three of you.

Thank you guys for coming. Pleasure. The very first thing we do when we call people is we try to get to know them in a manner that even they haven't spoken online or it's not available.

So we don't want to know any of the stuff. You're all popular people, you've done interviews. We don't want to know what you've said already, so we'll try and nudge it in a direction which will help us learn a bit more about you.

And for the point of this show, there's no drama, there's no like, you know, trying to get a reaction out of anyone. It's very much focused on a 20-year-old boy or girl and when they are starting off, what can they learn from the learnings you've had without any filters? We did a venture capital episode and we came to the conclusion that 90-95% of startups fail.

You three have succeeded and you must have done something differently and today is about finding out what that could be and how other people can learn from it. So maybe we can start with Gazal. Tell us about your life from the very beginning, from childhood, all of that and take as much time.

And what others don't know yet.

[Speaker 2] (2:05 - 3:09)

Yes, what others don't know. I think others don't know a lot about how confused and how, I would say, I was still figuring it out for the longest period of time until eventually, of course, people started believing that this is the definition of success and that's for others, right? So I come from a humble middle-class family.

I was born and brought up in Chandigarh. Up till my marriage, Chandigarh was the only place that I'd stayed in because the background that my parents come from or I've come from, they were not very pro-sending women out for jobs or working. So that's the childhood that I've experienced.

I was probably the first woman in my family to go out and work. But the only difference between the rest of my family and my parents was the conviction that both my parents had to ensure that our kids are going to be independent in life.

[Speaker 3] (3:09 - 3:10)

Was this in Chandigarh?

[Speaker 2] (3:10 - 3:17)

In Chandigarh itself. So like I said, up till my marriage, Chandigarh was my geographical...

[Speaker 4] (3:17 - 3:18)

A very pretty geography.

[Speaker 2] (3:18 - 3:42)

Beautiful. It's called the city beautiful, right? I love that place.

I think till today, that's my favorite city. But while I was growing up, that wasn't the case because I saw potential outside the city but I was not sort of allowed to explore it. I was told that within this five kilometer of radius, whatever you want to do, feel free to do it.

Feel free to pick it up. So that's how my...

[Speaker 3] (3:43 - 3:44)

What did your parents do?

[Speaker 2] (3:44 - 4:23)

So my father continues to be a businessman. Very interesting story. I think first lessons in entrepreneurship is, I learned from him when I was in standard eight.

So big joint family. My father has three brothers and five sisters. So eight kids in total.

Grew up with a lot of love. But eventually realized that a business that was being run by brothers, when the parents were no longer... Their parents, my grandparents were no longer there.

There was certain friction that started coming in and there was an unfair distribution of wealth.

[Speaker 3] (4:23 - 4:25)

That happens everywhere, no? All the time.

[Speaker 2] (4:27 - 5:11)

It does. There are a lot of stories. I experienced it for the first time and with my own father.

I think even at that point of time, I couldn't imagine how can your own real blood do this to It was

very complicated. And my father, I've seen him trust his elder brother. He used to consider him his father because he wasn't there.

And that trust getting broken was like an eye-opener for me. My first experience into any kind of relationship and how it has such a strong impact on who you are or your own ability or you being able to trust anyone else after that.

[Speaker 3] (5:12 - 5:16)

What age were you when your father and his brother's thing happened?

[Speaker 2] (5:16 - 5:22)

I was in standard eight. So I think 12, 13, 14 years. Whatever that is.

[Speaker 3] (5:22 - 5:53)

I have a theory, okay? I feel like great entrepreneurs such as yourself, when asked the question, why are you successful, often give the very generic rehearsed thing that is common to everybody. But I feel like it's not because somebody is trying to lie, but we don't realize ourselves what insecurities we have deep inside, which pushed us to do a certain thing.

Hence a little unusual background.

[Speaker 2] (5:53 - 6:34)

Absolutely. So for that matter, over the years, and this is very recent, last two to three years, what I've realized is the reason for my success is not because of anything that I've done in the last five to seven years of building the business. It actually goes back to my childhood and the way my attitude got shaped because of different events that happened.

And the perspective towards looking at some of those, be it problems, be it circumstances, be it the attitude of how do you take a decision has shaped because of certain incidents which have happened, which I might not have liked back then when I was going through them, but truly have shaped me to be the person that I am.

[Speaker 3] (6:34 - 6:38)

So what changed in you? Ghazal the person. Were you a good student?

[Speaker 2] (6:38 - 6:49)

I was always a very good student. For that matter, till grade 10, I was amongst the top five in my class. I was the sports captain and I was also the best artist in the entire school.

[Speaker 3] (6:49 - 7:06)

Okay, so the overachieving Ghazal. Overachieving Ghazal at age 12, young girl going to a school in Chandigarh, watches her father and his brothers go through a difficult time. What changed in you pre and post that event?

[Speaker 2] (7:08 - 7:15)

I think one thing that I realized for the first time in my life was the helplessness that I had in that situation.

[Speaker 3] (7:15 - 7:16)

Helplessness around money?

[Speaker 2] (7:17 - 8:21)

Helplessness around comforting my father. Money didn't come into the picture then because it took a while for me to realize that okay, now money is also a problem. Did your lifestyle change?

Yes, it did. Because what he got was under a lot of debt and we had to sort of as a family take care of that. And when suddenly, because it was an unexpected event in his life, right?

He broke down and I saw him breaking down for the first time. A very confident, fun-loving person that he was. I saw him getting very quiet, not talking to people, not going out.

And I could feel that he's going into depression, right? What I also saw at that point of time was the power that my mother had to correct the situations and she had been a housewife all through her life. It was beautiful.

She pulled out all her gold savings, sold it, brought in some money, helped papa put inventory back into the shop.

[Speaker 4] (8:22 - 8:22)

What was the business?

[Speaker 2] (8:23 - 8:59)

So he was into accessories of all of these cars and trucks, like that entire business. I still don't know how to call it out. Yeah, yeah.

All of that, right? I still don't know how to accurately describe the business. But that's what my brother still continues to do.

Oh, interesting. But he was into that. But the division happened in a way that the shop that he got was under a lot of debt.

There were a lot of receivables that had to be recovered from the market. And we knew that was like a dead money already. He knew that it was a dead money.

It was not going to come back.

[Speaker 3] (8:59 - 9:02)

And how much debt? To attribute a number to it.

[Speaker 2] (9:03 - 9:11)

I think it would be anywhere between 40 to 50 lakhs back then. That was a big amount. It crumbled the hill.

[Speaker 3] (9:11 - 9:14)

Versus income of 4-5 lakhs a year? I don't think you'll be able to...

[Speaker 2] (9:14 - 10:52)

Versus an income of around a lakh a month. Right. Yeah.

So that was the kind of debt that we were looking at. And he could clearly see for the next 4-5 years, this is not going to come in. And for me to put in inventory, I don't have anything left.

So what do I do? And with a little bit of money that... The fact that a housewife can actually stand up and contribute to situations like this was again a first for me.

Because before that, mama is always sitting at home. She's the caretaker. So my, you know, the belief that you as a woman do have the ability to change things around.

Because I hadn't seen anything like that in my family ever before. Came from her. That source of inspiration came from her.

And I think that incident, of course, after that, things started getting better. Slowly and steadily. It took us almost 5 years to come out of that debt to start making money.

But the conversations that I had with my father during those 5 years were beautiful. I think the first lesson that he told me was, kid, money only comes home when the business makes profit. That was my first lesson ever.

That if any business, if it's not making profit, the money doesn't come home. It might be generating revenue, but that keeps getting... There's a cycle that exists in a business and it keeps rotating.

I also saw my mom step up by taking tuitions for smaller kids. Trying to help the family. And I saw

how they both beautifully came together.

And that was another lesson that I learned in relationship building.

[Speaker 3] (10:52 - 10:55)

Today, do you want to be more like your mother or your father?

[Speaker 2] (10:57 - 11:28)

Very interesting. I think I want to be more like my mother. The courage that she showed in that situation when papa was breaking down and the will that she had that this is not going to define the rest of our lives and we are going to turn it around is the confidence that I still hold in myself.

I always refer back to that incident. And whenever things are tough, I'm like, we will turn it around. This doesn't define who we are going to be.

[Speaker 3] (11:28 - 11:30)

And then after 1230? Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (11:31 - 12:11)

So, after that, continued to grow, I think. Value of money is what we realized then. Importance of money and how do you spend it and how do you...

So, there was a fixed budget in which you had to manage the house. All of those learnings started coming in during that time. As a student, I was doing well in school.

Plus one, plus two came. So, good in maths, good in science, doing well. Mama had this dream that...

Because it was a trend back then to be an engineer, right? Take up engineering and do that. So, good in maths and science, you're going to become an engineer.

And you're like, okay. You don't know what's in store.

[Speaker 3] (12:11 - 12:13)

And is that when you left Chandigarh?

[Speaker 2] (12:13 - 12:33)

I didn't leave Chandigarh even then. It goes on with me for the longest period of my life. I took non-medical as subjects.

And I was also under this impression that, you know, everybody used to say that... If you study

well till 10th, then you have some time free to yourself. And I took it very seriously.

[Speaker 1] (12:33 - 12:35)

See, that's a lie that everybody is told.

[Speaker 2] (12:36 - 12:37)

And it continues for life.

[Speaker 1] (12:37 - 12:39)

Yeah, yeah. 10th, 12th, then undergrad.

[Speaker 2] (12:40 - 12:41)

It's a never-ending thing, Hrithik.

[Speaker 1] (12:41 - 12:47)

Get your first job. Get the promotion. Get married.

Have children. Get your first house.

[Speaker 3] (12:49 - 12:54)

So, after the 10th, you were still like a grade A student? Till 10th.

[Speaker 2] (12:54 - 13:00)

Then life changed for me completely. I took that. After that, you can relax.

But seriously...

[Speaker 3] (13:00 - 13:03)

Did you come to terms with the fact that you're good-looking after 10th?

[Speaker 2] (13:04 - 13:06)

Oh, no, no. That's another story.

[Speaker 1] (13:06 - 13:06)

Life changed how?

[Speaker 2] (13:07 - 13:10)

Good-looking? I didn't get that in this picture. I mean, where's that gone?

[Speaker 1] (13:10 - 13:13)

It's a compliment, ma'am. I'm just trying to figure out... Say thank you for the compliment.

[Speaker 2] (13:14 - 13:16)

Then how do you become a 20-year-old 10th grader?

[Speaker 1] (13:16 - 13:18)

First, they have to recognize the looks.

[Speaker 2] (13:18 - 13:35)

Why I say that's a completely different story. Because, again, for the longest period of time... I thought I was the most horrible-looking girl that could exist.

Especially till grade 12. Okay. Reason being...

[Speaker 3] (13:35 - 13:37)

You had bad self-image till grade 12?

[Speaker 2] (13:38 - 13:40)

Just on the beauty side of it.

[Speaker 3] (13:40 - 13:42)

On the physicality of it?

[Speaker 2] (13:42 - 13:59)

On the physicality of it. I had a dark complexion compared to the other girls that I was studying with. I was very tall.

And for the longest period of time... I thought this was something which is odd. Odd, yeah.

Because...

[Speaker 1] (13:59 - 14:00)

Last one in the row.

[Speaker 2] (14:00 - 14:06)

They used to make me stand in height in school. And the smallest one... And all the girls used to fit in the first five and six.

[Speaker 1] (14:06 - 14:08)

Early in the morning, you know your grade. You're last to stand.

[Speaker 2] (14:09 - 14:25)

Oh, yeah. All the girls used to fit in the first five rows. And I used to be in the 12th, 13th row.

Back with the boys, right? When did that change? That changed after grade 12.

When the attention from the boys started coming in.

[Speaker 4] (14:25 - 14:25)

Which college did you go to?

[Speaker 2] (14:25 - 14:29)

And I started getting compliments. Again, Chandigarh, MCMDAV.

[Speaker 3] (14:29 - 14:33)

Which is a girls' college. In Chandigarh, everybody is good-looking. So, differentiating is hard, right?

Yeah.

[Speaker 4] (14:34 - 14:38)

So, not everybody... I'll take that as a compliment again.

[Speaker 2] (14:38 - 14:50)

But yeah, Chandigarh... I don't know. For me, the definition of good-looking has changed considerably from there.

So, I always used to think that I'm not this person...

[Speaker 3] (14:50 - 15:04)

All good-looking people say that. Like, you know, good-looking is relative and all that. Let me redefine it for you.

Did you get... If your class had 20 girls... Did you get more attention than the majority of the

class?

[Speaker 2] (15:04 - 15:14)

From men? Or boys? Till grade 10, no.

Post grade 12, yeah. Post grade 10, yes. Okay.

Okay.

[Speaker 3] (15:14 - 15:15)

So, grade 12, you went to college.

[Speaker 2] (15:15 - 15:27)

That actually worked well for me, by the way. Because it did help me realize that I'm not probably as bad. It's okay, I think.

But even there, it was my mother who changed it around.

[Speaker 3] (15:27 - 15:57)

What does that do for a girl? Like, I will never know this because I can't resonate with how a girl would feel. But when a girl gets male attention and is appreciated or is wanted from a very, like, emotional lens, is wanted by many people, desirable, what does it do to you?

Like, how do you feel? Is it validation of something? Is it an insecurity going away?

How do you feel?

[Speaker 2] (15:57 - 16:57)

So, for me, it was an insecurity going away and me becoming more confident in my appearance. For example, you have farewells, right? In schools.

Farewell parties, etc. And you have to dress up and you have these events which are happening. Ramp walks, etc.

All the kids participate. I never used to participate in that. I never had the confidence to go up the stage.

I never had the confidence that, if I dress up and style my hair, I will end up looking good. So, that emotion was so strong that I used to avoid events like these. My mother realized that I was trying to avoid some of these events because I was image conscious and I felt I wasn't beautiful, is when she brought in a lot of magazines at home.

And she started talking to me about a few models and I was not interested in that space at all. And just for me to feel a little more confident on how I looked, she started complimenting me at home. For anything.

Like, any weird thing that I'm doing.

[Speaker 3] (16:57 - 16:59)

What year was this? Around 2000?

[Speaker 2] (16:59 - 17:01)

This was in grade 12. I clearly remember.

[Speaker 3] (17:01 - 17:02)

2004-2005?

[Speaker 2] (17:03 - 17:04)

Yeah, around that time.

[Speaker 3] (17:05 - 17:08)

Yes. Okay. So, Gazal got good looking in grade 12.

[Speaker 2] (17:09 - 17:11)

I didn't get good looking. I was still looking the same.

[Speaker 3] (17:12 - 17:17)

Boys started running behind Gazal. Went to college in Chandigarh. And what next?

[Speaker 2] (17:18 - 17:25)

I wouldn't say boys started running behind me. Nothing of that. But, yeah.

A little bit of intention worked. What is he discovering? I know.

I don't know.

[Speaker 1] (17:26 - 17:28)

In the end, you say, this is my analogy.

[Speaker 2] (17:29 - 17:29)

No, no.

[Speaker 3] (17:29 - 17:30)

This is not therapy.

[Speaker 2] (17:31 - 18:44)

Some of these years are so... Formative. Yes.

So much happens on so many different levels. Be it your family side. Be it the person that you're becoming.

Be it your attitude towards things. Be it friends and all of that. It forms you as a person.

And, I mean, 12th again was a very, very difficult year for me. Because I realized that engineering was not something that I wanted to do. I also realized that my parents didn't have money.

And they figured from somewhere. And they spent so much on the coachings that you have to take. To prepare for the entrance exams, etc.

And I was wasting that money. I was becoming more confident on how I looked. So, on the image side of it.

I was realizing the importance of different relationships. And how it's very important to have fewer people in life. But have them really close to you.

I also experienced a lot of friends moving away. And the pain that it causes. Because somebody can be your best friend today and tomorrow.

Because the school changes. The college changes. You know, you've picked up computers.

They've picked up something else. That relationship changes. And they move on in life.

[Speaker 3] (18:45 - 19:03)

And that was... Are you like that now? Did you become a person who really gives importance to loyalty.

When you watched what happened between your father and his brothers. When you were 12, 13. And has that continued?

At Mama Earth today, is loyalty a big thing?

[Speaker 2] (19:03 - 19:26)

Till today, loyalty is the most important thing for me in any relationship. Be it with my employers.

Be it with my family.

Be it with my... Any kind of relationships or friends. I...

If it gets broken once. It's very difficult for me to be that same person with that person again.

[Speaker 4] (19:26 - 19:27)

Unforgiving?

[Speaker 2] (19:28 - 19:43)

Not unforgiving. But I don't forget it. There's a difference.

I will forgive the person. But I will not forget what happened. And that feeling stays with me.

Because of which I'm not able to be that same person again.

[Speaker 3] (19:43 - 19:44)

Do you think that's a good thing or a bad thing?

[Speaker 2] (19:44 - 20:02)

I think it's a very bad thing. It does more harm to me than anybody else. And...

I want to let it go. I've tried really hard that this should move away. I should be that person who doesn't care, etc.

It's been so many years now. But I haven't been able to change it. A bit.

[Speaker 1] (20:03 - 20:09)

That's fine. Actually, I forget but I don't forgive. And I forget like this.

I don't remember anything.

[Speaker 2] (20:10 - 20:11)

This is better. That's a blessing.

[Speaker 1] (20:11 - 20:15)

I just don't remember that person. Forgetting is the same as forgiving if you can't remember.

[Speaker 2] (20:15 - 20:19)

Yeah, it's a blessing if you can do that. Trust me.

[Speaker 1] (20:19 - 20:29)

And it's only because that work pulls me so hard that I... I kind of forget everything which is around me. Okay, just finish on Gazal.

[Speaker 3] (20:29 - 20:30)

Okay, you went to college then.

[Speaker 2] (20:30 - 21:56)

Yeah, so college I was like a very aggressive... Because of what had happened with my dad and all of that time. One thing that my mother told me was...

You know how you have these parties? Like I talked about the farewell parties. Or you want to go out with your friends for a movie or for a lunch, etc.

Everybody pulls in money, right? And when you have to pull in money at that age, you're asking your parents to give you some money or a pocket money, right? And one day, I saw some crazy discussion.

But I saw my mom telling me, I don't have the money to give you. So I can't go. And this happened two, three times.

I don't know what the reason was behind that. But either she actually did not have money or she wanted me to learn something out of it or value money more, whatever that was. There's this one line that she said when I said that, you know what, you're not giving me money.

How do I do? Everybody gets it. I will make my own money.

So she said, till the time you're taking money from anybody else, whoever you're taking it from will make decisions for you. The day you start earning your own money is the day you get to choose where to spend it on. And that is what I took with me all through these years.

And when I entered college… So college is very liberating, right? Unlike school where you have a fixed routine.

College, you also have some time and you know you're going to…

[Speaker 1] (21:56 - 21:58)

I have no idea. I never went to college. So it's the same.

[Speaker 2] (22:00 - 22:29)

It's liberating in the sense that you have more time to yourself than you had while you were in

school. You also have a little more freedom because you have your own vehicle. You have to go to college.

You have to take classes. Then you're taking coaching, etc. I actually used that opportunity and I tried to find a job for myself because I said, college, I have to have my own money if I want to spend it my way.

How do I make money? I started taking tuitions. Until I could figure out something else.

[Speaker 4] (22:29 - 22:30)

What were you teaching?

[Speaker 2] (22:30 - 22:36)

Maths and science. To students who were pre-10th, till 10th, I would say.

[Speaker 1] (22:36 - 22:37)

Little guzzles.

[Speaker 2] (22:38 - 22:49)

Little guzzles, like… But I was teaching everything because my objective was not… I was not focused on what I'm teaching.

I was focused on what's the money that's coming in and how much am I able to make, right?

[Speaker 3] (22:49 - 22:51)

So tuitions, college on the side.

[Speaker 2] (22:52 - 24:46)

College, tuition on the side. And that's the time when I also picked up my passion for computers because I had experienced it as an elective subject in grade 10th. Grade 11, 12th, it got taken away from me and I was missing it like crazy.

So I realized that that's my passion. So when I went to my parents saying, you know, engineering is not something that I want to do. And I didn't sit for the entrance exams with a fear that what if I get through?

Then I'll be pushed towards pursuing this as a career. So I didn't do that. And instead said, regular college.

Regular college that has minimal fee. MCMDAV. It's an all-girls college.

And on the side, while I'll take tuitions, I'll also figure out what is it that I want to do. And I picked up computers. I joined NIIT.

There was this course, two and a half year course called GNIIT which basically gave you exposure towards multiple different languages and softwares. So that's something that I picked up and I thoroughly enjoyed it. I loved it so much that I went to my principal in college.

I said, this is something that I'm doing. I'm working really hard. I want you to give me some time off college hours because attendance used to be a concern there and you had to have like a minimum.

I think she understood my passion or I don't know what happened. She gave me that permission that, okay, you're taking this another course. You're doing really well there.

Every six months, you used to get a scorecard that I had to submit at college, but continue to do that. But when I picked that up, I had to leave the tuition. So the money that was coming in, the comfort of having your own, you know, little whatever, that two, three thousand at that point of time, it was, right?

But it was a lot. It was mine. I could choose to spend it on a dress that I want or go out with my friends.

How old were you then, Gajju? 18? Yeah, 17, 18.

17, 18. That money went away, but the hunger for money still stayed. So when I was taking this…

[Speaker 3] (24:46 - 25:18)

Why is that? I've heard this from a lot of people. I think Ritesh will resonate.

If you make… If one were to equate money with power, power corrupts above all else, right? The more power you have, the more you want.

There is no concept of being satisfied by virtue of power. Why do you think most people, when they get… It might be a bad analogy, but the taste of money early wants so much more in a very precocious manner where they want it so quickly.

What is it about money?

[Speaker 2] (25:19 - 25:42)

I think early on… Early on… Absolutely.

That's one of the things. Early on in your journey, when you taste money and you're able to… And that's only my view, I don't know.

You're able to experience the comforts that it brings, right? Comfort could be a mental comfort that I have this cushion. It could be the things that I'm able to buy.

It could be experiences that I'm able to take.

[Speaker 3] (25:43 - 26:01)

Is it that? Or is it when your father split, he was depressed, lifestyle changed? That's so ingrained in your subconscious that when you made money, your subconscious was thinking that you're solving what happened to you as a 12-year-old?

Because the comfort is irrelevant. Everybody gets happy when they get things.

[Speaker 2] (26:02 - 26:09)

So I would phrase it that I went through the discomfort that happens when you don't have money.

[Speaker 3] (26:09 - 26:10)

At 12, 13.

[Speaker 2] (26:10 - 26:10)

Right?

[Speaker 3] (26:10 - 26:11)

The biggest trigger there.

[Speaker 2] (26:11 - 26:22)

Yes. And I also saw my dad break down. So subconsciously, in my mind, money was a very, very important tool for you to be happy.

[Speaker 3] (26:22 - 26:32)

So when you started earning, it was not the shoe or bag you bought. But deep down, it was that problem that you didn't want to go back and address in your own mind even.

[Speaker 2] (26:33 - 26:46)

In my mind, I was taking pressure off my parents by not asking them for money. And that was my way to help them, which I was not able to do when I was, you know...

[Speaker 1] (26:46 - 27:09)

But I believe, Nikhil, once you've truly been... And you know, again, poor is a relative term. But I

think once you've really been through trouble, right?

Like when you basically... To put food on the table is a challenge. You never want to go back to it.

I think that feeling of remembering back that specific period is... It's such a stark feeling.

[Speaker 3] (27:09 - 27:11)

I think that's a very obvious thing, though. Of course.

[Speaker 1] (27:12 - 27:12)

Of course.

[Speaker 3] (27:12 - 27:16)

Someone who is hungry knows the... Someone who was hungry...

[Speaker 1] (27:16 - 27:16)

Correct.

[Speaker 3] (27:17 - 27:19)

...knows the advantage of not being hungry today.

[Speaker 1] (27:19 - 27:19)

Yeah.

[Speaker 3] (27:19 - 27:24)

I'm trying to get at what is the emotion that got ingrained in your brain when you were hungry.

[Speaker 1] (27:25 - 27:27)

Makes sense. Makes sense.

[Speaker 2] (27:28 - 27:53)

Now that you've asked that question and I'm thinking about it, I haven't thought about it earlier, right? For me, that emotion still... It stayed.

Even when we started Mama Earth out, because I did not have any experience in beauty or personal care, I had no intention of building a business. I'm an artist as well. I was selling my works nationally, internationally back then, doing really well.

Can I ask you a question? Yeah.

[Speaker 3] (27:53 - 27:55)

Who are your favourite artists?

[Speaker 2] (27:55 - 27:56)

My favourite...

[Speaker 3] (27:56 - 27:59)

They say that kind of art you like tells you a lot about a person.

[Speaker 2] (27:59 - 28:05)

Is it? So my favourite artist is Seema Kohli followed by Paresh Mehti. Both of these are Indian artists.

[Speaker 4] (28:05 - 28:06)

I know.

[Speaker 2] (28:06 - 28:14)

I've met them. I've seen their work. I've taken a lot of inspiration from them.

I love Van Gogh. And I love Picasso.

[Speaker 3] (28:14 - 28:19)

Which painting? If you say Picasso, do you like his red face, his blue face? Do you like Cubism?

[Speaker 2] (28:20 - 28:28)

I like Cubism the most. Why? You will also see a bit of it in my work.

Why? There is so much depth to that painting.

[Speaker 3] (28:28 - 28:42)

I think Cubism was not him originally. Cezanne started it. He got inspired, right?

I think it was the first time when some artist did not depict something as it is but took a derivative of it and that appealed to him.

[Speaker 2] (28:42 - 29:17)

But my favourite works of Picasso have been on the lines of Cubism. I just feel that when you put

those lines to form certain shapes and I don't know how true that is but there is so much interpretation or there is so much depth to it that you can pull out. Every time I look at these paintings, I feel a different emotion.

And it goes back to how I am feeling at that point of time when I am looking at the painting. And that's something that I wish I am able to bring out through my work.

[Speaker 3] (29:18 - 29:21)

How long after college did Mahmood start? Just out of curiosity.

[Speaker 2] (29:23 - 29:44)

So I spent almost three and a half years with NIIT. Then I was an artist for two and a half years. And after that two years, I was working in India and after that Mahmood happened.

So almost seven years.

[Speaker 1] (29:45 - 29:45)

Not long.

[Speaker 2] (29:46 - 29:51)

Seven, seven and a half years. When I had my son is when Mahmood happened.

[Speaker 1] (29:51 - 29:53)

Really? So which year did you start Mahmood?

[Speaker 2] (29:53 - 29:57)

So Mahmood started because of my son when I became a mama.

[Speaker 4] (29:57 - 29:58)

Wow.

[Speaker 2] (29:59 - 30:07)

Is that why you called it Mahmood? The mama word did come from there. But there were a lot of other reasons as well.

Right.

[Speaker 3] (30:08 - 30:10)

Now the mama story has been told already.

[Speaker 2] (30:10 - 30:11)

Yes.

[Speaker 3] (30:11 - 30:16)

So I won't go into that too much. But NIIT, then what did you say?

[Speaker 2] (30:16 - 31:48)

Yeah, so studied at NIIT. While studying at NIIT, took up my first job with NIIT which was a corporate trainer. No experience just because height achi thi, mama ka suit pehen liya tha.

Went, gave an interview, got cleared. Next day they asked us to give whatever documents we had because they had to finalize it. Is when they realized that I don't, my age is not eligible, I don't have any prior experience and I'm a student of NIIT so I can't take the role up.

Convinced them in some way that, give me one, if it doesn't work out, I won't charge for it. Like I was doing it for money, right? There was no other reason.

But they were kind enough to give me that one opportunity. Learned on the job, had no idea how to train people. This was a training that I was taking for people who were in their 40s to 50 years of age bracket who had been working with their company for almost 10 to 15 years.

And I was the one who was taking a software that NIIT had built to them saying, I will teach you how you can do your work better. That was also the first time I experienced that confidence can be faked. Because I was, I had, my legs were shivering when I entered that room.

I was a student and I was supposed to become their teacher. And tell them, how can you use this software that I had also learnt just 7-10 days back. And sort of, you know, it's learning on the job.

[Speaker 1] (31:48 - 31:55)

This is the number one competency in entrepreneurship that you have to be confident no matter what. But really you have no idea what's going to happen next.

[Speaker 2] (31:56 - 32:20)

I know. But again, I think on the flip side, I always think, what can go wrong? Worst case, I'll be thrown out of it.

Any which ways, don't have it. So like, nothing can be worse than that. I will eventually complete the course.

Yeah, so that's okay. The downside was so low. The risk of failing was so low that then you confidently go and you pitch it and you take those trainings.

[Speaker 3] (32:21 - 32:37)

How did you come up, like, I know there's an onion oil Yeah. which has played a big part in this story. I want to know a bit more about that.

How did you go from NIIT to being an artist? I'm guessing you sold a reasonable amount of art, did fairly well.

[Speaker 4] (32:37 - 32:37)

Yeah.

[Speaker 3] (32:37 - 32:39)

How did, what kind of art did you make?

[Speaker 2] (32:40 - 32:43)

So I'm also into semi-abstraction, inspired by these guys.

[Speaker 3] (32:43 - 32:47)

Okay, so you're doing decently as an artist. You were married by this time?

[Speaker 2] (32:48 - 33:45)

Yeah, yeah, so there's a lot of journey in between. So NIIT did that. Eventually ended up taking that as my main job.

Did that for about three and a half years. Met Varun. We got married.

Where did you meet him? Arranged marriage. His aunt used to be my neighbor in Chandigarh.

She's the one who arranged it between us. Of course, Varun and I were chatting on social media before that because we used to come visit aunt often. But we were like, yes, this is an arranged marriage.

The way you're saying, got married. First boyfriend? No, I had a couple of boyfriends before that.

First husband. Met Varun. The first question that he asked me when we met, right?

Not exactly the first question, but during that first conversation was, what is it that you want to do? And of course, you say a lot of things, etc, etc. My mother had prepared me.

[Speaker 3] (33:45 - 33:47)

What did Varun do when you guys got married?

[Speaker 2] (33:47 - 33:48)

Varun was working with HUL.

[Speaker 4] (33:49 - 33:50)

Okay, FMCG.

[Speaker 2] (33:50 - 34:56)

Yeah, FMCG. Varun has a pure FMCG experience. He was working with HUL.

Very good job. We got married within five months of meeting each other. I moved to Delhi.

And within two months of marriage, Varun had to move to Philippines for his job. And because we were in this new relationship, still trying to figure each other out and the relationship out and you don't want to be... I took a call that I will leave my job and I'll move to Philippines with him.

So when I moved to Philippines is where I had a lot of ample time. I picked up this passion for painting. I think one day, I just pulled out some paints and canvases and I painted.

And I didn't realize I was painting the entire night till morning about 6.30, 7. And by the time Varun woke up, I had like four, five works ready to be hung on the wall. And he was super surprised.

So without telling me, he actually submitted my works to a couple of colleges internationally. Because earlier he had asked, you know, what's your passion? I said painting is my passion.

Whenever I get time, I'll pick it up. He'd ask that, what do you like?

[Speaker 1] (34:56 - 34:57)

He didn't know it's that serious.

[Speaker 2] (34:57 - 35:21)

Yeah, he was very surprised. So he asked me that question back then when we were getting married, right? That if given a chance, would you want to pursue it professionally?

And I said, yes. So yeah, without telling me, sent the works to the academy, couple of colleges. I got a call from New York Academy of Arts to come there and pursue artists with them.

You know, the course with them, it was a nine month course.

[Speaker 3] (35:22 - 35:22)

And... What year?

[Speaker 2] (35:24 - 36:42)

This was right into our marriage. We got married in 2011. So this was 2012.

We'd spent about six months in Philippines while I was doing all of this. So 2011, 2012 is when this happened. And before, even when the call came, he did not tell me the call has come.

He figured out that if I have to go to that place, where do I stay? How do I manage? Because he knew that this girl has never been out of Chandigarh, let alone going to New York and pursuing this.

He figured all the nitty gritties out. Where will she stay? Who are her friends?

How will she manage? Etc, etc. And when everything was sorted, that's when he said that if I tell you, you can go to New York Academy of Arts, would you go?

I said, of course, I would love to go. With an assumption that he'll go with me. Um, he said, that's when he said that a call has come, but you'll have to go alone.

Because he was also new into his journey of, you know, handling Southeast Asian markets. But, um, I said no. And then he convinced me to take the risk, go there alone, figure it out.

Yes. Good husband. Yes.

That's good. I'm blessed. You guys.

[Speaker 1] (36:44 - 36:50)

Over to you. We have to make sure that we sound good for our wives.

[Speaker 2] (36:53 - 36:56)

Yeah. So when there, then first heroes. But go on.

[Speaker 1] (36:57 - 37:04)

No, no. I really wish that Geet also says the same things about me. I have no idea.

I'll only find out. But please go on. But you would know.

[Speaker 4] (37:04 - 37:07)

You would be putting things together, right?

[Speaker 1] (37:07 - 37:15)

Yeah, of course. But look, we've dated each other now for what, 11 years. So ever since high school.

So there's probably a longer context.

[Speaker 4] (37:15 - 37:18)

But we'll come to it later. Yes, I did that.

[Speaker 2] (37:18 - 37:27)

Really enjoyed my time there. Went for a very different course, which was realism, where you paint photo-like real pictures.

[Speaker 3] (37:27 - 37:28)

Old school impressionism.

[Speaker 2] (37:29 - 38:19)

Yes. And hated it. It's still life.

Was learning that. I signed up for that course. I got invited for it and I hated it.

And then I still remember, like, one of these side opportunities came in, which was a call for artists and you can submit your artworks. And I created something that I felt like, in, I think, three hours. And I submitted that work.

And it got selected to be exhibited at New York Academy of Arts. It was up in their gallery until about two years back. That is what gave me confidence that, again, it's not about what you know or what you are learning.

Something entirely different caught the attention of my teachers and it got selected. So then that's where I started my journey around painting. Came back to India.

Started exhibiting works. Started getting sold. Was doing really well.

I thought that was something that I wanted to do for the rest of my life.

[Speaker 3] (38:19 - 38:21)

How Mama Earth? I'm still wondering.

[Speaker 2] (38:21 - 39:04)

So Mama Earth happened after this. While I was an artist, we went on our family route. I was expecting.

Agastya happened. What year? This is 2014.

Okay. And first six months were okay. You're still figuring out, right?

We used to have a lot of, like, our doctor used to call us Google parents because we were googling each and everything around baby. You're so worried as a new parent that you would end up breaking the baby. That...

I mean, we were, like, hell lot of paranoid set of parents. Not just me. Set of parents.

Our japa maid, which helps you with the baby for the first three months, left in 15 days. She said, you guys don't let me do anything. Why have you signed me up?

She left in 15 days.

[Speaker 1] (39:04 - 39:08)

She used to hold the child like this and you have to see it when she does this.

[Speaker 2] (39:08 - 39:48)

And you can't do that, right? So we did allow her to feed the baby. We didn't allow her to sleep with the baby.

We didn't allow her to bathe the baby. Everything we were doing ourselves. So she left.

And our doctor also was saying the same things. Google parents, etc. I think it was after that where Agastya started having some skin reactions because of which I realized that the products that we were using on him were not good enough.

We started ordering from outside of India and those products were suiting him really well. So that is how, you know, as a cribbing wife, I went to Varun. Why isn't, why?

Why isn't anyone doing anything Why don't we have regulations? Like we did not have any regulations.

[Speaker 3] (39:48 - 39:49)

What products were you ordering from outside?

[Speaker 2] (39:50 - 39:55)

So there's this brand called Babyganics. Okay. And there is this brand called Honest.

Yeah.

[Speaker 3] (39:56 - 39:58)

Like Jessica Alba. Yes, Jessica Alba.

[Speaker 2] (39:58 - 40:02)

I was ordering products from these two brands and hoarding it like crazy. Cupboard full of cupboards.

[Speaker 3] (40:02 - 40:03)

They were all like organic.

[Speaker 2] (40:04 - 40:15)

Natural, organic. Very low, you know, food grade preservatives, etc. And we did not have anything like that in India.

India was, even the products that were calling themselves out as Ayurveda.

[Speaker 1] (40:16 - 40:17)

Whatever was existing.

[Speaker 2] (40:17 - 40:30)

That was my, I shouldn't, that was my trigger. That was my trigger. Because whenever anybody has a new baby, maximum number of gift sets come from the brand that you said, right?

[Speaker 3] (40:31 - 40:32)

Johnson's and Johnson's. I'll see.

[Speaker 2] (40:33 - 40:37)

Yeah, my first achievement was getting a Foreign brands are so bad.

[Speaker 3] (40:38 - 40:39)

It's not Indian brand.

[Speaker 2] (40:39 - 41:19)

So save more. So that was my trigger, right? That was, I was like, this is just not acceptable outside of India.

And because I had lived in New York, I knew. Back in New York, there was this whole movement around J&J going on where their talc had some cancer causing ingredients in them and they were being taken off the shelves. So I knew that there's something off with the brand because I used to use that talc back then.

When I came to India and I was getting all of those gift sets. And then internationally those controversies are happening. And India also started getting those cases.

Is when it was, it was like a very strong trigger that how can this come close to any of our babies?

[Speaker 3] (41:19 - 41:23)

Is there a regulation now which makes it harder for stuff like that to come in?

[Speaker 2] (41:24 - 41:44)

I don't think there's any regulation per se. But that's what we solved for through Mamount India. I don't think there is.

So for example, Ayush would have brought in certain rules on the ingredient usage and how do they certify products to be Ayush certified. But back then there wasn't.

[Speaker 3] (41:44 - 41:52)

So you figured there's no such product in India. You have to make it. So what is the, how do you go from there to making a product?

[Speaker 2] (41:53 - 42:55)

Yeah, so like a very brief conversation between me and Varun where I'm saying ordering products is so crazy. You're like tracking friends and family. Who's going where?

What are you doing? Bring this packet. Then that packet gets lost in the transit.

Right? It was so much pain. And I just went as a cribbing wife.

I said, why? This problem needs to be solved. Why isn't anyone doing this And he just made one statement.

He said, if nobody else is doing it, why don't you give it a try? And that statement stuck. I think all through my life, I'm just realising now that there have been certain statements which have been like life-changing for me.

And this was one of those statements where he said, figure it out. Can it be done or not? It might be a possibility that it's not possible in India.

Ingredients are only available outside and hence it's not happening. I got like a lever to I wore that research hat and I went mad around figuring out what's happening in the baby care industry, in personal care. Can someone do this?

[Speaker 3] (42:55 - 43:11)

If I were a 20-year-old girl and I want to start like an organic Indian, maybe Ayurveda inspired something like that brand. Can I create an oil or a shampoo or a soap or something like that?

[Speaker 2] (43:11 - 43:31)

Absolutely. And it's not even difficult. And it doesn't have to be very expensive.

I think all you need to do is so for example, what is the kind of product that I'm trying to create? What are the kind of ingredients that I want the product to have? Where are those ingredients available?

And at what cost?

[Speaker 3] (43:32 - 43:53)

Tell me, I want I'm a 21-year-old girl. I want to start a shampoo which is very good for me. Don't laugh at me being a 21-year-old girl.

Where do I go about finding out what goes into a shampoo? What goes into a shampoo? How do I get those ingredients and how do I put them together?

[Speaker 2] (43:53 - 44:06)

You have to have a product that you believe in. That this is something truly differentiated and is not available in the market. Or is providing convenience or is extremely superior.

[Speaker 3] (44:06 - 44:09)

But how do I do that? I want to make a shampoo. How do I make it?

[Speaker 2] (44:09 - 44:56)

Okay. So what we if I'm a 21-year-old One, you google formulation of shampoo very easily available. What are the ingredients that go into it?

You google, I want to make a shampoo at home. You understand that okay there is a surfactant system which causes foaming. These are the ingredients.

This is what I want to put. The difficult part is to understand what are the ingredients that you want to replace it with? And how do you go about creating those formulations?

That is where Google might not be able to help you as much if you don't know what do you want to replace it with. So my journey on creating that product and that was a baby shampoo back then started by reading the labels of these brands that I was sourcing from US.

[Speaker 3] (44:57 - 44:59)

That's a good hack, right? If there's something nice out there.

[Speaker 2] (44:59 - 45:00)

Absolutely.

[Speaker 1] (45:00 - 45:00)

Which is expensive.

[Speaker 2] (45:00 - 45:02)

If you have a reference point.

[Speaker 1] (45:02 - 45:03)

You can make it for cheap.

[Speaker 2] (45:03 - 45:06)

Yes. And study the in and out of that product.

[Speaker 1] (45:06 - 45:11)

Are you trying to say you make that assessment and make your own derived formula like a...

[Speaker 2] (45:11 - 45:12)

No, no, no.

[Speaker 1] (45:12 - 45:21)

No, no. For the moment like this could be swapped in. So now you go to an expert to get that validation that's of course there.

But you could do all this within yourself in the same Google frame.

[Speaker 2] (45:21 - 45:55)

No, I just did paperwork. I was just on the paper studying and trying to understand what is it that I want to build? What is it?

What should a shampoo have which will make it milder yet effective and be very different from what's available in India which was more harmful ingredients. Outside of India those ingredients were banned in a few countries to be used on a baby's skin which were being widely used in India. Right?

So one, for example studying... I just studied US regulation because that's where the products were being lifted off.

[Speaker 3] (45:55 - 45:57)

How do you study US regulation? Where do you find it?

[Speaker 2] (45:58 - 47:02)

Online? Absolutely freely available. Freely available.

You can study US. You can study Europe. I did all of that.

Google was my best friend. And studying these products for example going to an honest company's website and seeing what are the ingredients that they're putting in their product. What is the source?

You take the name of that ingredient you put it on Google it tells you what that ingredient does why is it used for what is the ideal percentage etc. etc. So the only thing that I understood out of all of that study was the fact that one coconut-based cleansers exist which can make the shampoo far more milder and non-irritant in nature be it for the eyes be it for the skin.

And I wanted to replace the harsh surfactant systems which were banned in countries outside of India but were being used in the baby products here with the coconut-based surfactants. And then after that I had to reach out to people who could help me build formulations. And when you're starting out How do you find these people?

[Speaker 3] (47:02 - 47:28)

Yeah, so like again cold calling cold mailing So you can find if I go on Google and say I'm a 21 year old girl I think my shampoo is horrible I find a shampoo a really expensive honest company shampoo which I really like I look at the difference in ingredients of that and what is available here And then I need to find people who will make this for me.

[Speaker 2] (47:28 - 47:28)

Yeah.

[Speaker 3] (47:29 - 47:30)

Who do I call? What do I Google?

[Speaker 2] (47:31 - 47:42)

So here is where LinkedIn helped. Because on LinkedIn you can specifically put search people out who are into research and development for personal care products.

[Speaker 3] (47:43 - 47:43)

Interesting.

[Speaker 2] (47:43 - 48:04)

Right? So that's where LinkedIn came handy and we of course we like pulled out at least at least 30, 35, 40 people that we wanted to reach out to. We sent we figured their email IDs from LinkedIn itself.

I sent cold mails to these people. Probably out of those 35, three reverted.

[Speaker 1] (48:04 - 48:08)

And one out of them And what timeline? Months or?

[Speaker 2] (48:08 - 48:56)

No, no, no. I think that way our system is good. Even today if you write a cold email to somebody I think you mostly get a reply.

It might be different now because the definition of entrepreneurship has changed. It's not that easy in real estate. Yeah.

Back then there was this again, you know you have to find people who are able to understand what you're trying to say. We were a set of parents trying to solve a problem that a lot of our friend parents were also facing. How do you establish that connect?

So we wrote a parent couple trying to solve a problem as the subject of the mail that we had sent out. And I think that really helped us. Be it finding the right manufacturing partner or finding this scientist couple who helped us build formulations.

But that was also true, right?

[Speaker 1] (48:56 - 48:58)

Because I did not have... It's a real story.

[Speaker 2] (48:58 - 49:43)

I couldn't say anything about myself apart from being just a mom. So they reverted. They helped us put basic formulations together.

Of course, they did not have any manufacturing units. So we had to find another partner who could manufacture the product for us. They are the ones who actually gave us access to their R&D lab because we did not have any.

And that's the beauty of start-up ecosystem in India, right? The shared infrastructure that exists actually eases out building a business. Had it been 10 years back, you would not even be able to think about something like this because if you had to build a formulation, you have to have your own lab and then have your own manufacturing unit.

Otherwise, that shared ecosystem didn't exist.

[Speaker 3] (49:43 - 49:46)

And they'll be okay to do 5-10 pieces if I were to reach out?

[Speaker 2] (49:46 - 49:52)

So they gave us access to their labs. In labs, you can have handmade batches.

[Speaker 3] (49:52 - 49:53)

You can try.

[Speaker 2] (49:53 - 49:54)

This is not expensive?

[Speaker 3] (49:55 - 49:56)

Like access to a lab?

[Speaker 2] (49:56 - 50:11)

So nobody gives you access to their lab or their resources. The only reason why we were able to get that was because we went crazy. Like, he's still our largest manufacturing partner, by the way.

We went crazy following up.

[Speaker 3] (50:11 - 50:15)

But it's doable. As a 21-year-old, I can reach out today and get access to a lab.

[Speaker 2] (50:17 - 50:22)

Yes. I mean, you have to have a vision and you have to be able to show that vision to others.

[Speaker 1] (50:22 - 50:24)

You want to name your biggest manufacturing partner?

[Speaker 2] (50:24 - 50:48)

Yeah, yeah. So, Capco. Varun Kapoor and Benita.

Again, a set of parents who had kids similar age as us. They said that this is something that we had also been thinking about for the last couple of years. A lot of people have actually come to us, tried to figure this out, but nobody has been able to formulate or do something about it.

So, are you sure you want to put in time and effort? Because nobody has cracked it till now.

[Speaker 1] (50:48 - 51:14)

But can you imagine that now I'm getting the point where he's going, and since he started from your earlier journey. Do you think today you have manufacturers of these lab heads who are that welcoming to attend a call of a 20-year-old and says, Okay, son, come. Let's see what to do.

Or they have somebody give a meet this so-and-so person. Is there a welcoming system in this segment of labs and recipes?

[Speaker 2] (51:14 - 51:15)

Absolutely.

[Speaker 1] (51:15 - 51:16)

You think it's still there?

[Speaker 2] (51:16 - 51:22)

I mean, look at the number of startups that have come up in the beauty and personal care space in the last five years.

[Speaker 1] (51:23 - 51:25)

I would say there'll be more today than there were back then.

[Speaker 2] (51:25 - 51:29)

Absolutely. That's for sure. Because there'll be more labs.

There are labs.

[Speaker 1] (51:29 - 51:31)

The young one calling up, you know. I don't know.

[Speaker 3] (51:31 - 51:36)

Young people call me all the time. I engage with so many of them. I don't have a lab, but in other domains.

[Speaker 2] (51:36 - 52:21)

I think especially last three years, this has really changed because a lot of people have also experienced success and they also understand that if you like the idea, you should pursue it with the person. I have come to terms with that, right? First three years, I used to absolutely ignore whoever was writing such.

I mean, nobody used to write back then. Nobody used to write as well. But today, if young people and I'll tell you a small story.

A 14-year-old who comes to me and says, this is the Ayurveda brand that I want to create and sits with me for a couple of hours, brainstorms, understands how to build a business and is working on it as we speak.

[Speaker 1] (52:21 - 52:22)

Oh, this is a real story?

[Speaker 2] (52:22 - 52:23)

Yeah, yeah, yeah.

[Speaker 1] (52:23 - 52:24)

14-year-old?

[Speaker 2] (52:24 - 52:37)

14-year-old. 14-year-old. And I'm like super surprised at the kind of ideas that they have.

They are so sure that they will be able to figure it out. It is beautiful.

[Speaker 3] (52:38 - 52:45)

Okay, so you formulated it. You met the Capco guys, who are your friends. I'm sure some people

are going to hit them up after this.

[Speaker 2] (52:45 - 52:47)

A lot of people have already hit them up.

[Speaker 3] (52:49 - 52:52)

So you made a baby shampoo, which worked better?

[Speaker 2] (52:53 - 54:11)

We made four products. We made a baby lotion, we made a baby shampoo, we made a 100% natural mosquito repellent and we made a sunscreen. So these were the four products that we made.

We were very clear and each of them had a purpose. How much did it cost you to get to this point? Nothing.

This business, getting your prototypes, for example, what we were working towards was having five pieces of each, which we could show to people, let them experience it, sort of figure it out and give us feedback. We had to make five pieces. We made a handmade batch.

It's like working in your kitchen. It's like beakers and you're whipping it and you made handmade. It's not as fine as the commercial batch.

But you know, if the formula is okay, if the feel and texture is okay, the commercial batch will come out fine, right? Again, because we were digital first, we did not have the pressure of number of units that need to be created, right? Because we were not distributing it.

One warehouse, you can produce as low as 5,000 units per product. And how much does it cost to set up that warehouse? So it costed to set up the warehouse.

No, again, we didn't own the warehouse. Shared ecosystem. You use people who have, you know, amazons and all of those of the world who have that infrastructure.

And you sign up with them. No cost.

[Speaker 1] (54:12 - 54:13)

No fixed cost.

[Speaker 2] (54:14 - 54:26)

So it depends on the amount of space that you sign up for, as you're using, and then it starts from there. For the first six months of our business, we did not have an office. Varun took one seat up.

[Speaker 1] (54:26 - 54:29)

I think you can transfer the question. So she, this hot food.

[Speaker 2] (54:29 - 54:31)

He knows that I ate before I came.

[Speaker 3] (54:32 - 54:33)

What year was this?

[Speaker 2] (54:34 - 55:27)

We started, we launched Mama Earth in December of 2016. So 2015, end of 2015 and early 2016 is when we were figuring it out. July is when we incorporated the company.

We then worked with partners, finding the right kind of people who could actually make it for us. December, 5th December 2016 is when we launched it with Amazon Launchpad. What is Amazon Launchpad?

Amazon Launchpad, okay, so that was also the first year that Amazon had come up with this property called Launchpad, where they were helping startups or newer businesses get launched on their platform. It was separate from Amazon, so they were also trying to optimize, for example, this brand should come up in search or try to give them more visibility or get them, you know, visibility to the right kind of people within the ecosystem of Amazon, etc. So we launched with them.

[Speaker 1] (55:28 - 55:33)

You owe a lot of success to that pad that they created, according to you now?

[Speaker 2] (55:33 - 55:34)

That was a starting point.

[Speaker 1] (55:35 - 55:39)

So you made a few products, they worked. What happened next?

[Speaker 3] (55:39 - 55:41)

You had a warehouse, all of this costed next to nothing.

[Speaker 2] (55:41 - 56:09)

In between also, how do you know the product worked or not worked was also something that was really important and like completely changed the way we pitched the brand to our consumers or we talked about it. So we made those set of five products because we were living in Delhi. We found a really premium toy shop in South Delhi and we stood outside that toy shop because that guy did not let us in.

We wanted to do some consumer work to understand if people…

[Speaker 3] (56:09 - 56:10)

Wait, you went to a toy shop?

[Speaker 2] (56:10 - 56:10)

Yeah.

[Speaker 3] (56:11 - 56:15)

He didn't let you in? So you stood outside and did the survey? And anybody can do that?

[Speaker 2] (56:15 - 57:16)

Anybody can do that. It's basically a walkway outside the shops, right? Anybody can stand there.

So we stood there. We knew our relevant consumer set is going to come in. Parents are the only ones who will come to a toy shop or probably one who's trying to take a gift for kids but they will be exposed to that segment of kids.

We can't take feedback from kids so we had to pitch it to parents. So we stood there and wholly approached people who were walking in. Made them try our products for feedback.

Gave them candies in return. That was the only thing that we could afford back then. And started filling our survey form for us to be able to take feedback because when you're making natural products, back then we did not know that the performance can be at par with some of these other products.

Now we know far better but we also thought that performance might not be as good or the texture might not be as good. It's a handmade batch, etc. We wanted to take a lot of feedback on the way the product looked.

We had created labels.

[Speaker 1] (57:16 - 57:18)

So you were doing it with the packaging as well?

[Speaker 2] (57:18 - 57:29)

Yeah. And we had created the labels and everything at home between Varun and I. Came up with the brand name.

Those labels still continue. All our baby products are with the same label that we had designed back then.

[Speaker 3] (57:30 - 57:35)

And you got this far with no money? Very little money.

[Speaker 2] (57:35 - 58:33)

Yeah, so we had raised our friends and family around because we thought we would need a lot of money. We did need money. So for example, the entire first 30 days, it was just me and Varun.

When we launched ourselves on Amazon Launchpad and a few orders started coming in, we were the ones who were packing the orders ourselves as well for us to be able to dispatch it. I still remember December is when we got this order of 20 sets of four different products from Bombay. This mother wanted to give those products as return gifts on a birthday party.

And we were like super happy, very excited but so nervous. How will we make 20 products per month? We were working with five per product.

How would we make it? How would the production happen? Who will make it?

How will it reach them in time? Etc. But figured that piece out.

Worked on crunch timelines and everything. January...

[Speaker 1] (58:33 - 58:37)

The first time you get that check for the first transaction is the most special.

[Speaker 2] (58:37 - 58:44)

The first purchase, the first consumer, the first bulk order. We used to call it a bulk order. We rocked it.

[Speaker 1] (58:44 - 58:45)

It's the most special.

[Speaker 2] (58:45 - 58:53)

It is. It was really special. And that's when...

That's what gave us confidence that we feel we need somebody in the team for us to help.

[Speaker 1] (58:53 - 58:58)

I still have the first check framed at our office. The first check of bulk booking of 10 room nights.

[Speaker 3] (58:59 - 59:08)

So you pitched each vendor individually to get orders? Yeah. And how do you find out who the vendor should be for cosmetics or baby products?

[Speaker 2] (59:09 - 59:13)

No, back then I didn't have an option. There was only one guy who said, yes, okay, I'll work with you.

[Speaker 3] (59:13 - 59:14)

How did you find who to pitch to?

[Speaker 2] (59:14 - 59:24)

So, okay, the way you find manufacturing... There are so many personal care products available in the market. Every personal care product has the manufacturer's address written on it.

[Speaker 4] (59:24 - 59:24)

Right?

[Speaker 2] (59:25 - 59:26)

So you pick up like the top 10...

[Speaker 4] (59:26 - 59:27)

The exposed system of India.

[Speaker 2] (59:27 - 59:59)

Yeah. You pick up top 10, you reach out to them for them to give you some time for you to be able to go to them and pitch. Nobody gave us time.

These were the only people that we were able to get through. We had a conversation with them. We loved the fact that they were parents themselves and that gave us a lot of confidence that they will put in extra effort to figure this out with us, which they did.

So they came in as a blessing to us. Started working... All the products were being manufactured at the same place.

As a consumer, it's actually the most misunderstood thing.

[Speaker 4] (1:00:00 - 1:00:00)

Is it? Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:00:01 - 1:00:13)

One of the biggest pain points that I'm facing today is this perception that people have that if you're manufacturing... If you don't have your own manufacturing, the quality of the product can't be as good.

[Speaker 4] (1:00:13 - 1:00:14)

Oh, is it?

[Speaker 2] (1:00:14 - 1:00:14)

Because you don't have controls.

[Speaker 1] (1:00:14 - 1:00:16)

They subcontract everything.

[Speaker 2] (1:00:16 - 1:00:16)

Right?

[Speaker 1] (1:00:17 - 1:00:27)

So technically, they do. But it's not really. But isn't that the case with most large...

It's not manufactured by Mama Earth, right? It's sold and marketed by Mama Earth.

[Speaker 2] (1:00:27 - 1:00:27)

Yeah, yeah.

[Speaker 1] (1:00:27 - 1:00:31)

But isn't that true for most large CPG companies? They also... Who will explain it to the consumer?

[Speaker 2] (1:00:32 - 1:00:33)

See, what I think...

[Speaker 1] (1:00:34 - 1:00:35)

Consumers will say...

[Speaker 2] (1:00:35 - 1:01:25)

And this comes from history, right? For the longest period of time, for example, HUL, etc. All of these larger partners have had their own manufacturing.

For that matter, 10 years back, that was the only way to get into business. You can produce a product if you have a manufacturing unit. And that was the capex that was required to set it up.

To get started. I'm so glad that that entire process got disrupted. And with very minimal capital, you can now use this shared infrastructure and start a business of your own.

Otherwise, 90% of the ideas would have still stayed an idea because you didn't have the money. Now, from the consumer's side, because this comes to me a lot personally, that you don't have your own manufacturing. And hence, anyone can make your product.

What they don't understand is, manufacturing is different. R&D is different.

[Speaker 1] (1:01:25 - 1:01:26)

The IP is yours.

[Speaker 2] (1:01:26 - 1:01:29)

Developing personal care, there's no IP.

[Speaker 1] (1:01:29 - 1:01:29)

There's no IP.

[Speaker 2] (1:01:29 - 1:01:31)

Right? Because you're disclosing 100% of the ingredients.

[Speaker 1] (1:01:31 - 1:01:34)

You put all the ingredients with the percentages.

[Speaker 2] (1:01:34 - 1:02:57)

So not with the percentages, but you're disclosing the name. When R&D is yours, which is, and a product has so much to it, the sensorial, the texture, the efficacy, the feel, that just knowing the

ingredients, you might be able to come closer to the product, but you cannot crack exactly what the other person has cracked. Right?

Or you reverse engineer. That's also a possibility. But, a company can have her own R&D, her own expertise.

We have our team members sitting at manufacturers' plants, you know, for quality checks, to ensure that everything that we have set out as a process is being followed. And what we are using is the CAPEX that that person has invested into putting those machines and setting up that manufacturing unit. If I have to set it up today, it actually becomes a limitation for my business.

Because I'll be limited with the space that I have, the number of machines that I can put, and hence innovation, which for the longest period of time has been super slow in India. Formulations get developed outside of India, and then they are imported within India, and then they are adjusted for India, which dilutes the performance of the product. That is something which Mama Earth challenged.

That is something that we figured and we played on. And innovation is an edge now that everybody talks about, and all of the larger players have also started talking about.

[Speaker 3] (1:02:57 - 1:03:49)

Okay, coming back to it. So, as a 21-year-old, what I have learned today, if I'm able to look at a great Korean brand, I know the formulation, I can hit people up on LinkedIn who will make it for me, I can find a lab which will be willing to do 5 to 10 pieces to try. If I convince them enough, at a negligible cost, I don't really need to spend the money required to set up a manufacturing facility.

I can use a co-packer and it'll be just as good. Probably better, because if one guy is not doing good, I can make him compete with another and get a better product. Now, I've gotten to the point where I can manufacture.

How do I get distribution? How do I sell? What worked for Mama Earth there?

[Speaker 2] (1:03:50 - 1:05:01)

So, when we were doing the consumer study, standing outside that toy shop, we realized, we got a lot of feedback on how to communicate, what to communicate, what were they understanding, what were they not understanding. So, one of the examples, our pack said, sulphate-free. And this one mother came to us and said, sulphate-free?

What are you giving free? So, that was the understanding that the consumer had and we realized that just communicating this free, that ingredients, this is free of these harmful ingredients, is how we've got to put it. We can't say sulphate-free, paraben-free.

Communication got sorted from there. What we also realized was that for a new brand, purchasing directly from the website takes some time for them to have trust on the product or the brand. And hence, platforms which have, which these guys already trust, which were like Amazon, Flipkart, etc.

It's better to list yourself and be available there because the trust on the platform has an equity rub-off on your brand. That if this brand is available on the platform that I trust, yes, I would want to give it a try.

[Speaker 3] (1:05:01 - 1:05:21)

What works in terms of, like you said, not sulphate-free or paraben-free but different things? That was your hack. What could be a hack in the ecosystem today?

21-year-old starting a cosmetic company. What can I, what can I use as a means of selling my product which would be differentiation today?

[Speaker 2] (1:05:22 - 1:05:43)

It depends on different propositions. For example, Mamowat was one brand. We now have six brands.

And each brand has a very different communication and a very different proposition. Beauty and personal care in India is still evolving, right? And people now have global aspirations.

They know what's happening in a Korea. They know what's happening in a China and how the beauty system there is evolving.

[Speaker 3] (1:05:43 - 1:05:48)

Can I bring what's happening in Korea to India and replicate it well? And it's an opportunity right now?

[Speaker 2] (1:05:49 - 1:06:12)

You can bring what's happening in Korea to India. One way is you source the products from there and make it available in India at affordable prices and you'll have to figure out how to do it. But I'm guessing people are already doing that well.

Right? Yeah. But it ends up being expensive.

Second is you create your own brand on the proposition that's working there because you've checked enough that even Indian consumers really, very strongly relate with it. So I'll give you an example.

[Speaker 1] (1:06:13 - 1:06:14)

Can we match Korean quality here?

[Speaker 2] (1:06:15 - 1:06:19)

You can do better. Nice. I've done that with my third brand.

[Speaker 4] (1:06:19 - 1:06:20)

Good for you.

[Speaker 2] (1:06:20 - 1:06:48)

I have a brand called Aqualogica which is a brand based on deep hydration for your skin. Korea's skincare trend is deep hydration for your skin. They've been using multiple ingredients to figure those formulations out.

We said, what can we do for India? See, the problem is for the longest period of time in the beauty personal care industry no one had innovated for India. It was like Varun says it beautifully that the British came and brought thick creams with them.

The British left but the thick creams stayed.

[Speaker 1] (1:06:49 - 1:06:49)

Charmings.

[Speaker 2] (1:06:49 - 1:07:16)

Right? People haven't been able to come out of it and say that Indian skin is different, Indian weather is different and hence the product efficacy or the product texture, etc. needs to be different.

So Aqualogica is that brand which is based on basically this Korean trend around deep hydration for your skin. A best-selling product there is sunscreen. It has taken the market by storm.

It is the best-selling sunscreen?

[Speaker 3] (1:07:16 - 1:07:17)

Sunscreen which is with hydration.

[Speaker 2] (1:07:18 - 1:07:19)

Sunscreen with hydration, no white cast?

[Speaker 3] (1:07:19 - 1:07:33)

What if hydration doesn't? I know what a moisturiser is but how does it... I'm actually curious about a lot of what you're saying and hence I'm like what determines how much hydration you get from what cream?

[Speaker 2] (1:07:36 - 1:07:37)

So one, Amazon...

[Speaker 3] (1:07:37 - 1:07:49)

Like if I'm paying a bomb, if I'm paying one lakh rupees for a fancy cream, let's say La Mer or something and let's say I'm paying 200 rupees or 50 rupees for a cheap cream, let me not name them.

[Speaker 2] (1:07:49 - 1:07:49)

Yeah.

[Speaker 3] (1:07:50 - 1:07:51)

What is the difference?

[Speaker 2] (1:07:52 - 1:08:12)

So one, the way your skin feels after two to three hours of application or even after six to eight hours of application should one tell you the difference. Second, we have figured... Simple hack.

Amazon has this instrument called Moisture Meter. I think it's available anywhere between three to four hundred bucks.

[Speaker 1] (1:08:12 - 1:08:13)

That's it.

[Speaker 2] (1:08:13 - 1:08:30)

Right? Apply any cream. Test the moisture in your skin.

Compare whatever creams you want to compare and it'll tell you which cream is the most hydrating one. Over the years I've realized that nothing should be left to gut-based or subjective interpretation of things. If you put in data points...

[Speaker 3] (1:08:30 - 1:08:31)

And anyone can buy this on Amazon?

[Speaker 2] (1:08:31 - 1:08:32)

Yes. Yes.

[Speaker 1] (1:08:33 - 1:08:35)

But what's the meter we should look for that it is correct?

[Speaker 2] (1:08:35 - 1:08:53)

So it has two metrics. Moisture content and oil content. Oil content needs to be lesser.

Moisture content needs to be higher. The more moisturizing it is, the more moisture content, the more hydrating the product is. If the oil content also ends up being higher, you will feel stickiness on your skin and that's how you can judge.

[Speaker 3] (1:08:54 - 1:09:41)

I won't get into distribution too much because we did an episode with Kishore, Raj and Anant and we did distribution for two hours. How to sell on Amazon, how to be ranked higher in their algorithm, growth hack, stuff like that. But incredible story.

Some of the nuance... I don't know. Now will we resonate with it?

When you were 12-13 years old, the split in your family built some kind of insecurity in you that many of the other things, loyalty, financial freedom, early, slightly aggressive, slightly unforgiving, forget but don't really forgive.

[Speaker 2] (1:09:41 - 1:09:46)

Forgiving but doesn't forget. Forgive. I've forgiven a lot of people in my life.

[Speaker 3] (1:09:47 - 1:09:52)

Could you say that if you forgive and you don't forget, it's slightly unforgiving too?

[Speaker 2] (1:09:52 - 1:10:19)

No. When you forgive, you're putting yourself at ease. You're taking that burden or that pressure off you.

Otherwise, it keeps moving in your mind that you're still upset by certain things. So you've forgiven. It's no longer bothering you and it's no longer bothering the other person.

But would I trust that person again with the amount of trust that I had before? Would I trust that

person again? Probably yes.

[Speaker 3] (1:10:20 - 1:10:20)

Diminished trust.

[Speaker 2] (1:10:21 - 1:10:22)

With my fair share of doubts.

[Speaker 3] (1:10:23 - 1:10:26)

Yeah. Mom stepping up, big event.

[Speaker 2] (1:10:27 - 1:10:27)

Yes.

[Speaker 3] (1:10:27 - 1:10:57)

It's very evident how that has... Also when you said mom or dad favorite or who you would like to be like, you said mom. I think it has defined your personality to a certain extent.

When you got confident about how you look beyond the 12th grade. I think Ritesh came in between and added there, but being confident about anything. How you are confident about how you look is a big part of being confident about anything.

[Speaker 2] (1:10:57 - 1:10:57)

Yes.

[Speaker 3] (1:10:58 - 1:11:58)

And I think to any young entrepreneur, it makes a big difference. Also, creativity by virtue of being an artist. Big part of...

I'm drawing a gazelle. Word cloud. At the end of the day, I will compare word clouds because you are anomalies.

All three of you. One in 99 who have failed at building a successful startup. So I'll see what are the similarities and then we will try and figure out if this is the right answer to the question.

What makes a startup successful? Creativity, again, I think extremely important in a world where everything has become so mechanized. Differentiation comes from creativity.

And this is a little bit of a digression, but how good your partner is. Yes. How supportive the man or woman you choose to cohabitate with or marry or have children with.

[Speaker 2] (1:11:58 - 1:11:59)

Absolutely.

[Speaker 3] (1:11:59 - 1:12:00)

Is a game changer.

[Speaker 2] (1:12:00 - 1:12:01)

Absolutely.

[Speaker 3] (1:12:01 - 1:12:05)

Would you think this would have been your word cloud starting off? What is gazelle the entrepreneur?

[Speaker 2] (1:12:07 - 1:12:10)

Very interesting. I'm also hearing this for the first time.

[Speaker 4] (1:12:10 - 1:12:11)

It's your aatma tatha. Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:12:12 - 1:12:21)

I've never created a word cloud around me, but I would truly say these are the words that have... I can't add anything more to it.

[Speaker 3] (1:12:22 - 1:12:33)

These are the largest defining pillars of your professional success. And not the typical hardworking generic bullshit that everybody gives, right? Those are byproducts that everybody needs to have.

[Speaker 2] (1:12:34 - 1:12:57)

Yeah, like over the time, I also figured that everything is figureoutable is the word that I use. I mean, there's nothing that you can't figure. If you put in the right amount of effort, everything in the world is figureoutable.

It doesn't matter. Like you've learned it, you've done a course around it, you've picked this up or not. Just be curious enough.

And that works really well.

[Speaker 3] (1:12:57 - 1:13:13)

But thank you for being so vulnerable and honest about it. I think in this pursuit of being more public, we all become so rehearsed with time that we become boring. And I think people are able to gauge that today.

[Speaker 2] (1:13:14 - 1:13:14)

I'm sure.

[Speaker 3] (1:13:15 - 1:13:39)

Yeah. Yeah. Okay, moving on.

I think we'll come to Ritesh last because his story is most popular and has been told so many times. So Manish is this rare... Like, you know, we talk so much in the media about unicorns and all that, right?

I don't know what animal is rarer than unicorns. I would call him like, I don't know, a dinosaur.

[Speaker 1] (1:13:40 - 1:13:45)

Dinosaur. I was going to say dinosaur because that one is rarer. So you made my cloud already.

[Speaker 3] (1:13:45 - 1:13:46)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (1:13:47 - 1:13:48)

The one word is enough.

[Speaker 3] (1:13:49 - 1:14:27)

So I've seen rare rabbit. There's a store in the mall right next to my house in UB city. And I've seen it like here and there many times in the past.

So we were investing or we're in the process of investing in rare rabbit. And when we started researching the company a bit more, it just didn't make sense. It was stupidly incredible.

Like, an Indian homegrown Western cloth manufacturer, a company built in the era that we live in, making a profit after tax with no investors.

[Speaker 1] (1:14:28 - 1:14:32)

It's his house. So I'm hearing that. Fully bootstrapped.

He's uplifting it too much.

[Speaker 3] (1:14:33 - 1:14:39)

With no investors, no dilution, nobody. And our man has built it. When I...

[Speaker 1] (1:14:39 - 1:14:42)

First generation. You built it. Incredible.

[Speaker 3] (1:14:42 - 1:14:43)

How many years ago?

[Speaker 1] (1:14:43 - 1:14:46)

Seven years. Seven years ago. Just seven years ago.

[Speaker 3] (1:14:47 - 1:14:48)

So we started together.

[Speaker 1] (1:14:48 - 1:14:51)

Congratulations. We are also seven years. 16, 17.

[Speaker 3] (1:14:51 - 1:14:58)

And nowhere to be found in the media. No interviews. No like, if you like, our team was trying to do like a bio of him.

[Speaker 1] (1:14:58 - 1:15:01)

Yeah, someone asked me, do you have a bio? I said... He said he doesn't have a bio.

[Speaker 3] (1:15:02 - 1:15:03)

I made a bio at the time of our marriage.

[Speaker 1] (1:15:04 - 1:15:05)

I didn't make a bio after that.

[Speaker 3] (1:15:06 - 1:15:08)

So then they started looking up online.

[Speaker 2] (1:15:08 - 1:15:12)

You made a bio after that, but you didn't make it. You didn't put words to it.

[Speaker 1] (1:15:13 - 1:15:51)

I am from Bombay originally. Born and brought up in Bombay. Lived in a small place called Kalbadevi, which is a very hustle bustle textile market.

You can call it the Bada Bazaar of Kolkata or the Bazaars of Chandni Chowk and Chikpet of Bangalore. So grew up there. Had a lot of challenges.

Dad was a hardworking man. Separated from his brother when he was trying to make his big life. Dad separated from his brother?

Brothers. Similar story. Yeah.

Happy separation, sad? It's sad, separation.

[Speaker 2] (1:15:51 - 1:15:52)

Separation never happens.

[Speaker 1] (1:15:53 - 1:15:58)

We are brothers, how can it be happy? He moved on. Not that I could, I have no memory of how he did and all that.

[Speaker 4] (1:15:58 - 1:15:59)

It's serendipity.

[Speaker 1] (1:15:59 - 1:16:35)

You didn't pick it up like this. Okay. No, but I think in India, 95%, 98% is normal.

This is like, it's bound to happen. So we used to live there. Not had too much of access of great things from a colour TV or whatever.

Would go to neighbour's house to see movies. They would be on sofa, I would be on floor. But that was life.

And there are a couple of things that strung me that when I moved from that place to Cuff Parade, which is the, let's say, the skyscraper part of Bombay.

[Speaker 3] (1:16:35 - 1:16:38)

How old were you when your parents, your dad and brother separated?

[Speaker 1] (1:16:38 - 1:16:45)

I would be what? Three, four, five years old? Three, four.

I mean, not even in the conscious of mind.

[Speaker 2] (1:16:45 - 1:16:46)

Too young to understand.

[Speaker 1] (1:16:47 - 1:16:49)

No, we were in Bombay always.

[Speaker 3] (1:16:49 - 1:17:01)

Actually, that age, they say, between three to seven, eight. All psychology states that even though your memories might not be vivid, those are the most impactful.

[Speaker 1] (1:17:01 - 1:17:03)

Those are very formative. My memories go very far.

[Speaker 2] (1:17:03 - 1:17:06)

Those are the years when kids grasp the most as well.

[Speaker 1] (1:17:06 - 1:17:07)

Some things I remember for some reason.

[Speaker 2] (1:17:07 - 1:17:11)

But I'm not sure this kind of stuff, would they be able to understand?

[Speaker 1] (1:17:11 - 1:18:06)

Yeah, absolutely. You would not understand what happened, but now you can relate to it. You can understand the noises.

You can understand that you're packing a bag and leaving and just going somewhere. But yeah, it happens in everyone's life. But I think we are sitting also here because today, from whatever success we've got, the message is also to those 20-year-olds that you may be in that same hustle-bustle, madness, wrongs and rights of life, but there's always an outcome.

There's always a shine-out. That's why you can hear us or believe us or it can happen to any of you. So moved, it was tough.

Small things were difficult. I always had the eye for design, color especially. I can pick color very fast.

Some eyes are trained for that. My God gift is that. And I used to love shoes like these in those days and it was not accessible.

[Speaker 3] (1:18:07 - 1:18:09)

We'll put a picture of Ritesh's shoe on his way out.

[Speaker 1] (1:18:10 - 1:18:11)

On this podcast, you should.

[Speaker 3] (1:18:11 - 1:18:12)

They're really cool.

[Speaker 1] (1:18:12 - 1:19:10)

He's shying my red ones as well. My red ones are shying actually. So for me, it was a lot of everything was less available and I had to do a lot too much in advance.

I mean, everything in life, I've done it. I think almost six, seven years earlier, five, six, seven years earlier, from lighting a first cigarette to stealing children money from home, stealing a car from the house, doing anything in life. And then one fine day when you're growing, you just say, the other big influencer of my life is movies.

Indian and Western movies. I think people may realize or not realize. Maybe some part you would realize that in movies, some lady has also affected some personality there as well.

Because India is somewhat we are enveloped and surrounded with this culture of movie around us.

[Speaker 2] (1:19:10 - 1:19:11)

Actually, I do.

[Speaker 1] (1:19:11 - 1:19:19)

And if you're now busy, that's a different thing. But it has a very big impact other than parents, movie and the role play. It has always.

[Speaker 3] (1:19:19 - 1:19:26)

I think the way diamonds and cigarettes got sold by Hollywood is testament to how soft power is

in the movies.

[Speaker 1] (1:19:26 - 1:19:27)

Absolutely.

[Speaker 3] (1:19:27 - 1:19:28)

But let's hear it from your childhood.

[Speaker 1] (1:19:29 - 1:21:20)

My childhood, of course, been unlike your parents. My mother was very hard on me. I was quite brutally handled because I also never gave better reasons in life to her for doing everything in life.

And so I was talking about movies because with movies, for me, there was nothing beyond Mithun Chakraborty and Amitabh Bachchan. There was nothing. There was one guy who could move, dance, and look glamour and gold.

And this is this man who's got all this charisma of looking how dashing he was. And the first time when the jacket came with a... So we are talking about bomber jackets now when Amitabh Bachchan got his first jacket to put his hands inside, we were like, how do you put a hand here?

You know, that's a big thing. There's a pocket here. And that was a big thing to have to ourselves that you could wear something that can have a pocket here.

So from dad's business, would pick up some fabrics here and there and from his office, steal some tons of kapda and go to the tailor, get it stitched, sit there and aise kaato, aise kaato. And while this was happening, education was nowhere. Just trying to kind of scrape through by 70% copying in exams and finding a way through, just do this duty.

And finally, when 12th came, I was done with the struggle of copying. There's a lot of... Usme bhi bahut mahinat hai.

Planning karna hai, shades manana hai, kidhar kya hai, uski mapping karna hai. I said, chhode hai aaye sab. So I just took a car back and I said, mom, I don't want to study.

And I had this nag of becoming a businessman. So in school, people would carry bags, you know. And I would carry a VIP suitcase of my dad.

[Speaker 4] (1:21:21 - 1:21:21)

To school?

[Speaker 1] (1:21:21 - 1:21:41)

Yeah, to school and open my books from that and people would laugh at me. Because I just wanted to feel businessman, you know. Businessman leke suitcase office.

To mujhe, I think fifth standard, I carried the first time a VIP suitcase. Basically, businessman would carry cash in a suitcase. So that equivalent was you carrying books.

Yeah, and I wanted to carry... That was my bag.

[Speaker 4] (1:21:41 - 1:21:42)

Also files.

[Speaker 1] (1:21:42 - 1:21:45)

Yeah, I did it for five, six years. I mean, the class...

[Speaker 2] (1:21:45 - 1:21:47)

You're going in the cash direction.

[Speaker 1] (1:21:47 - 1:21:48)

And...

[Speaker 2] (1:21:48 - 1:21:49)

Maine toh kabhi nahi dekha cash.

[Speaker 1] (1:21:49 - 1:22:35)

Maine toh dhume nahi dekha. But I... Maine toh cash bahut dekha hai.

So, dad used to be... Tell us a bit more about your dad. My dad, he's a great businessman, a great hustler.

He's... There's one story I want to tell you from where it starts, actually. My dad, when he split from his brother, and it was over a simple issue that his brother wanted...

My uncle wanted to make 50 paise a meter. Kapda ek rupe ga hota tha. He used to be in textile business.

Haan, textile business. And he was the monopolist. My uncle was a monopolist of few NTC mills of Bombay.

For certain... So, NTC mills would have... What is NTC?

National Textile Corporation. Because everything was nationalized. There was some...

[Speaker 3] (1:22:35 - 1:22:36)

What era are you talking about?

[Speaker 1] (1:22:36 - 1:23:46)

We're talking about 80s. 70s and 80s. Till 90s also, there were mills.

NTC mills was... So, he was a supplier to NTCs? No, he was a buyer of the mills, the fabrics.

And they used to make 10-20 qualities. Each quality used to be hand-held by certain cartel of businessmen. So, my dad would have certain sorts.

And my dad was very... He was a very quick rotator in business. And unlike his brother, who was 15 years older to him, who would want to make more money, but he would say, you're making 25 paise, you know.

Sell the 1 rupee product for 1.25 rupees. So, on that tussle, he says, no, you don't know business. And he knows business better and things like that.

They split. But he still went there to take that 20,000 meters to the mill end. And at that time, he entered that office.

So, he was not an English speaking guy. He would actually go and... He didn't know what's excuse me or how to enter.

He was just a straight man. So, he would enter the chairman's office where he would have two guards and no one can get out of. So, Mr. Sen, when he would leave the textile mill...

[Speaker 3] (1:23:46 - 1:23:47)

Who is Mr. Sen?

[Speaker 1] (1:23:47 - 1:24:12)

Mr. Shushil Sen is also one of the reason... One of the key man who made even Kishore Biyani's life. And he also was instrumental in making my dad's life from very, very early days.

What did he do? He was the director and chairman of all the mills in Bombay by the government in the 80s. So, when he would leave his house, 42 mills, air conditions used to go on.

That Saab ka Idhar bhi aa sakta hai. Very powerful man.

[Speaker 3] (1:24:12 - 1:24:17)

Mr. Sen left us. And textile was the predominant large business of the 80s?

[Speaker 1] (1:24:17 - 1:24:21)

India, yarn, textile, and that's it.

[Speaker 3] (1:24:21 - 1:24:23)

Reliance also started like that.

[Speaker 1] (1:24:23 - 1:25:50)

Yeah, Reliance, Bombay dyeing. Bombay dyeing. All.

You name it and everyone. Bombay wealth creation effectively started. Pyramids are also from textile.

So, Mr. Shushil Sen was like entering his chamber and he wanted to crash in. Who wanted to? My father.

Because he said, yeh sauda mereko chahiye. And he was fighting outside with the managers that mujhe ek rupe mein de do. I want this deal on my name.

And which was not happening because they said, this is your brother's and why have you come? He heard all this nonsense. He said, come inside.

I said, my brother doesn't know how to deal. I want to take this. And he says, and how will you pay?

He says, that I don't know. And when will you pay? He says, after I sell and I recover.

And I said, aur company kitna purana hai tumhara? Bolo abhi banaya nahi hai. So, I said.

And he was like, are you serious? This is almost like I was seen as Trushul differently. And he just saw it in him.

And that's how you get that. In those days, trust and eye contact and those things had a very different value than these 30 pages contracts today. So, he was just like, theek hai.

Lekin contract mein likh lenge kuch toh naam bolo. Bolo Radhakishan Murailar likh do. That's my father and my name.

So, and I'll just formulate the company and come back. And he did that and he never stopped. He was called the textile mafia.

When I joined, I was 17 years old.

[Speaker 4] (1:25:50 - 1:25:51)

Who was called the textile mafia?

[Speaker 1] (1:25:51 - 1:27:55)

My dad. Because he would really break in. He was very, he's a big hustler.

He was a big hustler in textile. He could break. There are many things he knew that his objectives are very clear.

That my objective is first, the rest is last. So, he would like literally know that kapda toh saaf aayega nahi. Acha banega nahi.

Aur mujhe x quantity bhejna hi hai. Bechna hi hai. Toh wo 4000 banao.

Ya 4 jake banao. Kyuki mujhe agar thoda-thoda bhi sub-jege samjhe jaaye, my contract is closed. My income is very important.

So, when I joined the business, everyone, he also became very popular with, even the Pyramid House, the biggest trader. Foreign trips given to him and things like that. The 80s.

This was late 80s. Late 80s, he and my uncle thought, my other uncle actually, they were still together, that let's start exporting fabrics to Bangladesh. Aaj kal exporter banna bahut zaruri hai.

You know, that dollar income. 25 rupee ka dollar tha or 26 ka. Bag liya, chale gaye.

Pehli baar dollar dekha hai. Pahunch gaye. Riksha se 25 kilometer paddle riksha se hotel tak gaye.

Finally, riksha stand ke upar aise hi upar ek naam dekh liye Mohammadi group. Bhush gaye. What group?

Mohammadi group. Why Mohammadi? Bangladesh is all Muslims, right?

So, everybody, their names are. But one of the companies in Dhaka. Yeah, companies in Dhaka.

They just saw that group and they said, let's get into entry here. Bas kuch sample-ample dikha hai and they took the first order. So, they, so as a family, we just go, we are a family we kind of respect and really bow down to those people who have actually given us that first lift in life.

So, Sushil Sen hai, phir Aneesahab, who would have become the leader of the country today or a very important leader of the country. He left, I mean, he passed away almost a decade back, maybe plus minus. So, that man, it never stopped.

[Speaker 3] (1:27:55 - 1:27:56)

He passed away a decade ago.

[Speaker 1] (1:27:56 - 1:29:26)

We became the founder of Mohammadi group. Mr. Aneesul Haq. Bangladeshi person.

He's my mentor. Because in 96, when we had another split between my father and another brother, that's when I had to pack a bag and I had to go out for business at the age of 18, 18, 19 years old. And…

Where did you go to school in Bombay? Which school? I went to GD Somani and followed by Jai Hind College, which I didn't pursue.

And study what? Commerce. Maharwadis have no other option.

And as soon as I heard art, I felt like… I did home science though in school. Cross stitching, cooking.

I was the only guy in the girl segment. So, when the other split happened, I had to take over the business of dad's and I'd already started working at the age of 16, 17 with dad in the mills. All the mills, I would design textile, create my own color boards and I was the first one to actually create mood boards, which today in your business would be themes or the whole campaign board around and things like that.

I used to make those in those… People would carry bags of swatches and hangers and I would carry boards. Unreal for even factories and self for Bangladesh.

Not to even… How old were you at this time? 17, 18.

And not to…

[Speaker 3] (1:29:26 - 1:29:33)

When was the first paycheck you got on your own? Like a Marwadi family, did you get paid by your family for a bit and then?

[Speaker 1] (1:29:34 - 1:30:08)

So, there's a very different and I hope the generation, especially, I don't know, wherever it's relevant. Nowadays, kids think, you know, that dad has put me to education and one day I will pay back my dad for whatever he spent on my education. And I tell my kids, I say, don't make it too cheap and shallow here.

You start from the birth, from the cereal that you ate, add even compounding but baiyaj of Marwadis, all the holidays and if you can also firstly, calculate all that. So, don't take this short four-year payout.

[Speaker 4] (1:30:09 - 1:30:11)

I thought that was a good thing.

[Speaker 1] (1:30:11 - 1:31:05)

I said, I initially thought that you meant to say that don't be so shallow. You don't need to do it. And then you reversed it and said, Baba, that starts all the way.

No, I said, no, you do all this because what's this fad? Because I have boys, right? And all of them are young and my friends have kids.

They all have this one paycheck to their parent in the end. Like, you know, one exit clause. That brother, if we give so much to the father, if he spends 4 crores, then I will give that and leave.

I mean, I have a debt. You have returned the root. Yes, I mean, what did I do?

I said, look, I have employed people. I have created a system, an ecosystem. You are born in this family not to give me my 4 CR back.

And what do I do with that money? You owe much more. No, and what do I do?

And then did you study just for that? You try to commit me that you'll add more value. You'll do this.

You'll do that. I want to dream this. I want to go.

That's what you're supposed to do. Eventually, would you want…

[Speaker 3] (1:31:05 - 1:31:09)

This is not just a loan. Would they work at Red Rabbit eventually?

[Speaker 1] (1:31:10 - 1:31:23)

I don't know this. So, I work, I think very differently. My wife and I think very differently.

They have their own life. They can do what they want. There is no ready seat at all.

They'll never get that readily.

[Speaker 4] (1:31:23 - 1:31:24)

Why not?

[Speaker 1] (1:31:24 - 1:31:48)

Because it's a business which has its own dynamics. It has its own plus, minus. 2 plus 2 is never 4.

It's sometimes 5. Sometimes it's minus 4. Whatever reason.

Because nothing works. And you have to learn the snake, ladder game, you know. You go up to 99 and suddenly like that last snake brings you down.

And you don't come up straight to 100 because your father made you do the dial roll. Can I ask you a question?

[Speaker 3] (1:31:49 - 1:32:05)

Nurture versus nature. Who is… Are kids predisposed to do well at a certain business?

Is there such a thing as talent? Inherent talent in people? Or is it upbringing, evolution, experience which defines who does well?

[Speaker 1] (1:32:05 - 1:32:46)

I think a small part of… But it's a very small part according to me that they have it in them for whatever DNA reason is just to be that you can have your somewhat a bit values of the family, right? That's it.

Rest, I think kids only see and become and behave only from whatever they see around their home. Dad's working hard. He's coming late.

He's not… He's still got a smile on him and all of that. So that upbringing…

The upbringing is not the upbringing, you know holidays and take them out do some trampoline jumping and…

[Speaker 3] (1:32:46 - 1:32:49)

Was that the case with your father? He worked hard, came home with a smile or no?

[Speaker 1] (1:32:49 - 1:33:14)

I never got to see my dad for the longest time. He would come and I would be sleeping and Sunday was the only time and I would watch with him back to back four or five black and white movies. For me, when I was in textile I used to…

I was very fortunate then at the age of 98 I was barely 20, 21 and Dalmia Ji of Century Mills which is owned by Mr. BK Birla.

[Speaker 3] (1:33:14 - 1:33:16)

What happened between 18 to 21?

[Speaker 1] (1:33:17 - 1:33:20)

That's where I am. I got a chance to…

[Speaker 3] (1:33:20 - 1:33:29)

So at 18, you split your brother your father and the other uncle who had not split, split. You left and started what?

[Speaker 1] (1:33:29 - 1:34:05)

No, no. It was my dad who split with my uncle and I helped him that and that's why I was an arbitrator actually at that time. I was doing the…

My dad didn't want to… He didn't understand what was going on and what's with the books and all of that and I had to dig in a lot. So learned a lot actually from that.

I have no regrets with that and I'm super, super close to my family yet again. And so when we split I had to start all over again. Took up Bangladesh export business and what came my way because I got a little popular with the textile mills of Murarji Mills of Piramals.

[Speaker 3] (1:34:06 - 1:34:06)

Why?

[Speaker 1] (1:34:06 - 1:34:49)

Because I used to be forever in their 60 degree furnace areas and inspecting fabrics and boiler rooms and no lunch. I got hospitalized for acidic attack. No water intake.

That's my biggest habit. Wrong habit even today. Water is missing in my body.

When you talk about hydrants water itself has been… Contrasting. It's been…

It's the only bad habit I have. I can't sip water even now. I don't feel the urge of it.

But anyways moving from there got popularized somehow Dalmehji and Mr. Panwarji in those days…

[Speaker 3] (1:34:49 - 1:34:50)

Was this with your dad or outside?

[Speaker 1] (1:34:50 - 1:36:06)

With my dad. Yeah, that's why I said why got my kids along because when you said is it your money and you separated or what is it? I said dad had got this amount of three and a half, four crores.

Big money back then. Yeah, 99. I would not say big.

I think it was good money. It's not the bigs of today is like how you would imagine big is what. And but yeah so on and so forth.

So if you put that money in that frame then you realize that you're already one only left. And then we finally said okay let me do this. Mr. Dalmia of Century Mills Denim they put a plant in Satrati, Indore and they saw that they put the big large mill and they didn't know how to make more than 69 qualities there. And I could weave and construct and so many other textures and weaves and I could take it to almost 450, 465 sort numbers. They were sort numbers created like that. They were each quality batches and I would take about 30, 25, 35% of the production to Bangladesh and sell it at a margin.

[Speaker 3] (1:36:08 - 1:36:10)

Is that how Bangladesh's textile industry started?

[Speaker 1] (1:36:11 - 1:36:13)

So Bangladesh is a very it's a jute country.

[Speaker 3] (1:36:14 - 1:36:19)

And so why did they have need or demand for the textile you were taking from India?

[Speaker 1] (1:36:19 - 1:36:40)

So in 1986 there is which is called the father of the nation Mr. Noorul Qadar. He actually took 16 men at his expense. It's a very poor country.

It was and back then though it was terrible. Now it's booming. That those numbers are per capita income of Bangladesh is probably the highest in South Asia.

[Speaker 3] (1:36:40 - 1:36:42)

At least in textiles they've killed it.

[Speaker 1] (1:36:42 - 1:37:16)

Yeah, but Biggest employer in Bangladesh? The largest. Largest in the world.

And as a country and I think 56 or 60% almost they GDP, the economy is on garments. To export

manufactured garments. They employ the largest human force in manufacturing in one industry alone.

So this gentleman Noorul Qadar and back in those days took 16 men and took them to Korea on his expense to understand how to do line manufacturing system. Not do one piece.

[Speaker 3] (1:37:17 - 1:37:18)

He was the Prime Minister of?

[Speaker 1] (1:37:18 - 1:39:00)

No, he was just a businessman. But a very renowned person. Those 16 people from Korea when they trained and came back it's like how the Toyota car manufacturing is.

Parts come from all sides and you're just assembling it. So that's the mechanism of production which he adapted to on his expense. He put up a large factory and in 89 the entire factory was underwater of 3-4.

So everyone had to leave. He just took a promissory note in those days that you all will stick to garments. So those 16 people became 5,900 factories plus minus today.

In Dhaka and I think Dhaka itself is the highest. Then it is Chittagong. It's huge.

I mean they do the best of garment manufacturing globally today. So I did very good business out of Bangladesh of textile export. Continuing whatever dad started in 88 and From the age of 18 to?

To almost 23-24. I got married at 24 and I was also doing South African textile export business. And that's when I realized that's a smaller country.

I could ask or convince the brands like Camel, the cigarettes brand. They had a manufacturing there. Billabong and all of them.

That if I could manufacture garments and send it. So took the initial orders of 6-800 pieces back in those days. And was doing well.

So what happened in 2005 Sorry. Yeah, 2004-05. I just was in Europe and I realized this brand called Zara.

And I was looking at the store.

[Speaker 3] (1:39:00 - 1:39:03)

How old were you then? 24-25.

[Speaker 1] (1:39:03 - 1:40:29)

And I said, looks good. Looked at some shirts. And I said, it's possible I can make it.

And everything was seen made in Spain. Made in Spain. So I thought it must be a brand from Spain.

Came home. Opened Apple. I mean, the desktop.

Googled Inditex. And made a phone call. And I want to speak to the shirt buyer.

And he said, yes. So there's one thing which that's why I asked you about manufacturers. Are they welcoming here to just say yes?

So we have this policy which is there in my life. In my company. Which I got it from Inditex.

So Inditex cannot refuse an appointment. You can call right now. I'll give you the number.

You can just call up and I said, I'm Nikhil Kamath. And I'm a manufacturer of t-shirts. I make sleepwear.

Even today they can't refuse? No, it's monitored. It's a very simple logic.

You're sitting here in a village. It's a village, La Colonia. Northwest of Spain.

Nobody goes there. The flights operate for that company. From Madrid and Barcelona.

And because Mr. Ortega doesn't leave. And he's a fine man. Lives in a small house still.

Doesn't move from that house. 1,600 square feet house. Since then, it's the same house.

Married there. So you're telling me if I'm 21, boy.

[Speaker 3] (1:40:30 - 1:40:36)

Making t-shirts. And I want to sell to Zara. If I call Inditex today, they have to give me an appointment?

[Speaker 1] (1:40:36 - 1:41:34)

They will tell you, yes, you can come in. Now it may take you four more calls. But the operator system there is that they don't ask who you are.

You just ask for a sleepwear buyer. You just push the call. And everybody in their office has their office phone in their pocket.

It's a desk phone. But it's in their pocket clip. And you can't leave it.

You have to have it with you. By chance you've left it, you're announced on The Voice in the entire office, which is almost 2 million square feet of office. And it's a very, very slow decibel sounder.

Mr. Perbarak, call for you, extension. All he has to do is go to the next phone anywhere on the world and pick it up. While he's talking to me in a meeting room.

And they have 200 meeting rooms. Each table is as big as this. And 600 square feet each room.

200 meeting rooms. And you have Korea, China. But tell me, what are the odds?

[Speaker 3] (1:41:34 - 1:41:37)

If I... Like I'm making a t-shirt. This is my t-shirt.

[Speaker 1] (1:41:38 - 1:42:50)

I call Zara and say, will you buy my t-shirt? What are the odds of them buying it? So if I look at this particular t-shirt, because you've written the word Bangalore boy, and if the designer there or the chief designer there or someone just catches an eye and a story behind it, that I'm taking a city, which they'll not take a city.

No, sorry, they will take it. They'll not take scripts of different language because it could mean an abused area and all that. So if they can build city, Tokyo, New York, Bangalore, if they create a table of t-shirts, if that's the theme they would have, they would place an order to you back in those days.

Even now? Now they will just maximum tell you that we like your product. Everything is good.

Can we keep it? Or please can you contact our Delhi office for compliance? Just to check that you're fine.

In those days, I worked for 12 years exclusively for them. I designed collections for them. I was the only men's manufacturer for them, for Zara Man.

When you say you were the only men's manufacturer, you're talking about all of them. And designing. So I used to sell my own design.

I'm not a factory who would manufacture given designs, which most of the exporters do in India.

[Speaker 3] (1:42:51 - 1:42:54)

Zara gives them a design and says, make this for us.

[Speaker 1] (1:42:54 - 1:42:54)

Yeah, that's it.

[Speaker 3] (1:42:54 - 1:42:56)

You would design and take it to Zara and say?

[Speaker 1] (1:42:56 - 1:43:45)

So a collection, sell the collection and get my hit ratio there. So of course, coming back, it's still about that marvel, no? And I always did business for only profit.

I never understood business, which had no margin. It's similar to what your dad said, that if you don't have P&L, you won't get anything at home. And I don't know how the gestation period, the Aamna, the valuation, how it's done.

I don't know because I only knew 2 plus 2 has to be 4 or 2 plus 2 make me my 6 because I need that balance too. So I didn't know any other formula. And that similar thing happened with Red Rabbit as well, when my dad came once to see the collection and he said, this boy is getting frustrated doing exports.

So in that whole process of my life… At 25, you went to Zara. 12 years, you made t-shirts for Zara.

[Speaker 3] (1:43:45 - 1:43:46)

You were 37 by then?

[Speaker 4] (1:43:47 - 1:43:47)

Yeah.

[Speaker 3] (1:43:48 - 1:43:49)

And then what happened?

[Speaker 1] (1:43:49 - 1:45:43)

And became the largest for their kidswear, started buying… What is the scale of this? How much money did you make from Zara at that point?

I'll tell you about my first money then, what you're talking about. My first money was Bangladesh, which was… On calculation, it was about 25 lakhs.

And I placed the order in… I got an order from Bangladesh. You're talking about one order?

One order. And when I took that order, I had to go to Salem to place it. And I stayed back in

Salem because I found that I could not…

I should not buy from traders in Bombay. And when I went to Salem, I could find it at least 15-10 rupees cheaper because he was keeping that margin. So, I stayed back there and I opened an office there and I didn't come back to Bombay.

And a lot of mosquitoes. So, I would sleep with a wet towel on me because the building that I bought… Now, rent has started.

So, I thought, how will I spend money in the hotel? Let's sleep here. But it was a bad choice today, if you ask me.

Because I didn't know what sound I was sleeping with mosquitoes of what size and it was bad. And so, my first real income was 25 lakhs. And to that same customer, within three months, I paid 50 lakhs as claim.

Because that quality which was shipped from there was not of good standard. And I was crying from the hotel there. And I called up dad.

The only thing he explained to me was that, you went to school, right? I said, yes, I went. My dad never knew which class I am in all his life.

And I said, yes, I went. He said, do you pay fees in school? I said, yes.

So, this is the fee for business. Fill the claim. Then only you will learn.

Dad will not teach you. You have taken the order, you have placed it and you have opened the office and you don't even want to see it. Eyes are closed.

You go and stay there. So, you are seeing that the light is not good here. I am sure, there will be frustration.

You must have sent four messages. That WhatsApp team...

[Speaker 2] (1:45:43 - 1:45:43)

Very difficult.

[Speaker 1] (1:45:44 - 1:46:14)

It's impossible. An entrepreneur who has created this product, he doesn't have to be satisfied. I go to my office and they have this internal...

Messages with pictures. Yeah, yeah. WhatsApp's journey is the same.

So, in fact, talking about messages with pictures. So, I had to learn styling. I was not a designer.

Officially. I stole 5000 rupees from my mother's cupboard. I applied to some lady in Worli Seafest who could get me brochures of colleges to go abroad.

I had to go abroad. I mean, no one asked.

[Speaker 3] (1:46:15 - 1:46:17)

Digressing. Did you steal money from your mother's cupboard?

[Speaker 1] (1:46:18 - 1:46:22)

Yes. Agarwal. Ritesh, Agarwal.

You were a very good child.

[Speaker 3] (1:46:24 - 1:46:25)

I'm talking like 50 rupees.

[Speaker 1] (1:46:26 - 1:46:28)

I was 3 years old when I first stole 25 paisa.

[Speaker 2] (1:46:29 - 1:46:29)

Kazir?

[Speaker 4] (1:46:30 - 1:46:31)

I have. I have.

[Speaker 1] (1:46:31 - 1:46:41)

But my mother used to beat me up. If I had a low number, she used to beat me up. We don't have that many numbers.

I was so scared of my mother that if I saw her from a distance, I would salute her.

[Speaker 3] (1:46:41 - 1:46:43)

We'll come into that. Why we three have and you haven't.

[Speaker 1] (1:46:44 - 1:47:00)

It's an interesting question. How are the grooms of milk? No, how are the grooms of milk?

How is your sari whiter than our sari? We should talk about that. Fair enough.

So... After that? This 10...

Where was I?

[Speaker 3] (1:47:00 - 1:47:03)

25 lakhs Bangladesh, 50 lakhs claim.

[Speaker 1] (1:47:03 - 1:49:45)

Dad's school fee. And they never looked. I never did that mistake again.

And made sure everything was right. My biggest support and to anyone is I think at least now I have a lot of friends of my age and everyone. And we all miss that fact that one support, it's okay.

It's fine. Just to say that, to confirm that it's fine. Otherwise, who else do we go to and ask it's fine?

If we ask a banker, he won't say it's fine. In today's maturity. And if we look left and right, with friends, we don't get time to joke.

When to ask, who to ask. Someone has to assure that I'm going the right way. And I'm very...

The way I walked up to you, I do that and ask. If I find that I can get some answer from him, I'll take him in the corner and ask him that. What would you call that?

That trait in you? Upfront. No ego?

No ego, absolutely no. My lower back is very flexible. Good way.

Better way to put it. Because I asked somebody, what does it mean He's saying, you don't have your ego. It's not giving you anything from the ground.

And neither is it touching you from above. You are showing that you are ready to bend. Your ego is low.

Yeah. So, that's textile for me. And garments was...

Did so well that I didn't even know how to cost garment. So, if you're in Zara and I had... So, my first collection I did is I took some fabrics from Hind Mata.

There was a ladies shop behind the theatre. All these chicken fabrics. In Bombay?

Bombay. Just picked up anything. Filled a car.

Went to Dharavi. Did some block printing on it. For Zara.

Made some shirts. No, I just first made it. Then I called them up.

And I went and showed them. They were like, stunned, I said. It's a temple.

It's a mad place. You know. They have a very simple philosophy in the company.

Someone's coming from China. It takes him 24 hours to come here. Someone from India takes 18 hours, 16 hours to come here.

Because there's no direct flight to Spanair. So, everybody's ready to come here and show them this fuchsia with that work on it, right? You designers cannot dream that.

Okay, we've got the paparazzi to release whatever is shot in Milan and all of that. Because now the phones are your freedom of switch. Earlier they had to be like, those kind of thing.

And those are paid guys who get the images out. And, so they cannot refuse somebody.

[Speaker 2] (1:49:46 - 1:49:47)

And why do you think is that?

[Speaker 1] (1:49:47 - 1:50:07)

Because he's coming, he's taking the trouble to come and show you a bag of 4,500 garments. I'll relate it to you. If someone is coming from Korea to show you design of bottles, every week, five times, five new guys are coming and showing you bottles of designs.

Why would you even dream of saying no? Why would you even create a wall?

[Speaker 4] (1:50:07 - 1:50:09)

But it's a great culture.

[Speaker 1] (1:50:09 - 1:50:14)

Why would you create a wall in your office saying, that you guys are busy and there's no one busy.

[Speaker 2] (1:50:14 - 1:50:16)

Exactly my point. He's designing a bottle. That's the bias.

[Speaker 1] (1:50:16 - 1:51:46)

He's coming to you with a design. Then why? What else is to learn from Inditex?

One learning you mentioned is, no meetings can be refused. So, I take unregistered numbers. I

take it because I just think someday a vendor is calling me.

And they said, Manish, I got your number from somewhere. I said, I'll send you a number. You must come.

Their logic is very simple. This has got a skewed tailored pocket. It's done by hand.

This can't be stitched. The designer has to find this. And he has to listen that the Japanese guy is saying something.

And he has to take it back. And you do what you want to do behind. So, my shirts would go like, they have a 100,000 square feet showroom in the office.

Blank white. Like a clinic. Like a lab.

And they're building the collection for the next season, which is nine months later. So, they've come and they say, Okay, we are thinking the city name, boys, and graphics. Someone has thought.

We've built a board. And luckily, he comes with this t-shirt. And I go with this t-shirt.

I go down to the, it's a closed private area. Oh, it fits well. Come back.

And while they're walking up, only they'll react. Russia? Okay.

Europe? Fine. US?

Done. 40,000 pieces, one color. Done.

No PO? You pack your bag, you leave. You start production.

Well, while you sit in the car, you've already started taking the yarn, booking, closing.

[Speaker 2] (1:51:46 - 1:51:47)

I'm loving this.

[Speaker 1] (1:51:48 - 1:51:49)

And they're very fast.

[Speaker 2] (1:51:49 - 1:51:54)

And that's why probably they are the most innovative. And they're able to turn things around and bring the best.

[Speaker 1] (1:51:54 - 1:52:56)

Their speed is simple. That we are not creating bombs. There's no mistake here.

That red wire got connected to the yellow, so it'll explode. Whereas you talk about the American businesses of brands and everything, their SOPs and their methodology, their books, their Bible, they give you to read. Zara never inspected my factory for 12 years.

They never even visited where I am. And when they give you an order... And I asked them once, what if you don't get your shipment on time?

So, that's your loss. You lost business on Inditex. So, trust is also another very key part of their...

You lost Inditex. And your blue didn't come now. We've already bought three times more because we already know some shipment gets cancelled, some flood happens, some political crisis, ship has not come over on time.

And we have a wall to create of all these pieces on your wall that you see has to come at one time in the store. And when they give you an order for 40,000 pieces, do they pay upfront? Nothing.

Nothing. They don't pay. 90 days.

So, the credit line in our business is 90 days.

[Speaker 3] (1:52:57 - 1:52:58)

So, if you fail, it's on you.

[Speaker 1] (1:52:58 - 1:53:59)

But you can discount it from the Swiss bank, which is their credit line at 1% per annum. I only worked with Europe all my life. And from 2004, I had a beautiful chance, 2005 actually, to start two brands in Italy.

Miss 60 for men. And because these Spanish designers go here and there, so they try to explain them that he's the vendor, he can come and do it. I created 60 men.

I created Gazzarini. Everyone knows Miss 60, the Italian brand for women. Very successful.

Why Miss 60? So, diesel was coming up and which was with Renzo. And Replay was always there.

Like, Replay is like Tata of fashion. It's there. It doesn't move.

It doesn't try to be oversmart. It stays classic. It has the truest jeans.

The best jeans in the world. Till today. The classic Italian jeans.

[Speaker 3] (1:53:59 - 1:54:04)

And was this the first time you got like real financial independence? 25 to 37 with Zara?

[Speaker 1] (1:54:04 - 1:54:12)

Good money? My independence of finance is much earlier. Zara and Italian business.

[Speaker 2] (1:54:13 - 1:54:16)

For me, the 2 to 4 crores was also very serious money.

[Speaker 1] (1:54:17 - 1:54:24)

So, with Zara, it was like I would walk off. And I love calculating my profit at least 10 times. I have to do that.

[Speaker 3] (1:54:24 - 1:54:29)

How much would you make per year during the Zara era? When you were 25 till you were 37?

[Speaker 1] (1:54:30 - 1:54:36)

15. 10-15 crores a year? 10-15 crores a year?

Yeah, that's serious money.

[Speaker 3] (1:54:38 - 1:54:39)

And we're talking 20 years in.

[Speaker 4] (1:54:40 - 1:54:40)

And that's serious money even today.

[Speaker 1] (1:54:40 - 1:55:38)

You account for inflation. It's probably... But now...

Probably a few million dollars a year. It was always a 30-35% business for me to take home. And it came by mistakes.

I don't know how to cost this garment. I've just come from textile to apparel. Consumption.

What is it? I don't know. What is it?

I don't know. So, with the calculator, I'm just doing something. And I would just say $13.

But a garment costs $4. $5. And they would bargain and say $12.

So, at that time, I would know that it's too much. That trend got set and it was Euro. Their currency had just come in.

They moved up for 5-7 years to dollars. That's when you started losing a bit. Then global competition.

Primark coming in. When Primark came to Spain, they all became tough. Because they own Pull&Bear, Bershka, Lefties, Primark.

Zara, Oysho. Zara Home. And they're told about 9 brands.

Starivarius.

[Speaker 3] (1:55:39 - 1:55:47)

What's your learning from this time that someone who is 21 today can use? Looking to start a fashion brand.

[Speaker 1] (1:55:47 - 1:56:16)

I think this… If you want to start a fashion brand, ever. First, the pinnacle, of course, is creativity.

You have to have a nag. You cannot say that, if I'm successful, go and make a fashion brand tomorrow. Most of the guys are trying to do it.

Nag for? You have to have creativity. You have to…

You have to look fashionable before even thinking about it. What is creativity? You both said this.

How do I define creativity? Give me a wall and ask someone to…

[Speaker 2] (1:56:16 - 1:56:18)

For example, when he's saying…

[Speaker 1] (1:56:18 - 1:56:32)

I'll rearrange your furniture right now in a different manner. It'll be creative. So what is that?

It's about actually giving the presence of mind to that subject. Someone like you will say, why am I doing this? Why was he given that task?

My mind is somewhere else. I'm a number guy.

[Speaker 3] (1:56:32 - 1:56:39)

Is it your ability to move away from conformity that you're saying is creativity? I would leave the furniture this way because…

[Speaker 1] (1:56:39 - 1:56:40)

Yes, because conformity is…

[Speaker 2] (1:56:43 - 1:56:51)

I would define it as the ability of letting things evolve in your mind.

[Speaker 3] (1:56:51 - 1:56:52)

Differently from convention?

[Speaker 2] (1:56:52 - 1:57:04)

Different from convention. Something that's evolving in your mind, you're able to envision it and then possibly create something out of it. At least, paintings, even the products that I create, that's…

[Speaker 1] (1:57:04 - 1:57:46)

But in the mind, people like him… Maybe, I'm sorry. I'm just judging you over and over again.

Because I just feel that you're the math side of the man. So, in the brain, you have a creative side and you have a multiplier side. Sometimes, you leave multiplying because you love the creative side.

So, that's what I do in my business from then to now. My office is white because I paint it three times a year. It will keep moving.

A man will keep moving around in the office. The staircase has to be completely white. Because I have to see colours and people have to understand colours in my office.

And people have to believe in colours in my office. So, you can't have any other colour as such. So, it has to be white.

High maintenance, but yes. I've also learned from my dad. He would paint the house every year.

So, it would come from him.

[Speaker 2] (1:57:47 - 1:58:19)

But tell me something. For example, do you have to look at colours to get a design out of it? Or can you visualise them and just by thinking, create something out of it and then put it to practice?

Both. So, that's creativity, right? How do you bring a certain emotion to life that makes the other person who's experiencing it get some nostalgic feeling, right?

Something that they have experienced in the past and they're able to remember that. I think I would define creativity like that.

[Speaker 3] (1:58:21 - 1:58:31)

No, creativity is such a... It's such a common word, but a hard word to define. Okay, 37.

Inditex Journey finishes. Why does it finish?

[Speaker 1] (1:58:31 - 1:59:32)

The entire Europe experience for me kind of dies at 36, 37, 38. It was like a... Because the margins are going down, the European crisis, currency, dollars.

They want to trade in dollars though they're in Europe. They want to hedge and make money out of that transition. France was doing very good for me.

Denmark. I was the very large vendor for Jack and Jones. That was a very...

Same time, I was... I just went to Copenhagen and I saw another brand on the wall again. Jack and Jones.

So with Jack and Jones, also same thing. Yellow Pages Diary. Found Jack and Jones.

Called them up from Copenhagen. Went to Billund. It's another village.

30 acres of land. Two single, single floor huts made which are all brand offices. The LC opens here.

The shipping department is in that hut. Outstanding design. Man made from India.

Slept on Calcutta streets. Found a Chinese wallet which said Jack and Jones. So he labeled his brand.

[Speaker 4] (1:59:33 - 1:59:33)

Wait, who?

[Speaker 1] (1:59:33 - 2:00:38)

Mr. Truce Paulson. He's the richest Danish man. The guy who created Jack and Jones?

Jack and Jones. From Calcutta? Because he's Danish.

But he would come to Calcutta, make garments and carry them in a suitcase to Denmark and sell. Really? Yeah.

And that's his story. We have a fairly large Danish business. It's incredible the connections between India and Denmark, Sweden.

And he's the richest Danish man. And of course, he owns... He has 4,000, 2,000...

Wouldn't the founders of Lego be the... No. ...wealthiest people there? No. It's him. In apparels.

And he started like that? He started like that. Young days.

Coming in Calcutta. Making garments. East India Company's era.

Making garments. Going. Selling.

He was selling it without a label. He would fly down and keep doing this. And finally, someone told him, at least put a label on it.

I said, what should I write? So there was a Chinese wallet. It had Jack and Jones written on it.

He would sleep in the factories in Calcutta. He was very emotionally attached to the... Why was Jack and Jones in the Chinese wallet?

China...

[Speaker 3] (2:00:40 - 2:00:42)

Chinese have a big fair-skinned...

[Speaker 4] (2:00:43 - 2:00:44)

Yeah.

[Speaker 3] (2:00:44 - 2:00:52)

...fatuation. Really? You're an actor. Who comes and sits in meetings.

Because you're white, you get paid to come there.

[Speaker 1] (2:00:52 - 2:00:54)

So you're not a board member. You don't speak. Nothing.

[Speaker 3] (2:00:54 - 2:00:56)

Just to make the meetings look good.

[Speaker 1] (2:00:58 - 2:00:58)

Interesting.

[Speaker 3] (2:00:59 - 2:01:01)

Like, being white is a job in China.

[Speaker 1] (2:01:03 - 2:02:01)

Being white is a job. Our time will also come. So...

That's how it... So he... He was a great man.

And in that time, he wanted to take the Indian tram... He wanted to inherit it. He runs a lot of schools in Rajasthan.

He's the largest founder of the largest fund for Tsunami. In Tamil Nadu. Still, he operates that.

So... Did a great, great business. Again, they have a department called Express.

The missing part of the buyers which they didn't buy. And the season is running. So who can give you 45 days delivery?

So our lead time in our business is generally... 100 to 140 days. From order placing to shipment on the vessel.

And we... I learned the nag of things from Inditex kind of a process. That you can ship anything within even 45 days.

[Speaker 2] (2:02:02 - 2:02:03)

And how do you do that?

[Speaker 1] (2:02:04 - 2:02:46)

Firstly, don't interact too much with the buyers. Is it okay? Is it not okay?

So when I first took their order... And I took an order of a shirt with that embroidery. And they said, we bought it.

30,000 pieces. I'm supposed to send them this for approval. The button for approval.

The quality for approval. The thread approval. And they called me up.

I said, you think we have people here to sit and approve all these things? We liked your shirt. We gave that shirt back to you.

You just have to make 30,000 shirts. I said, but these are the processes. They said, I don't know.

We have nobody to even file this. What all you've sent to us. And every other brand in the world will sit and do that filing job.

Tests here. Tests with that chemical. Tests with this.

I said, it's a garment here.

[Speaker 2] (2:02:46 - 2:02:50)

But do you think that would have interfered with the quality of products that they were delivering?

[Speaker 1] (2:02:50 - 2:03:18)

Because it's a... Okay, I was a... I was a luck by charm kind of a situation that I had a small factory in Bangalore.

I moved from Bangalore... I moved to Bangalore because of the factory that I put up here. There was another thing in between.

I took the largest loan of our family of 37 crores. And put up a factory in Bangalore. First land to buy.

Would you be the first garment manufacturer... ...having a factory in Bangalore? No, no, no.

The K. Mohans and Shahis of the world.

[Speaker 2] (2:03:19 - 2:03:23)

But you invested money in buying the land to set up your own factory.

[Speaker 1] (2:03:23 - 2:04:16)

I put everything here. Went file to file. Vidhan Sodha.

Vikas Sodha. What year? K.I.D.V. 2004 and 5. How important do you think this is? Ability to leverage. Risk taking ability.

Very important. For an entrepreneur. Absolutely.

I mean, let me put it in a better way. That I have a set of family and mentality. It's a way of thinking.

Risk taking. And there are always an outlier. I am an outlier.

And I said, I want to take a loan. And I didn't badly sell it to my dad. But I just gave him a very

different equation.

That when you get depreciation in the end, you're getting it back in tax. I thought that depreciation is coming from God. That our money is coming back.

That is that part I didn't understand. I didn't correlate it then. And I kept putting this.

[Speaker 3] (2:04:16 - 2:04:19)

Can you explain it for the audience? The concept of depreciation.

[Speaker 1] (2:04:19 - 2:05:13)

When you start a business. Like that one or this one? Both.

Both. Oh, that one was very simple. I was putting 100 bucks.

And I thought that someone explain to me. You have a profit in your company. You are earning 10-15 crores.

You have to give this much interest. And my loan was 8.5%. Minus 5% for tough scheme. Textile.

Apprehension scheme. Which was resultant at 4%. Subsidy.

After subsidy. So you will get this. And then in the end when your profit will come.

10 rupees. You will get 100 depreciation. 12%.

This much for building. This much for this. This much for that.

This got minus. In the end you paid this much tax. So the way I looked at that was.

Like you know. Some God gift check is coming here in the middle. For depreciation.

And dad didn't. This was too much for him too. He just trusted me blindly.

I said.

[Speaker 3] (2:05:16 - 2:05:19)

And how much money did you have when you borrowed 37 crores?

[Speaker 1] (2:05:20 - 2:05:25)

I had. So my part was.

[Speaker 3] (2:05:25 - 2:05:29)

Net money in your. Net money to your name in this world. Oh.

[Speaker 1] (2:05:30 - 2:06:04)

Just one apartment. Of 3 crores which also I borrowed from my dad. That one I literally told him I want to borrow this.

After marriage I want to move out to an apartment at Verley's Seaface. And I said I'll pay you this back in 3 years. But I did it in 1 year.

And that was when I was 25. First year. 2 years after marriage.

And. And after 5 years of that. I went and put this factory.

And. So maybe 5-10 crores? What?

You had to your name? 10. 10ish.

I feel like this is the biggest.

[Speaker 3] (2:06:05 - 2:06:14)

Whenever I talk to people who are very successful like you guys. Often it comes down to risk taking ability. Who is willing to put it all on the line?

[Speaker 1] (2:06:14 - 2:07:00)

Otherwise it doesn't happen. Okay. We were at 37 crore loan when you had 10 crores to your name.

I was. I was devastated and screwed at that time of this loan. I thought I could make a cheaper factory.

Buying my own steel. Getting it converted. Making a PB structure.

That factory design was designed by me. Because I was stranded in Hamburg airport. And I loved that airport.

So I said this is what I want to make. This is not how a factory is made. But I landed up making an airport there.

So it's a 200 feet. Ceiling. And 6.

Curve hangers. With carts moving inside. Everything automated.

Put the works there. Someone should make a movie on your life.

[Speaker 4] (2:07:01 - 2:07:01)

I know.

[Speaker 1] (2:07:02 - 2:07:12)

I made all the sweet machines which came from Italy. I said they make it in blue colour. And I was set back with blue.

So.

[Speaker 2] (2:07:12 - 2:07:13)

So you changed the colour.

[Speaker 1] (2:07:13 - 2:07:22)

So I said it should be all Ferrari red. So you are from Italy. So you have to do that.

Otherwise I don't pay you. Otherwise there are technical problems.

[Speaker 2] (2:07:22 - 2:07:23)

I want to go see your factory.

[Speaker 1] (2:07:24 - 2:08:59)

What is this that you created? So they made red machines. And we did that.

The entire building is a submission of design. What Replay factory is. Because I manufacture for Replay as well.

And it's basically a coal factory. All brick building. It still has the tracks for moving the trolleys in metal.

The wartime. And the reception going to the office and things like that. So I said I want a brick building.

And that's when I saw the builder Van Gogh. Total Environment Mr. Kamal Sagar. Who's no less in creativity.

Uses only Indian materials to build his homes for customers. That was the part. Yeah.

So I saw his project there. Took a picture. Got caught by security.

Because I said I have to make this. And I have to make this guy understand. So do the whole thing.

The factory. The way I expected it. At the same time I built my house here.

And then suddenly the water was stopped. Dad said to hell with you. If nothing is moving after this.

What's happening here? So that 3 years was a stress. Crying.

Weeping. Early morning 6 o'clock in the factory. Getting it up.

Building it myself. Because I didn't want to waste money on contractors. I would have saved maybe 3-5 months earlier.

Which today I don't. Today I just finish it fast. Let my turnover start.

So that factory created a huge impression in Bangalore.

[Speaker 3] (2:08:59 - 2:09:04)

This is coming so often in your story. No ego. Shameless.

Relentless.

[Speaker 1] (2:09:04 - 2:09:29)

Is a superpower. I came to your house also like that. I said it might be big.

I don't know for whom. I mean even about you guys. I had to just quickly see.

Have some shame. Who will you sit with? At least read a little.

So I said okay. We'll do that. And then comes a way.

I went into say almost a one and a half year. Two years down. One and a half year of depression kind of a thing.

[Speaker 4] (2:09:29 - 2:09:29)

Why?

[Speaker 1] (2:09:30 - 2:09:46)

Going to give my designs there. 16 years. Living almost 8 years.

6-8 months in Europe. Hotels. Beds.

Flights. I almost landed up being at 19-22 flights a month. So I just gave up all that.

Milan.

[Speaker 3] (2:09:46 - 2:09:49)

Sounding quite nice to me. Going to Milan, Madrid. Being on flights.

[Speaker 1] (2:09:51 - 2:09:56)

It is not exciting at all. Not at all. I mean come on.

I don't think you would have seen any of this.

[Speaker 2] (2:09:56 - 2:09:57)

I find it very exciting.

[Speaker 1] (2:09:57 - 2:10:05)

So to save money. Earlier days I used to sleep in the railway station. The heater lamp like this.

Put my bag for $2 in the...

[Speaker 3] (2:10:05 - 2:10:07)

But you were making 10-15 crores a year.

[Speaker 1] (2:10:07 - 2:10:17)

No, when I started. It was 1920. So I used to go to the club.

Smoking was my problem. Not the drinking part. And then straight train.

Next country. To save money for the hotel.

[Speaker 2] (2:10:19 - 2:10:28)

I have a question. When you were setting this factory up. And that seems to be like a very important project that you picked up.

Right? All through your journey.

[Speaker 1] (2:10:28 - 2:10:32)

2005. So yeah. It was a brilliant project of my life.

[Speaker 2] (2:10:32 - 2:10:37)

So was it because you wanted your own manufacturing? Or was it that the...

[Speaker 1] (2:10:37 - 2:11:37)

No. So I had a small factory. I wanted it large.

So there are ancillaries. Like in your manufacturing. I had...

Everybody has a garment manufacturing factory. I said I do garment dyeing. I have to send it outside.

I want garment dyeing inside. I do printing like this. I send this panel outside.

I want to print inside. I do embroidery outside. I want to do this inside.

So I put all these ancillaries inside the factory. A very large black temple. What does stylish mean?

Like if you were to say... If you can coordinate your attire. Is it the colours that go with each other?

Is it the fabric? I'll give you a simple thing. If I was in black today.

And if I had any small piece of black cloth. With these dandelions on them. I would probably have it inside here.

Showing a bit here. So I've styled myself today. I've kind of embraced...

Basically you pay more time and attention. My mother is a stylist. Leftover food or whatever ingredients.

If a boy comes in at 12 at night. She'll style something and cook something out of it. Whatever is available.

[Speaker 2] (2:11:37 - 2:11:42)

So basically how do you put stuff together? Is style.

[Speaker 1] (2:11:42 - 2:11:44)

Yes. So in fashion is...

[Speaker 2] (2:11:44 - 2:11:45)

Wearing clothes as well.

[Speaker 1] (2:11:45 - 2:11:49)

Fashion is today. Okay, straight jeans. Torn jeans.

Broad leg jeans. Fine. It's today.

[Speaker 4] (2:11:49 - 2:11:50)

It's not tomorrow.

[Speaker 1] (2:11:51 - 2:12:02)

But there are guys who wear those same broad leg jeans. They've never left it since 80s. But they'll also go to the skinny.

Today they'll also wear a bell. Because their style quotient says today. I want to be like this.

[Speaker 3] (2:12:02 - 2:12:40)

Okay, let's go to 37 to Rare Rabbit. I'll tell you the appetite for Rare Rabbit in the market right now. I was at an event.

I actually even didn't tell you this. I was at an event with some investors. One sovereign fund.

Southeast Asian country. Their India CEO or something like that was there. He comes up to me and he says.

Why don't you reduce your allocation to Rare Rabbit? So we can do more. I obviously said, you know.

You take care of me a lot. For me to reciprocate. But there is that much.

So that you invest in him. There's that much happening.

[Speaker 1] (2:12:40 - 2:12:41)

So that you invest in him.

[Speaker 3] (2:12:41 - 2:12:42)

So that he can invest more in you.

[Speaker 1] (2:12:43 - 2:14:43)

I didn't want to even raise that much. I didn't want to raise at all. That comes as a different thing.

But for the guys who are 20. And when you're getting depressed. Out of not getting charm of designing.

Going there. And they're trying to take the same garments out of Cambodia. And then China.

And Bangladesh. And you're getting just defeated. How much you're not going to catch the collars.

And I was not getting the juice. And I always had that. There has to be juice in the game.

I can't be that startup blood. I'm not. I am Kharagpur.

I'm not all these. That breed of. Or that.

Or the breed of mine is very different. And my backgrounds came differently to me. And their backgrounds came differently to me.

But that gestation period. My heart will beat even more. I'm waiting for 3 years, 6 years.

That one day the light will be on. When will it be on? Where is the switch?

How can you take so long to find a switch? You know. So they cannot.

Someone who doesn't. Cannot make 2 plus 2. Make money.

I think. It's. For me I don't know how to swallow that.

And one day I was standing at Forum Mall. And I was like. I've created brands.

And why men don't look good here? Style wise. And what are these brands doing?

Actually when I was. Then also to come out of this European business. I told all these European guys.

Please give me your Indian office business. I'll change everything for you. I don't want to travel and all of that.

I did all of that. I created good lines for all the fashion brands here. And I was expensive for them.

They could not afford me. Or things like that. And I said.

Forget it. Let's create a brand. And here I come after 2 years of depression.

Almost that. I'm not happy with my working. And nothing.

I was quite suddenly out of the picture. And I said. I want to create a brand.

And what should it be? And I said. I came up with Rare Rabbit.

And only because. Rabbit is a sexual mammal. It multiplies the fastest in the world.

And.

[Speaker 3] (2:14:44 - 2:14:46)

Did you like the sexual connotation?

[Speaker 1] (2:14:46 - 2:15:23)

The sexual part as well as the multiplication. Because I multiplied thrice for my own legacy. But men in India should be rare.

And respect their sexuality. And be rare in that. You are a rabbit.

But be rare. And the least you can do is to dress. So that you can address your opposite.

That's the whole funda behind it. Ritesh is like. I'm doing it already bro.

And you had Mr. Vedanta once saying that. Of Vedanta's team. Mr. Agarwal. To address. You have to dress. It was in his Forbes magazine.

He actually dresses well.

[Speaker 2] (2:15:23 - 2:15:26)

Do you think styling in India. Can be a big business opportunity?

[Speaker 1] (2:15:29 - 2:16:25)

I'm doing that. It is. That's why it's probably.

So we curate. Men's fashion. In a very different.

We do it for India. The way you said that. Hydration cannot come from Korean recipe.

Because I know it's very cold there. And they need less absorbency. And we dry faster.

The equatorial belt. Similarly our tummy is two inches higher. And than any average person.

So our last button is. To be relaxing on that. It's horizontal.

Not vertical. And when I started the brand. I just put in a line.

And I went. I created that line. I invested money in that.

Nothing. One and a half crore. 25,000 pieces.

Just made it. Colour blocked it. Because if you go to our store.

You'll see colour blocking in our scene. If he's. What he.

I'm only navy always. Mostly. So I will not go to a particular section of my store.

[Speaker 3] (2:16:25 - 2:16:26)

Have I styled myself well?

[Speaker 1] (2:16:27 - 2:16:28)

Yeah. You can say that.

[Speaker 2] (2:16:29 - 2:16:30)

He's just being kind.

[Speaker 1] (2:16:31 - 2:16:44)

If you want tips. Then I can. Like for example.

And I would like to say. Because you said not to be kind to him. For me grey and navy don't go together.

What goes best? Navy, navy.

[Speaker 2] (2:16:45 - 2:16:46)

Navy, navy goes best.

[Speaker 1] (2:16:46 - 2:16:46)

You saw it with such a bad eye.

[Speaker 2] (2:16:48 - 2:16:51)

So monotone. Does monotone mean luxury?

[Speaker 1] (2:16:53 - 2:16:56)

Monotone is only luxury. We call it high and low. So.

[Speaker 2] (2:16:58 - 2:16:59)

Monotone is luxury.

[Speaker 1] (2:16:59 - 2:17:43)

High and low is not the right way of dressing. I'm glad you didn't ask about me. The beige and the black.

And the light grey and the black or something. So no high lows. It has to be mono.

We were in the inception story of Were Rabbit. Styling. I said this is a lot of loss.

Because I've seen all the fashion houses of India. And all they do is. All I thought that.

We create a structure of buying. We create clothes. And we have an actor.

Or a face to the brand. And we try to sell garments. And it's been done repeatedly in the country.

And neither I have the money. Or I'm going to. Or the nag actually.

After maybe the factory investment. That I can go and get a celebrity face. And then.

[Speaker 3] (2:17:43 - 2:17:46)

Do you think that works? For someone young. Starting a brand.

Paying an influencer.

[Speaker 1] (2:17:47 - 2:17:48)

Actor. Never.

[Speaker 3] (2:17:48 - 2:17:48)

No?

[Speaker 1] (2:17:49 - 2:17:54)

Why is that? For me. You'll think differently.

Because it's a women category.

[Speaker 2] (2:17:54 - 2:17:55)

On influencer I think differently.

[Speaker 1] (2:17:55 - 2:17:58)

Influencers are different. Even influencer in fashion.

[Speaker 2] (2:17:58 - 2:17:59)

I would think differently.

[Speaker 1] (2:17:59 - 2:18:44)

Yeah. My office believes in it. I don't.

Why? For me it's short lived. The way I engage myself on Instagram.

I'm also a consumer. I'm too fast. And I need new, new, new, new, new.

So. So it's. I don't know how much does it resonate.

To convert and understand the brand. I follow among all the actors. Maybe Mr. Bangaj Dibati. And Amitabh Bachchan. For two different. One is legacy in my life.

And one is the new. I think the new man of substance. Who speaks great.

So. Bangaj Dibati.

[Speaker 3] (2:18:44 - 2:18:46)

Some people on social media tell me I look like him.

[Speaker 1] (2:18:48 - 2:18:52)

If you act. But he has exceptional depth. But yeah.

I think you could pull off very well in Mirzapur.

[Speaker 3] (2:18:53 - 2:18:53)

I can.

[Speaker 1] (2:18:53 - 2:18:56)

I can. I take it as a compliment. He will.

100 percent. He was good in Mirzapur.

[Speaker 3] (2:18:57 - 2:18:58)

Someone should cast him well. No.

[Speaker 1] (2:18:58 - 2:19:09)

But director can move things. And they need a first cut. And that UP style look.

It can pull it very well. You can. Then you'll change a lot.

[Speaker 4] (2:19:09 - 2:19:10)

Have you tried? I'll try this too.

[Speaker 1] (2:19:11 - 2:21:47)

So what worked for Airabid? There's a thousand people trying. Rigidity.

It's very important. Explain rigidity. Rigidity for me is that.

We are the only brand. Which has no logo on the chest. Because I never wore a brand on my chest.

All my life. Whatever wealth I would have earned in my life. I never wore a brand.

Which someone can recognize what I'm wearing. And that's what probably Italians taught me. Or that's what Spanish fashion taught me.

They are never on the face. I had a choice of doing jeans wear or formal wear. This is the only two fashion concept existing in India.

There's nothing called smart wear. And which exists in Europe. It doesn't exist in the rest of the world.

There is no. So there's jeans. There's business.

They call formal in India. And there's a smart. The smart dressing doesn't exist in India.

And I said I can't do formal. Because I have to compete with such legacies here. And I can't do jeans.

Because it caters to youth. Youth that I've been. How I stole a cigarette.

And asked for it. And went on a bike. All that.

I don't have that much money that I can burn. And to my equation of mind. Because I knew how that two and two works.

Is that if I don't have a multiplier. If I don't get that GP. I'm not going to sustain to sell.

What is GP? Gross Margin. Gross Profit.

And to do that GP. Everything around it has to be perfect. So my store has to be designed.

The way I imagine the Europeans see it. And there's another underlying message. For all designers.

Or creative people. Who want to do anything in India. Is that do it from what you have seen.

Or perceived from the west. Because you're trying to create a culture here. You're not creating.

If you're making a Jutti of Chandigarh. Or you're making a Chanya Choli of Rajasthan. Then bring that culture here.

Then make your store look at Jharokha. Make a balcony. Make a sandstone.

Whatever you want to do. Because that essence comes formally as a juice. But if you're trying to say the word western world.

Then you have to be resonating it to a storytelling. Communication of design. Holistic approach.

And the difference that you're trying to first create. Like oversized t-shirts are selling very well today. What you're wearing.

The boxy fits. But it's already a clutter now. Now if someone has to come with this.

He has to be very adaptive. That I'll make the same boxy. But I'm going to come with city names today.

Tomorrow can I use the word just Bachchans. Because it's not registered. The Khan.

Something like that. How does one find that gap?

[Speaker 3] (2:21:49 - 2:21:50)

Like what you're saying. How do I find?

[Speaker 1] (2:21:50 - 2:22:18)

It's intuition. It's your. It comes out of desperate mistakes.

Most of the business I think are created by your own realization. That I miss it in my life. I think most of them.

In product at least. Unless I don't know what the backgrounds of the FMCG companies. Otherwise I've been.

Commercial ones. But the new ones. Anything I would say.

It comes from that. This is what my style was. It became a brand.

The blue orange became a brand. I respect them.

[Speaker 4] (2:22:18 - 2:22:18)

J-Walking.

[Speaker 1] (2:22:18 - 2:22:34)

J-Walking. Because that's the cult. That's the way.

The design. I think these guys would have probably been somewhere in the world. Or got hold of that one piece.

And they said that's my style. That style became so popular among the friends. It's looking good.

I want it too. Where will I get it?

[Speaker 3] (2:22:34 - 2:22:41)

Do you think because the clothing market is so penetrated today. In terms of access. You have to hit a niche and play that?

[Speaker 1] (2:22:42 - 2:24:48)

So rightly said in your lines only. We are a clothing manufacturing country. We're not a fashion business country.

We don't create fashion. We don't buy, design, sell fashion. Other than the designers that we are doing.

I think the best in the world also. They're world ranking. We have Dior making their entire marriage gowns in Bombay.

That's also embroidered in India. I mean I have seen back in those days. Armani sending the suits LaFell.

Just the silk from Italy to Lucknow. To do one embroidery of chicken work. And goes flying back there to stitch it with the suit there.

So that's how. And they go that mile. And they.

In those days when there's no Instagram and all of that. They were doing it from an archive book. And the designer there is as eager bird.

Who's taking the trouble to go to the Instagram. Which is the library then. Picking up something and trying to throw that knowledge in the Armani's office.

That I want to do this. It's available in India. It's in Lucknow.

And they said okay talk to Global Office Hong Kong. They'll connect you to a buying office in Delhi. We'll send it to them.

They'll get this embroidery done. He must have got his house painted in it. He must have sent 100 pieces.

The whole house will be painted exterior and interior. It's an order from Armani for an embroidery. What was the breakthrough point for Rare Rabbit?

I would say the breaking point to answer is that. When we were stuck on our business. So the biggest challenge we faced.

Is getting real estate. No one picks up the phone in India. No one even understands the new bird.

That's why I was asking her again and again. In your industry do they. Pick up that call.

And I proposed this once. When I didn't have one store also. With one of the largest builders and developers.

And you'll have such millions of square feet. You have 3,000 square feet in a corner of a mall. For young guys to come and demonstrate their talent.

Without signing those LOI big big pages. Just give them so much table. One hanger.

[Speaker 3] (2:24:48 - 2:24:53)

Is that how malls work? Do they care which brand is coming so much? Or is it about the rate plus square feet?

[Speaker 1] (2:24:53 - 2:25:06)

I'm trying to sign or get. No, they have to create an ecosystem. They cannot have five rows of chocolate.

And ice cream and coffee shops. It's an ecosystem which I've learned. And it's a very hard business.

They are also cracking. So how do.

[Speaker 3] (2:25:06 - 2:25:07)

If I've started.

[Speaker 1] (2:25:07 - 2:25:30)

They trusted Rare Rabbit. They give a store. And imagine nobody comes in there.

So I kind of bring down their. Footfall. And if they do 20 mistakes on a floor.

That floor is dead. The 21st store will not get rented. Because that person is not getting footfalls.

No, the 21st one will say. What are you doing sir? Nobody is roaming on our floor.

There are some malls. Who do man-woman mix. They're not dissecting properly.

[Speaker 3] (2:25:31 - 2:25:34)

So if I'm a brand. What can I do to be more attractive to a mall?

[Speaker 1] (2:25:36 - 2:25:43)

Like I'm 21. I start a brand. I want store space.

Impossible. Is there no hack for it? I would not say the word impossible.

Just forget it.

[Speaker 3] (2:25:44 - 2:25:47)

Maybe in tier one mall. Can't I go to a tier two mall?

[Speaker 1] (2:25:47 - 2:25:47)

Forget it.

[Speaker 3] (2:25:48 - 2:25:55)

Really? Not at all. So you're telling me.

If a mall has empty store space. And I'm willing to pay the rent. They won't give me?

[Speaker 1] (2:25:56 - 2:26:03)

They won't. Yeah. See.

And they're not wrong. Who are you? You're a kid who started with a garment.

[Speaker 3] (2:26:03 - 2:26:04)

I'm someone paying them the rent.

[Speaker 1] (2:26:04 - 2:26:40)

Yeah, but. Your store will open. I don't know if you'll open it or not.

If you're a designer or not. If you're an architect or not. If it'll be made or not.

If it'll be put up or not. If the goods will come or not. If it's put up or sold.

Then when will the second round come? You're not going to say. Bro, close the shutter.

Let's buy a new yarn. Let's make a new cloth. Then we'll bring it back.

It'll come after a month. Because your dad will have money. But he's running an ecosystem.

So what you seem to be telling me is. You have to do this only. Only as a suggestion or advice.

Whatever I've learned from this. Go to a high street. Pull up your sleeves.

Go open a store. What's a high street? On the roads.

I mean. Like Indira Nagar is a high street.

[Speaker 3] (2:26:40 - 2:26:53)

And there you will get space. Okay, last two points from you. Hack for somebody trying to start a clothing brand.

This is actually personal interest to me. The hack. For someone young.

Find a difference.

[Speaker 1] (2:26:54 - 2:27:03)

Give us some examples of differences. You think might work today. Today.

Khadi. Khadi? We're the only country in the world.

Makes this fiber and this yarn.

[Speaker 3] (2:27:03 - 2:27:09)

You think going back to India. Using bandhgani. That kantara.

Khadi. Putting these together.

[Speaker 1] (2:27:09 - 2:27:38)

So that's women's side of the khadi. You know. Which is very highly embellished.

Still with a lot of work. Which is very women. The true true khadi in India.

It's a textile. Like Gandhiji khadi. The Gandhiji khadi.

Which you get in the industrial buildings. It is the best cotton you can touch. Khadi is cotton?

Khadi is nothing but. Raw cotton. Which has got seeds still in it.

Not removed. The seed. Kints are not removed out of it.

[Speaker 2] (2:27:38 - 2:27:40)

It's a little rough to touch.

[Speaker 1] (2:27:40 - 2:28:24)

It's rough. The organic. If this was an organic.

This would be. If recycled. Then it is going to be rough.

You dye it with only. Vegetable dyes and everything. You spin it this way by hand.

Like Gandhiji. You. On the chakra.

Yeah. And so you have very uneven yarn. And then you weave it by hand.

It's the softest fabric. It's the most organic fabric. That you want to be in.

And there are villages living on that today. They are desperate to get even money. Today raw mango is doing a brilliant job.

Their sarees are expensive. And today the advice to a 20 year is. Go and try to touch Khadi.

Because it's the only fabric in the world. Which only exists in India. There's no other.

Every other fabric is global. This is only Indian.

[Speaker 3] (2:28:25 - 2:28:28)

It's an interesting idea. We should. We should try t-shirts in Khadi.

[Speaker 2] (2:28:30 - 2:28:31)

T-shirts can't be made. T-shirts can't be made in Khadi.

[Speaker 3] (2:28:31 - 2:28:32)

Can't be made?

[Speaker 1] (2:28:32 - 2:28:32)

No.

[Speaker 2] (2:28:32 - 2:28:33)

You'll have shirts.

[Speaker 1] (2:28:34 - 2:28:35)

You'll have to weave it by hand.

[Speaker 2] (2:28:35 - 2:28:37)

Shirts, bangalas, kurtas.

[Speaker 1] (2:28:38 - 2:28:40)

It's a rigid fabric. You can make this.

[Speaker 2] (2:28:40 - 2:29:08)

I'm so intrigued. Because. I think.

Apart from beauty. If there's anything else that. I ever think.

I would. Want to build. Or try my hands on.

Would be fashion. And. Not that I've thought about it much.

But everything that you're saying. Is sort of. Building a story in my mind.

So when you say Khadi. I'm already thinking. Can Khadi be built.

A brand out of Khadi. Can it be built at scale? Would it be at all?

[Speaker 4] (2:29:08 - 2:29:08)

It should be also.

[Speaker 2] (2:29:09 - 2:29:11)

It can be built at a scale?

[Speaker 1] (2:29:11 - 2:29:12)

Yeah, 100%.

[Speaker 2] (2:29:12 - 2:29:12)

In India?

[Speaker 1] (2:29:12 - 2:29:16)

I think. Before I retire. It would be done.

[Speaker 2] (2:29:17 - 2:29:20)

And the cloth is. The pricing would be. Premium, right?

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (2:29:21 - 2:29:23)

It can't be sold cheap. And patriotism is in right now.

[Speaker 2] (2:29:24 - 2:29:25)

Patriotism is in right now.

[Speaker 1] (2:29:26 - 2:30:39)

So we all wear denims. Blue denims. We all think denim is.

Western, right? Denim comes from indigo blue. Denim is basically.

De. Nimes. It's de Nimes.

Which is France. Because the twill weave. Was first woven there.

The blue added in that. Was by the Americans. Who took the blue leaf.

From Tamil Nadu. So our leaf is. When it dries.

It becomes blue. The green leaf becomes blue. And we make.

We are the only country. Who grows organic denim. So.

Advice to them. They should find. These kind of.

Denim and Khadi. And fashion designing. Is not cut, paste.

Pieces here and there. It's about. Creating a complete.

Right look. And to get the margin. Do a good storytelling.

Alongside with it. You have to sell the story with it. You just sold your story.

Being a. A financial wizard. Guy saying that.

Six hours. Charity. City.

Recycle organic. You have to speak something. Story most important.

Very important. That's where IP sits. That story comes.

Story is IP? Story is the biggest IP.

[Speaker 2] (2:30:39 - 2:30:39)

Story is the emotional connect.

[Speaker 3] (2:30:40 - 2:30:41)

Biggest IP. Today's IP.

[Speaker 2] (2:30:41 - 2:30:42)

Which goes beyond.

[Speaker 3] (2:30:43 - 2:30:46)

Like even for you. Like that. Yeah.

Story tells.

[Speaker 2] (2:30:46 - 2:30:54)

Absolutely. I think. I was able to establish that.

Connect first. The story started selling. Before the product started selling.

[Speaker 1] (2:30:55 - 2:31:27)

So in our store. You will get. Fragrance in all.

120 stores the same. Our office smells the same. We get complaints.

When our Omni channel goes. That you send us used garments. Because our clothes smell of.

So you have a lot of perspiration. When you sue right. There are 69.

110 people. Who handle one garment. And it's their perspiration.

Which is coming from. What they've eaten. And if they're veg or non-veg.

It's a different smell. From your skin as well.

[Speaker 3] (2:31:27 - 2:31:28)

Pay attention to detail.

[Speaker 1] (2:31:28 - 2:31:35)

Yeah. So you have to. Neutralize your.

Fragrance of your. Each garment. When you wear your t-shirt.

Your store has to smell.

[Speaker 2] (2:31:36 - 2:31:38)

So if the store is smelling. Then the garment.

[Speaker 1] (2:31:39 - 2:31:39)

Garments carry the.

[Speaker 2] (2:31:39 - 2:31:40)

Will smell less. Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (2:31:41 - 2:31:42)

No. It takes that.

[Speaker 2] (2:31:42 - 2:31:44)

But how do you do it online? When you're selling it online?

[Speaker 1] (2:31:44 - 2:32:44)

So when it goes Omni order. And it goes from our store. People think we've sent them.

Worn garments. So they lodge a complaint for that. So we are busy.

Always explaining that. It's been our. So these are some rigidity.

Of your business plan. You should never deviate with. Give me another word for rigidity.

I think. I didn't do it. Abhi.

Be. Be. Core.

Abhi. Stuck to your core concept. Particular?

No. I think. You.

I see. I designed the brand. Saying the rare rabbit.

Will be written here on the belly. Because Italians. If they wear a blazer.

Their name generally is here. You're willing to take a. And then you don't even deviate.

Yes. You take a contrarian view. And back it fully.

So a fellow. Friend of mine in this business. He said Manish.

We too messed it up. Weaves. Ludhiana said.

Sir. That red shirt. Is going on these days.

He said. Send more cheques these days. He's saying.

Sir. You're a little sleeveless. Increase this a little.

You'll get so many comments in this country. That if you handle those comments. Your brand will become something else.

[Speaker 2] (2:32:45 - 2:32:47)

So he said. Did you manage to keep that noise away?

[Speaker 1] (2:32:47 - 2:33:16)

I. So. Because you said.

I'm rare. I never listened to them. We're the only brand in the country.

We don't do roadshows. We don't show our collection. And take bookings.

From the entire trade. Of 700 people. Who we.

700 points we sell today. We don't show our collection. And take orders from them.

We just send. What we think is right for them. For their market.

Because our AI. Our research. Our understanding.

[Speaker 3] (2:33:17 - 2:33:19)

Would you say. Would you like. Phrase it in a manner saying.

[Speaker 1] (2:33:19 - 2:33:33)

Client doesn't know what he truly wants. In India for sure. And.

At the same time. India is according to me. The most hungry country.

To ask for. Give me more. And give me new.

Just don't give me the same.

[Speaker 2] (2:33:34 - 2:33:36)

And what's the cycle of innovation?

[Speaker 1] (2:33:37 - 2:34:00)

So in. I'll give you a. I'll give you a better understanding.

In Zara. Innovation is every day. Our office is every day.

In India. Fashion is two seasons. You buy once.

And you buy twice. Second. Fall, winter, spring.

We buy every day. It doesn't stop. If I've seen this.

I can go back. And I'll say.

[Speaker 2] (2:34:01 - 2:34:12)

So for example. Let's say you've designed this shirt. And you've listed it.

On online. In your stores. Etc.

For how long do you think. It'll stay relevant. Till you have to change.

[Speaker 1] (2:34:12 - 2:34:15)

Not more than. Two and a half. Three months.

[Speaker 2] (2:34:15 - 2:34:19)

Two and a half. Three months. It's very quick.

It's very quick.

[Speaker 1] (2:34:19 - 2:35:07)

And we are the largest. Online. In the country.

Not metaphorically. But in genuine terms. Also because.

This also. So all our businesses are by accident. And people of 20.

Should not vary of that. In scale of that. I didn't get stores.

I have 25,000 pieces in my house. I had to start a website. I started the website 2016.

I think I was the only one. Has a website there. To design that.

I'm very particular about my font. So my font doesn't change. On our website.

Our deck letters. Anything you write. It'll be the same font.

You use this word a lot. Particular. The attention to detail.

We don't. I mean it's. So.

But you get these kind of. Hindrances. And you should not move.

Because that's how you stand a bit.

[Speaker 3] (2:35:08 - 2:35:14)

Do you think chains are in? Similar. Not bad.

[Speaker 1] (2:35:14 - 2:35:15)

I'm quite jeweled on this.

[Speaker 3] (2:35:16 - 2:35:48)

This chain actually. Is made by one friend of mine. Her husband is one of the fittest men.

Who will ever meet. His name is Manish. You know Manish?

He's my table. Yeah. So he would just be in the gym.

If. The time of 5 p.m. To 8 p.m. He would be in the gym. Wow.

I would go in between. From 6 to 6.45. Manish is there. You go at 8 o'clock.

Manish is there. You go at 5. Manish is there.

He is something else. Yeah. But she makes some interesting jewelry.

Outstanding jewelry. Yeah. And she only makes one one thing.

And she gave me this.

[Speaker 2] (2:35:48 - 2:35:50)

So she customizes it for you.

[Speaker 1] (2:35:50 - 2:35:54)

She only makes. It's her and her mother. Shruti is her name.

[Speaker 2] (2:35:54 - 2:35:55)

Sushma is her mother's name.

[Speaker 1] (2:35:55 - 2:35:57)

If you want diamond jewelry. That's the woman. According to me.

[Speaker 2] (2:35:57 - 2:35:58)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (2:35:58 - 2:35:59)

She made. It's not for all this.

[Speaker 2] (2:35:59 - 2:36:01)

I had. But this looks really good.

[Speaker 1] (2:36:01 - 2:36:05)

Yeah. I had somebody. I lost recently.

She made it. Yeah. She told me that.

[Speaker 2] (2:36:05 - 2:36:10)

Yeah. What's your channel of choice now? Is it digital?

Is it retail?

[Speaker 1] (2:36:10 - 2:36:22)

Store. We are 50. Store.

Store. Because country dynamics. Roads are getting built.

Malls are getting up. What great builders are building today. In terms of malls.

It's crazy. It's where all they are doing. What all they are doing.

[Speaker 4] (2:36:22 - 2:36:22)

It's like.

[Speaker 1] (2:36:22 - 2:36:24)

I love the stores. Right. Like I.

You can feel it.

[Speaker 2] (2:36:24 - 2:36:29)

I can see it. You can feel it. I can see it.

But I have a very different statistic. Going on in my mind. And I was reading.

[Speaker 1] (2:36:29 - 2:36:36)

So we play our playlist music. For all 6. 160 stores from our office.

Really. You control the music of your stores. Centrally.

Is it? Centrally.

[Speaker 3] (2:36:38 - 2:36:44)

Okay. So what I'm getting. Take away.

It's quite complicated. You're a complicated man.

[Speaker 1] (2:36:44 - 2:36:49)

Easy. Be straightforward. You'll be.

You'll make everything easy.

[Speaker 3] (2:36:49 - 2:36:58)

You're a avoidant attachment type. Do you. Worry about being vulnerable.

Or showing your insecurities. No.

[Speaker 4] (2:36:59 - 2:36:59)

I don't.

[Speaker 1] (2:36:59 - 2:37:05)

No. I'm the most open person. You can ever get to know.

About anything.

[Speaker 2] (2:37:05 - 2:37:08)

That's why he said. He has the most flexible back.

[Speaker 1] (2:37:08 - 2:37:09)

About anything.

[Speaker 3] (2:37:11 - 2:37:36)

Again creative. Parallel with you. I think.

I think attention to detail. Is something that came across. While you were speaking.

Many many times. From the perfume. In all your stores.

To the music. To where the buttons are. Indian waist is 2 inches higher.

So whoever is attempting this. Needs to pay. That much attention to detail.

To build in the space. That young 21 year old.

[Speaker 1] (2:37:36 - 2:37:38)

And also keep looking around. Your own society.

[Speaker 3] (2:37:40 - 2:37:47)

Story. Most important. Also IP.

Your story is as important as. As the product. If not more.

[Speaker 1] (2:37:47 - 2:37:48)

Absolutely.

[Speaker 3] (2:37:49 - 2:38:02)

Another big thing that came across. From Manish. No ego.

Shameless. Relentless. Is a superpower.

Ability or willingness. To bend your back. Very very important.

Can't have shame. When you're asking for business.

[Speaker 1] (2:38:03 - 2:38:06)

And not to forget. India is a very colourful country. So don't hide from colour.

[Speaker 2] (2:38:08 - 2:38:17)

And I think in a world full of ego. That can be your superpower. Say again.

In a world full of ego. That can actually become your superpower.

[Speaker 3] (2:38:18 - 2:38:22)

The world full of ego. Yeah. Not having one.

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (2:38:25 - 2:38:32)

Moving on to Ritesh. I shouldn't have come. Interjected.

It was going alright. I love being a spectator.

[Speaker 3] (2:38:33 - 2:38:35)

I came to you last. Because you're very popular.

[Speaker 1] (2:38:36 - 2:38:37)

Thank you.

[Speaker 3] (2:38:37 - 2:38:40)

I read in some magazine. That you're the most eligible bachelor in India.

[Speaker 1] (2:38:40 - 2:38:41)

Was.

[Speaker 3] (2:38:41 - 2:38:42)

I thought that was you. Was.

[Speaker 1] (2:38:42 - 2:38:45)

Before Manish. So you get crushed his house present.

[Speaker 3] (2:38:46 - 2:38:49)

I should have. I haven't yet. When I go to Delhi next.

[Speaker 1] (2:38:49 - 2:38:51)

I'll get crushed. Please please. I'd love to host you.

[Speaker 3] (2:38:51 - 2:39:14)

So Ritesh is a very unassuming. Sweet. Amicable person.

Basically he doesn't show his real self to anyone. Somebody so nice can't be so successful. Fundamental belief in life.

I agree. So the mask that he puts on is so strong. And it's always on.

Which must be so much work. That he must be tired.

[Speaker 1] (2:39:14 - 2:39:23)

So he has too many masks. No no no. I think Nikhil first gives you so much love.

He says sweet, unassuming, very amicable. And then goes for the kill.

[Speaker 3] (2:39:24 - 2:39:26)

Okay tell us about your personality.

[Speaker 1] (2:39:27 - 2:39:40)

I think you told some of it. So I'll borrow. I think calm.

I try to make sure that there's just a sense of calm in myself. And then around me if possible. But if I can't keep it around me.

At least inside of me.

[Speaker 4] (2:39:42 - 2:39:43)

Why?

[Speaker 1] (2:39:44 - 2:39:45)

I like it that way.

[Speaker 3] (2:39:45 - 2:39:46)

You never get angry?

[Speaker 1] (2:39:47 - 2:39:49)

No I do get angry sometimes.

[Speaker 3] (2:39:49 - 2:39:51)

Do you emote when you get angry? Do you show it?

[Speaker 1] (2:39:52 - 2:40:21)

Yes yes. But I think it is not as volatile. I think I'll try to put it in words.

I try to put it in words more than in actions. I think. When was the last time you cried?

When was the last time I cried? I think I cried when I had my baby in my hands. Yeah.

I think it was hard not to cry then. But yeah I think.

[Speaker 4] (2:40:21 - 2:40:21)

Before that?

[Speaker 1] (2:40:22 - 2:41:02)

Before that. I cry probably every few months. Sometimes out of no reason.

Sometimes out of happiness. I think one thing that actually I know. I cried.

I cry a lot. So I deeply because of my upbringing, family and so on. Believe in existence of God.

So whenever I'm in you know a place of worship. Or even at my own home at the place I worship. I think sometimes I end up crying.

Probably for no reason.

[Speaker 3] (2:41:02 - 2:41:05)

Can I extrapolate and ask you why you believe in God?

[Speaker 1] (2:41:10 - 2:41:41)

I think it's a tough one to put in words. But I think there have been multiple. I genuinely personally believe that I did not deserve all I have gotten all my life.

So I'm just genuinely thankful. And I feel like there's probably a greater power which has just given me this opportunity. So I think that's probably and again I'm just trying to play it back.

But that's probably the reason.

[Speaker 3] (2:41:41 - 2:43:03)

Can I tell you something that is slightly similar between me and you? Is we've been on this train of youngest A, youngest B, youngest C. Because I think even though I'm significantly older than you.

I think in our own times we were young at doing something. A very natural parallel to that. Something I face deeply right.

Is I have imposter complex in so many different facets of my life. Deep down I believe I have gotten something I have not worked enough for. I also believe I'm not the smartest.

I'm not the most hardworking. Because there is a lot of tangible evidence for this. I can find you 10,000 people who are smarter than me and more hardworking than me.

Absolutely. We happen to be in that position in a very circumstantial manner. Belief in something that you have never touched or felt like God.

I'll probably get trolled for this. Trolled as ****. But belief in something that you haven't touched is also a byproduct of our circumstance.

When you say God, what is the concept of God to you? What do you mean by God?

[Speaker 1] (2:43:05 - 2:43:12)

In my view, just a greater power than humans. I think that's my concept of God.

[Speaker 3] (2:43:12 - 2:43:14)

Are you taking the religious connotation?

[Speaker 1] (2:43:15 - 2:43:23)

I think, I know there is a fine line between these. But I would say spiritual, not religious.

[Speaker 3] (2:43:24 - 2:43:27)

So organized religion, no. Spirituality, yes. Is that what you're saying?

[Speaker 1] (2:43:27 - 2:43:37)

Like for me personally, I think the belief in the power of spirituality is higher. But what is spirituality?

[Speaker 3] (2:43:37 - 2:43:43)

I often ask people to define spirituality. Each one tells me a different answer. What is Ritesh?

[Speaker 1] (2:43:43 - 2:44:13)

And that is what it is supposed to be. I think for me, it is like I mentioned to you. I think you may have heard about in a lot of books, people write this person is God fearing.

And I think what it basically means to me is that there is somebody who's keeping a sense of a check or an oversight on us and is a greater power than us and has the abilities to do things which humans cannot do themselves.

[Speaker 3] (2:44:13 - 2:44:17)

You mean in terms of punishment, because your derivative word was fear?

[Speaker 1] (2:44:18 - 2:47:05)

I won't say fear, but I think more a guiding light, sort of a way to make sure that you can reach your purpose for whatever you're around. I mean, I liked what you mentioned. I was, when I was coming by, I was watching a recent video in which you mentioned about we take ourselves too seriously.

And you know that fundamentally, you know, you're around for a certain point of time, you do the best you can. But the concept of legacy is flawed inherently. I think I fully agree with that.

So I think the whole point is for all the time you're around, you try to do the best you can, despite like you mentioned, I agree with your point that you mentioned earlier, which is the conscious mind tries to do all the right things, but subconsciously you're still human. So it's like a constant battle, right? That you want to make sure that you're consciously doing as much to pursue your purpose as possible.

So I think that's how I would put spirituality. Just a question, do you fear God or submit to God much later in life? Or it was always your...

It was actually due to upbringing, yeah. I think it was due to upbringing. It kind of changed for me in the last 10 years.

So I grew up in a place in South Odisha, a place called Rayagada. It's, I think 60% of the population is Adivasi, which is tribals, right? So there is a temple near our house.

It's called Majigaryani Temple. But she's the tribal goddesses who effectively protects our town, it's said. And there's history behind it and so on.

So for example, Odisha, you would have heard about cyclones very often. Yeah. Ki bahut baad aa jati hai, floods hote hain and so on.

So people say that the reason why there's been no floods in our town ever is because she's protected us. Now, many people may have different opinions about it. But I think as I grew up around there, it just sort of became a sense of belief that got captured.

Now, it may be rational or not. It's a separate story, but it's just my personal belief as an outcome. So for example, many people used to notice this.

I used to, at work, take off my shoes and go inside for the longest time. And at some point of time, I changed it. I think three, four years back.

But for the longest time, people used to sort of, there used to be a joke that, you know, he's at work by just noticing that the shoes are outside. So, but that's, I think that's deeply personal to me. I think it's probably the first time I'm talking about it at all.

But it's deeply personal to me. I don't think I impose it on anyone. It's everybody's own choice, frankly.

But it's just something I personally believe in.

[Speaker 3] (2:47:06 - 2:47:30)

But the clarity in the manner that you're articulating is very refreshing. Because you're not being defensive or aggressive in your stance, but you're still being very concise and clear. I think at the end of the day, that's all one can hope for, right?

But start from childhood. So let's get to know you like we got to know that.

[Speaker 1] (2:47:30 - 2:48:43)

You're not convicted. No, but look, I'm really enjoying this format, right? I think it's just so refreshing to not just go through what Nikhil said is the rehearsed part and just sort of go through the, like, just get to know individually and so on.

So I really enjoyed listening to both of you and your stories. So I grew up, I was born in a very conservative family. It's a village in the Raigada district where I lived after.

We have four siblings. I'm the youngest of the lot, i.e. the most loved among the siblings. The eldest is almost eight years older than me.

So eldest is a sister. So there's quite a bit of age gap. So, you know, and typically, parents or especially mom, but both of them used to encourage better education as a way of being able to graduate out of the town we grew up in.

Because in some way, education is sort of...

[Speaker 3] (2:48:44 - 2:48:45)

Brahmin family?

[Speaker 1] (2:48:45 - 2:50:01)

I don't know. Agarwal. So Marwadi family.

But grew up with a very Odia kind of attributes because multiple generations of both Papa and mom had grown up in Odisha. My mom came from a village called Itamati near Bhubaneswar. But, you know, I think there when I used to speak to other people saying, how long has this family been here?

They say that for as long as we can remember, right? Like, even the oldest of people. So I don't know how, but it just so happened that they were there.

And so I think, and the town is small. So everybody sort of knows each other, right? Like almost every family, every individual will know each other.

There's no concept of like somebody lives in the place and you don't know who that person is. So koi naya agar train se utar jata hai, toh aapko pata hoga ki yeh naya insaan is an alien who's alien national, not alien in the sense of an alien. Like, you know, US ke forms mata hai na, are you an alien?

So, I think elder three siblings are like Asian parents dream. Engineering, business school, good job, all the other ticks, right? Like marriage, children and all the tick marks.

And I was quite inspired by my elder sister.

[Speaker 3] (2:50:01 - 2:50:02)

What did your parents do?

[Speaker 1] (2:50:03 - 2:50:29)

So mom was a homemaker. Papa had a small shop initially, where he would sell like grocery products and so on. But later he joined a road construction company as a manager in that company.

So anyway, I think growing up, I was more the rebel relative to the other three kids because of so much love.

[Speaker 3] (2:50:29 - 2:50:31)

One son, oldest sister, middle?

[Speaker 1] (2:50:31 - 2:50:47)

So eldest is a sister. Second is also a sister. Third is a brother, who's three and a half years older than me.

And I'm the fourth. So do you work with any of them? No, so the eldest sister works for one of the subsidiaries of S&P.

Second sister…

[Speaker 3] (2:50:47 - 2:50:48)

Standard & Poor?

[Speaker 1] (2:50:49 - 2:50:49)

Yes.

[Speaker 3] (2:50:50 - 2:50:51)

The rating agency?

[Speaker 1] (2:50:51 - 2:50:54)

The rating agency is one of their companies acquired.

[Speaker 3] (2:50:54 - 2:50:56)

What are they doing giving India such bad rating?

[Speaker 1] (2:50:57 - 2:50:58)

Look, I think…

[Speaker 3] (2:50:59 - 2:50:59)

It's a big problem.

[Speaker 1] (2:51:00 - 2:51:02)

We are also rated by Moody's and Fitch.

[Speaker 3] (2:51:02 - 2:51:05)

Same. And… What is it now?

Double B minus.

[Speaker 1] (2:51:05 - 2:51:07)

I think we are B rated now.

[Speaker 3] (2:51:08 - 2:51:09)

No, I think we are BB minus.

[Speaker 1] (2:51:09 - 2:51:13)

As India. Oh, sorry. I was telling the OYO rating.

No, no, I think… So…

[Speaker 3] (2:51:13 - 2:52:26)

You know, I'll tell you, it's such a big problem. We don't talk about it enough. Every country's cost of borrowing is dependent on how we are rated by these three arbitrary agencies.

And what are their criteria of rating? Six are quantitative in nature. Like GDP rate, fiscal deficit, inflation, past track record of servicing debt.

The other 10 or 11 parameters are arbitrary in nature. It's more coming around perception and stuff like that. And at triple B minus, correct me if I'm wrong later, but I think it's triple B minus now.

Our cost of borrowing is higher than countries which are one-tenth our size. Let's say a Kazakhstan has the same rating as us or slightly lower or whatever. Slightly better rating, let's assume.

Kazakhstan has better than us. I don't think they do. I think they're slightly below us in the table.

If they're able to borrow money at 5% for infra projects, building roads, train, airport, whatever… And we'll end up what? We'll end up borrowing at 6.5%. A 20-year term loan, if we are borrowing 10,000 crores. In reality, these numbers are significantly larger than 10,000.

[Speaker 4] (2:52:26 - 2:52:26)

Yeah, yeah.

[Speaker 3] (2:52:26 - 2:52:30)

When we are paying back at the end of 20 years…

[Speaker 1] (2:52:30 - 2:52:31)

With the dollar.

[Speaker 3] (2:52:31 - 2:52:43)

This 10,000, we are paying back maybe 25,000. They are paying back 17,000, 18,000. That tiny difference in rating changes our cost of infra significantly.

[Speaker 1] (2:52:43 - 2:52:59)

And it is not just for the country, right? It's also for corporations whose source of income is India. So, if you are an Indian corporation, you may be like any big company, you don't get an A rating because your sovereign itself is not rated.

[Speaker 3] (2:52:59 - 2:53:11)

But this is something we all need to make noise about. I think what these three agencies together are doing is extremely unfair and bad, very detrimental to the long-term growth of India.

[Speaker 1] (2:53:11 - 2:53:31)

Going back, I think the eldest sister has sort of been a source. So, I was coming through everyone. The second one is now between jobs.

She's left Cognizant. And because she's not joined, I'll not share, but she's moved to a consulting company. Elder brother works for Mindtree.

And I'm the fourth one.

[Speaker 3] (2:53:31 - 2:53:37)

How have the equations between the siblings changed? Because you are such an outlier today.

[Speaker 1] (2:53:39 - 2:53:41)

Equation among siblings.

[Speaker 3] (2:53:41 - 2:53:43)

How are you guys growing up? And how are you now?

[Speaker 1] (2:53:44 - 2:55:45)

Look, I think growing up, essentially, there was a unique perspective where the eldest sister was like a little mom of sorts, right? Because the age difference was so high. And she was sort of, in our family, the first woman who, you know, she was among the top rankers in her school when she graduated out of 10th.

Like the overachiever, Gazelle, right? So, she was the first one who went to engineering school. She got a job at TCS.

So, like our dreams, at least my dreams, were… This kind of villages you explain you are coming from or district or taluk, I don't know, how do you… How did your parents even think to educate all of you with such high pedigree?

I mean, okay, you have to teach. That too, Marwari's and Agarwal's. Teaching is one basic thing.

Flying out all four. And I think a large part of it, I think, is driven by… As much as my parents, I would give credit to the eldest sister also.

Because she pursued that path. And everyone followed. It basically became like a little bit of…

And every elder and younger sibling will relate with this. If your elder sibling got through good grades in your class and graduated, and if the same class teacher is there, they'll say, look at your elder sister or brother. They did so well.

And like, what are you doing? So, it sort of becomes a little bit of a peer pressure, right? So, I think she, for the first time, I think…

I was still in my junior or middle school, between somewhere between third and fifth grade. And she had just gotten into her engineering school. First year.

And she had what was the Entrepreneurship Fest. So, she went to Barampur, which is a place in Odisha. It's a bigger town for her engineering schooling.

So, she came back during her break. And she comes and says, we had an Entrepreneurship Fest. I had no idea what that word meant.

So, that was the first time I figured that there is this new word.

[Speaker 3] (2:55:46 - 2:55:49)

Being the eldest sister, like mother figure. The other two?

[Speaker 1] (2:55:50 - 2:56:01)

Yeah. So, I think the youngest sister, second sister, was a little bit like the person you create trouble with. Right?

Like, you know…

[Speaker 3] (2:56:02 - 2:56:02)

Were you naughty?

[Speaker 1] (2:56:03 - 2:56:04)

I was quite naughty.

[Speaker 3] (2:56:05 - 2:56:12)

I know of some of the naughty things you have done as an adult. But dig a little deeper as a child. I have no idea what you're talking about.

[Speaker 2] (2:56:12 - 2:56:14)

I would want to know what's that.

[Speaker 1] (2:56:15 - 2:56:44)

Dig deeper as a child. And the brother? With the brother, it was a mix of, I would say, learning and also that one sibling that you fight a lot with.

There's a combination, right? So, I think… So, for example, my love for sports started with him.

Because he and his friends would play sports. And I wanted to be a part of the group.

[Speaker 3] (2:56:44 - 2:56:53)

This again is something I hear from a lot of successful entrepreneurs. Some affiliation to sports. I've never been able to figure out what the connection is, but…

[Speaker 1] (2:56:53 - 2:57:25)

Actually, even when we recruit people, we try and recruit people who have been good in sports, especially… Why is that? Do they do better?

They do very well with us. There are two, three reasons why I have deciphered the outcome. The first is, especially we'd like to get people from team sports.

So, we believe that their ability to work with other people and make sure that the team wins rather than individual is better. Pursuit of excellence. Because in sports, you are competitive.

You want to win. You don't want to sort of be average as an outcome.

[Speaker 3] (2:57:26 - 2:57:28)

Would you say clarity of thought is important for an entrepreneur?

[Speaker 1] (2:57:29 - 2:59:40)

I think like… I call myself in a company, Chief Clarity Officer. I think fundamentally, one of the

biggest challenges…

I think that's probably the similar word of rigid that you were saying. I think having a clear answer versus saying that, I don't know how it's going to come, and let's derive it out of 20 other things. Or whatever people are saying, let's do it.

I think that fundamentally is different. I would say this is true for any leaders. You can be an entrepreneur…

I think he had that to a certain… He had that and even she to some extent, right? Like she said, this is the kind of product I want to build.

So, I think that… So, you say that some of or most… Whatever…

Some of your decisions also come by your gut and just without being a very derived formula, let's sit and get a calculation done. Or you just feel, no, I'm very clear. It will happen and let's…

Look, I think probably given today, I've been hearing a lot of depth in conversation. I'll try and sort of go a little bit deeper in that construct, right? So, I feel that most of my decisions are genuinely actually a derivation of many things.

But what comes out at the end is the gut feeling. So, I think… How would you define gut, the word?

So, in my view, the gut feeling is a summation of experiences I have had. Good or bad. But I have gone through some experiences where I have learned that, well, this works for me and this doesn't work for me.

And sometimes what works for me may not work for anyone else. And what works for others may not work for me. And I'm very comfortable with that.

I have no FOMO of saying that, well, it works for someone else. I have an interest to learn why it worked for others. But I don't have the…

So, that's what I sort of define gut as from my perspective. And I think being contrary… Like, it's sort of…

It means that you have to be contrarian. I feel being contrarian is the other thing that as an entrepreneur is very valuable, right? Like, you have to be able to sort of have an opinion which maybe the average people around you do not.

[Speaker 3] (2:59:42 - 2:59:44)

Basically, mass is generally wrong.

[Speaker 1] (2:59:50 - 2:59:54)

Basically, what everybody else believes, you don't have to believe.

[Speaker 3] (2:59:55 - 2:59:58)

Maybe that means the same thing. That is a startup, right?

[Speaker 1] (2:59:58 - 3:00:05)

Yeah, absolutely. I think the startup is fundamentally saying that what everybody… So, fundamentally, you have to build something which is against convention.

[Speaker 3] (3:00:05 - 3:00:12)

If it is convention, the incumbent will likely do it better by virtue of experience and time. And the motive capital.

[Speaker 1] (3:00:12 - 3:01:01)

Yeah, yeah, absolutely, absolutely. So, I think going back, right? I think my tryst with entrepreneurship or the first word came there.

Before that, my eldest sister used to say that she wanted to be a pilot. So, when people would ask me, what do you want to be? I used to say, I want to be a pilot.

Even I used to say that as a kid. Right? Yeah, stupid astronaut.

I had no idea. Okay, not even a pilot. Like, we never had a plane pass by our house.

So, I didn't even know what a pilot does. But my elder sister says it. And she is the smartest in the family.

So, if she is saying it, then we will be the same. So, there is no confusion. So, after that, she said entrepreneur.

I tried to figure out from the dictionary what it meant. After that, I started saying I want to be an entrepreneur. So, my rebellious nature was this.

I tried to sort of be different. Contrarian.

[Speaker 3] (3:01:01 - 3:01:05)

This is again something which is common to a lot of successful entrepreneurs.

[Speaker 1] (3:01:05 - 3:01:15)

Rebel. Often without a cause. Yeah, often without a cause.

I think it's more a lot of start-ups nature only. If you want to become one, you have to be like a bull.

[Speaker 3] (3:01:16 - 3:01:23)

Coming down to the same thing. Rebel, contrarian, against convention, anti-incumbent. Right?

Same thought.

[Speaker 1] (3:01:24 - 3:01:24)

Absolutely.

[Speaker 3] (3:01:24 - 3:01:30)

And I think… Where does the rebelliousness come from? Was it rebelling against your parents in the early days?

[Speaker 1] (3:01:30 - 3:02:18)

Or what they wanted you to do? No, I think quite the contrary. Actually, my parents, relatively, they felt that the elder three children had done so alright.

That they in some way also motivated me to become slightly more rebellious. Like they were generally more comfortable with me doing things which they were absolutely not comfortable with the elder three children. Which is probably also the reason I never stole, right?

Where basically if I asked for it, often they would give me. Which was not the case for my elder siblings. And I think I'm truly thankful to that extent.

I feel like if I was probably just born as a third child, I would not be who I am. I'd be who I am only because I'm the youngest of the lot.

[Speaker 3] (3:02:19 - 3:02:23)

Generally, middle kids are more rebellious. Because they have to set themselves apart.

[Speaker 1] (3:02:23 - 3:02:24)

Makes sense.

[Speaker 3] (3:02:24 - 3:02:30)

The top and bottom organically get attention. As long as they know it's their last one and there are no surprises.

[Speaker 2] (3:02:30 - 3:02:34)

I agree to that. Like for example. Even then the middle ones are still the rebellious.

[Speaker 1] (3:02:34 - 3:03:42)

At one point of time, principal said because he jumped the fence and came late da da da, for seven days he can't come to school. Like if any of my elder siblings had got that decision from the principal, I think they were up for like a lot of beating, scolding. There was no coming back from it.

Like for me, it was like, you know, mom sat me down. She said, you shouldn't do this. Dad said he's a young kid.

Happens. So, I felt, you know, I'm like. Ladla.

Yes, I felt like I should take full advantage of it and be as rebellious as I can. So, great communication with your parents? Good communication with parents.

I think more with papa. But because dad was more the person who said, do whatever you want to be. But mom was the one who would possibly sort of be the more, like you have to study well.

Like if you don't do that, you'll like be in Raigada and run like a paan shop, right? Like so mom would paint the contradictions much more actively.

[Speaker 3] (3:03:44 - 3:03:47)

Communication skills continue in companies like in OYO?

[Speaker 1] (3:03:48 - 3:03:51)

Yes, I think that's a very critical one.

[Speaker 3] (3:03:51 - 3:04:11)

Let me let me rephrase that question. If your management is doing something that is annoying you, two on a scale of one to ten. I might bring it up when it's five out of ten.

Do you bring it up at five out of ten, two out of ten, eight out of ten? How quickly do you communicate?

[Speaker 1] (3:04:11 - 3:05:02)

I think the feedback loop is or the communication loop is quite quick. I would now... And the magnitude is quite small.

Yeah, I'll just basically sort of swing it to say, annoying me may not be like there, the magnitude may be very high. But anything that I believe that is wrong for the company or wrong for the role or the purpose they're pursuing, I think I feel very comfortable to have a one-on-one conversation. Bring it up.

But along with calling myself chief clarity officer, I consider myself also a solution officer. So, I bring up the problem, but I often couple that with a solution. But I feel very comfortable in bringing up a conversation.

And I feel while in my family, that was very valuable. I think there was one person who changed it for me. I think the person is Bejul Somaya at Lightspeed.

So, Bejul invested in us like...

[Speaker 3] (3:05:04 - 3:05:07)

They invest very fast. Like they take no time at all.

[Speaker 1] (3:05:07 - 3:05:10)

With us, they took a long time. That was a different story back then.

[Speaker 3] (3:05:10 - 3:05:28)

There was one company we were reviewing recently. Let me not name the company. So, we were negotiating with the founder and he had come to the office in the afternoon.

He went to Lightspeed at night. He came back to us in the next evening and he said Lightspeed signed the term sheet. Lightspeed.

[Speaker 1] (3:05:28 - 3:05:50)

Yeah, no Lightspeed. They call themselves as a high conviction investor. So, they say that we invest very little.

Like they would invest in a year like four, five companies or three, four companies. But in the ones they believe in, they would move very, very quickly. But with us, they took longer.

I don't know why. Maybe they took longer to believe. But I had...

So, they invested... Your self-deprecating nature is very attractive.

[Speaker 3] (3:05:50 - 3:06:10)

Do you think that also holds good in the work ecosystem? Because we are so used to looking at people who are embellishing themselves constantly that that one startup which comes to you and

self-deprecates becomes a novelty. Do you think that works?

Contrarian mindset in a different manner.

[Speaker 1] (3:06:10 - 3:07:04)

Yeah, I think in some way. But I have learned that, you know, that's the only way, especially if you have a highly talented management, right? Who you want to retain for a long period of time.

There is no other way you can work with them rather than being absolutely straightforward, honest, vulnerable with them. And then, because you spend most of the time, most people don't recognize it, but they spend more time with their colleagues than with their own families also. So, due to which you basically become an average of the people around you.

That's my favorite line in The Office. I said, I know you more than your wife. You spend 11 hours here, 10 hours here.

So, to that extent. But I think, I feel personally that also comes when you become truly comfortable in your skin. I think the reason why the self-embellishing character gets built is because you genuinely have a sense of insecurity where you feel like…

[Speaker 3] (3:07:04 - 3:07:05)

Self-deprecating nature.

[Speaker 1] (3:07:05 - 3:07:13)

Yeah. Why do people say so much about themselves? They feel that if they say something bad, then, you know, what will it mean?

[Speaker 3] (3:07:13 - 3:07:16)

Can I ask you another question? I'm sorry, I'm digressing.

[Speaker 4] (3:07:16 - 3:07:16)

Please, please.

[Speaker 3] (3:07:17 - 3:07:37)

Ritesh and Oyo dissect the two apart from each other. Ritesh the kid, Ritesh the teenager, Ritesh the young adult, Ritesh at 13. What do you think are your personality flaws?

And it's very core. I've come back to this because we stole money from our mother's purses. You did not.

So, there must be something else that we need to know.

[Speaker 1] (3:07:37 - 3:08:14)

The rebel in some way… Not a flaw. No, no.

I'll conclude that. The rebel in some way, I think, came out of a personality flaw of trying new things. And the flaw in it is potentially lesser attention span or lesser span in…

I give less time to something to fully bake open, right? Like, I feel I tried to do too many things in the early days of our company. And I feel when I fully decided that I'm going to do Oyo…

[Speaker 3] (3:08:14 - 3:08:16)

I'll ask you another question which might help with this answer.

[Speaker 1] (3:08:16 - 3:08:19)

Yeah. Think of a kid.

[Speaker 3] (3:08:19 - 3:08:21)

I keep coming back to kids.

[Speaker 1] (3:08:21 - 3:08:32)

Yes. Think of a kid. No, I agree with that.

Three to seven. I think that's when your formation or foundation as an individual is built. Yeah.

Think of a kid, okay?

[Speaker 3] (3:08:34 - 3:09:11)

I'm in a room with a kid. I put a marshmallow in front of the kid. I say I'm going to go out of the room, make a phone call and come back into the room.

If the marshmallow in front of you, I tell the kid, is still there when I come back, I will give you two marshmallows. Then you'll have two instead of one. When people tested kids, actually, they figured that 80% of kids are not able to delay gratification until the person goes out of the room and comes back and they eat the marshmallow.

80%.

[Speaker 4] (3:09:11 - 3:09:11)

Yeah.

[Speaker 3] (3:09:12 - 3:09:36)

And when they tracked the 20% of kids over a 15, 20, 30, 40 year period, they figured this tangible evidence to prove that the kids who were able to delay gratification turned out to be the most successful when they grew up. Do you think not being able to delay gratification could be a flaw in you? Personally, don't bias it on what I have to say.

[Speaker 1] (3:09:37 - 3:10:58)

I'll tell you the two personality traits, which is confusing me about this question. I have very high ability of delaying gratification in terms of wealth creation, for instance. On the other hand, I have very low ability to delay gratification in terms of beginning the pursuit that I wanted.

And I'll give examples of both in a tangible way. So it'll explain this to you better. I genuinely fell in love with this idea that, you know, I will go digitize small hotels.

And I thought the time is now. And I said, I'll do it now. This is right after 12th grade.

First, Papa got to know and he tried to reason with me, saying that, you know, get your college done and then do this. And I said, you know, I genuinely believe the time is now. And of course, Papa having better communication, both of us then came up with what the communication to mom will be, which basically became all the kids in our 12th grade are taking a gap year.

Consider this the gap year. And if it doesn't work, I'll move back. So this is where I did not delay gratification.

On the other extreme, I think, probably just, so it was this year completing 10 years. So we are, we've been around for some time. Probably until three or four years back, I had a few likes in my bank account.

[Speaker 3] (3:10:59 - 3:11:00)

You never did secondary.

[Speaker 1] (3:11:01 - 3:11:21)

I never did secondary. Because the purpose and the enthusiasm was so exciting that nothing else mattered in terms of context. So I think there is a conformity in me also.

I have, I'm a unique combination of rebellious and conformity. So for example, Can I, can I take away from your last statement?

[Speaker 3] (3:11:22 - 3:11:42)

You're able to delay gratification when it comes to money paid out to you without complicating

how that's a secondary round. But you find it harder to delay gratification when it comes to growth or when it comes to public perception?

[Speaker 1] (3:11:43 - 3:11:55)

I think money paid out to me, I'm willing to delay gratification. I'm unable to delay gratification when it comes to intellectual stimulation.

[Speaker 3] (3:11:55 - 3:11:56)

Which comes via?

[Speaker 1] (3:11:57 - 3:12:01)

I think, you know, solving problems, right? I think finding...

[Speaker 3] (3:12:01 - 3:12:07)

Same problem, new problems. Because once the problem is solved, it becomes less intellectually stimulating, right?

[Speaker 1] (3:12:07 - 3:12:45)

Yeah, no, which means new problems. I think, which is the whole point I was going back to, right? That for me, last five years, I had to change myself fundamentally to try and make sure that every day I reviewed the same thing.

Because businesses are inherently boring at some level, right? So you have to make sure that there's the 30% excitement, which is solving a new problem, creating a product feature or one of those things. But 70% of it is just ops, right?

Like doing the same job a little bit better every day. And that did not come naturally to me. I think I had to train myself to become that person.

Who do you emulate? Ritesh, the person.

[Speaker 3] (3:12:46 - 3:12:50)

We all pick someone and do it. Consciously and subconsciously.

[Speaker 1] (3:12:50 - 3:13:37)

I think as a business person, somebody who, at least over the last five years, and I said that I tried to transform myself, especially with the onset of COVID or around four years maybe. I think that is Uday Kotak. I think, I feel like he's one of those people, again, first generation entrepreneur.

Most people don't recognize, built a bank, first generation. He's king of delaying gratification. Yeah.

And you sit with him in the room, there's a sense of calm, right? Like, and every time he begins in classic Gujarati saying, Paise aage, sab account mein rakh liya, sab abhi theek challa hai. So he, like, there's just a sense of, when you begin the discussions with him, there's a sense of, like the world may be burning and he will represent that in words, but he would not emote it in actions.

[Speaker 3] (3:13:37 - 3:13:54)

I agree with you a hundred percent, but if you have to derive something from this for a 21-year-old we are talking to today, what do you think people like Uday Kotak, his generation had that the 21-year-old today is lacking, which is relevant to the world of today?

[Speaker 1] (3:13:55 - 3:14:21)

I would say three things. The first one is being absolutely comfortable to make sure that when your friends are sharing beautiful Instagram stories of going to pubs, restaurants or very exciting places, you are pursuing things which are not exciting and you sort of tend to believe that it is because of your circumstances.

[Speaker 3] (3:14:22 - 3:14:24)

Would you say that's delaying gratification?

[Speaker 1] (3:14:24 - 3:14:26)

That's delaying gratification, but I'm just trying to put it in…

[Speaker 3] (3:14:26 - 3:14:28)

Going to a pub is instant pleasure center.

[Speaker 4] (3:14:29 - 3:14:29)

Yes, yes.

[Speaker 3] (3:14:30 - 3:14:59)

There's a psychologist who said a very interesting thing. What is the difference between pleasure and enjoyment? Pleasure is having that piece of chocolate which has sugar in it.

Pleasure is having a beer maybe. Pleasure becomes enjoyment when there is a gap between two pleasurable events and you add memory to it. Memory happens by virtue of adding a group around it.

[Speaker 1] (3:14:59 - 3:15:25)

No, I think the other way to put it is, if you look at this Netflix documentary, which is, I think it's called the Blue Lines or Blue Zones, which talks about longevity. And longevity has something similar, which talks about a sense of community, happiness, but at the same time, making sure that your food habits, etc. are sort of not designed for short-term pleasure, but long-term enjoyment.

[Speaker 3] (3:15:25 - 3:15:29)

So, delaying gratification. That's one. Not succumbing to the short-term pleasure.

[Speaker 1] (3:15:29 - 3:15:43)

Absolutely. And also not having to conform to average people, like average peer pressure around you, right? Don't you think this generation has that in check, compared to Uday Kotak in that generation?

[Speaker 3] (3:15:44 - 3:15:46)

They were more conformist than the 21-year-olds of today.

[Speaker 1] (3:15:47 - 3:18:12)

I think the 21-year-olds have, if I were to reverse the word of conformity, peer pressure to look the best on social media, to make sure they dress the best, to make sure that they have the best number of posts, to make sure they have the most number of likes. You would say social pressure. Social pressure.

That's probably a better word to it. But I think to avoid it to significant extent is a very critical thing because that pressure is so high and so noisy today that it can end up pushing you towards doing things. With no patience.

With no patience. If that is there, at least they can handle all that. Because I grew up in a similar generation.

Now, I think 10 years back is already a generation apart. But I think 10 years back when I was growing up, people around me would look at me and say that you guys are a dork, right? Like absolute dork.

Studying all the time, doing business. Who does this when they are 19? And if you get bothered by it, you will lose, in my view, the number one thing that it takes to get an entrepreneurial success or any success, which is perseverance.

Like being at it for long periods of time. Because there are so many reasons to give up, no? You

should not get one layer under your skin.

So, for example, like I told one of my friends, that my Barsati is here. Get down from this metro station and come in an auto. In Delhi, Barsati is like a thatched roof room at the top of a house.

So, that's where I used to live when I first moved. Like most people who move to Delhi live there. So, but I had never told him that it's a Barsati.

Because you don't tell it in normal conditions. I just said, my house is here. You come in this metro station.

He said, I have to come in an auto. You don't have a car. Right?

Like a usual kid. This was a wealthy kid. There were some kids I was trying to, not when I was starting my business in Delhi.

A usual kid would have gotten so bothered that they'd have stopped calling people to meet themselves. But for me, it was very comfortable. I was very okay with saying that people will say this to me.

And if I do well in life, it'll be all right. If not, then this is the means I have. So, being okay to let go of social pressure is what I would encourage.

And I also got bothered by it a lot of times. How old was that?

[Speaker 4] (3:18:13 - 3:18:13)

When?

[Speaker 1] (3:18:13 - 3:19:13)

I was 19. 19. But I also got bothered by it.

But I recognized that I'd get bothered if I didn't have enough money in my pocket. Like you were saying, what can be worse? So, whatever you have, from your reality…

How many out of 10 used to come? Correct. To your company?

All the entrepreneurial people used to come. Okay. After that, they say that if you have a problem with your vehicle, then change the route.

So, we took the route where we could meet more people while driving. So, entrepreneurs were similar. Rebels without a cause.

So, we became friends with everyone. So, Uday Khotak, you said… So, first is…

Delayed gratification. Delayed gratification. Second is no social pressure.

Let me put it as indifference is the new cool. Indifference is the new cool. Absolutely.

And the third one is, I think, a sense of humility. And humility in decisions which can be very large. So, for example, nowadays when I meet young entrepreneurs…

[Speaker 3] (3:19:13 - 3:19:21)

Do you think humility is counterintuitive to self-confidence, which we established as a prerequisite for someone looking to start up?

[Speaker 1] (3:19:22 - 3:19:27)

No, I think they are independent, strong characteristics. I think you can be…

[Speaker 3] (3:19:27 - 3:19:28)

Can you be self-confident and humble?

[Speaker 1] (3:19:28 - 3:19:29)

Yes, you can be self-confident.

[Speaker 3] (3:19:29 - 3:19:30)

Give me a for instance.

[Speaker 1] (3:19:31 - 3:19:52)

So, self-confident would mean that I can build Oyo into an incredible success. Humble is… It's the first time I'm building a hotel business.

So, I don't know what will go in this journey. But I will figure it out. So, I think that's my view.

But to the third point…

[Speaker 3] (3:19:52 - 3:19:58)

Will you add to the end of that line? Can you help me? His point of no ego, willing to bend your back.

[Speaker 1] (3:19:58 - 3:21:06)

Absolutely. Absolutely. And I'll explain an example with Uday Khotak's example, right?

He built a fantastic franchise in his previous avatar before the bank. And he was… So, he started

a big discounting business, if I remember it right.

He was okay to add the Mahindra name to the bank. Right? He had built a big business.

He didn't need to do it. But he was okay to do it. Nowadays, when I meet entrepreneurs who have just started the business, not all, like 90% of them, like I'm surprised young entrepreneurs can be so bright and they have all these characteristics.

But there's some people who have this sense of saying that a sense of superiority that I have done so much already. I think for people in that generation like him, like Narayan Murthy and various others, they built incredible businesses, but we're still able to accept that. But in comparison, I'm still a rounding error.

And I have to do a lot more. And I think that was that humility that allowed them to become, you know, a bigger version of themselves consistently.

[Speaker 3] (3:21:06 - 3:21:13)

They say people who made a lot of money very quickly, often hate themselves and the world. Subconsciously.

[Speaker 1] (3:21:14 - 3:21:19)

Do you? Often hate themselves and the world. Trying to find yourself or something.

[Speaker 3] (3:21:19 - 3:21:20)

Yeah, like deep down.

[Speaker 1] (3:21:23 - 3:21:34)

Deep down. Oh, yeah. I think I'm an absolute.

I like myself. And, you know, I try to do more to like myself.

[Speaker 4] (3:21:34 - 3:21:34)

You like the world.

[Speaker 1] (3:21:34 - 3:21:42)

Humility also allows you, allows a lot of common people to accept you on a very easy, approachable manner.

[Speaker 4] (3:21:43 - 3:21:45)

And humility is just being honest. In my view, humility.

[Speaker 1] (3:21:45 - 3:22:03)

You should be so surrounded with your own self and your XYZ. Humility doesn't mean that you just have to say that we don't know anything. So then you're under confident.

According to me, you should have confidence. But you should at the same time be able to accept that there are things that you don't know. And there are other people who have done better than you.

[Speaker 2] (3:22:04 - 3:22:11)

I want to understand that more. That people who have made a lot of money very quickly, deep down, hate themselves.

[Speaker 3] (3:22:11 - 3:22:17)

It's, there's a certain pathway to arrive at the conclusion. I think it passes through imposter complex.

[Speaker 2] (3:22:17 - 3:22:18)

Imposter syndrome.

[Speaker 3] (3:22:18 - 3:22:18)

Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (3:22:19 - 3:22:20)

I could relate it to that.

[Speaker 1] (3:22:22 - 3:23:24)

Yeah, but I think the imposter complex is a serious one, right? Like, I genuinely believe that I had, I have no business sitting here, right? Like, our entire Raigada town would have gotten laddoos if I had gotten Infosys Assistant Technical Engineer.

That is the starting job called. In which you get 3 lakh salary. Like, if I had gotten that, our town would have celebrated.

I would have been super happy. My mom for the longest time thought that I have gotten into friendship with wrong people who have gotten me to this entrepreneurship buzz. So, I think, I genuinely feel that something has happened.

Because of which, like, there was, by mistake, I got into a classroom. And it has happened many

times in life. I'll give you an example, which is a very close story.

And I've never talked about it. But very close to my heart. So, after 12th grade, what changed my life was the Thiel Fellowship.

So, Peter Thiel is the founder of PayPal, early investment in Facebook. How does a 12th grader know about who Peter Thiel is? Rebel without a cause.

[Speaker 3] (3:23:24 - 3:23:25)

$50,000, right?

[Speaker 1] (3:23:25 - 3:23:52)

$100,000. $100,000, right? Toh tab 71 ka hota tha rupee, toh 71 lakh rupee.

Big deal, right? Now, how does a 12th grader get to know even about Peter Thiel? So, Rebel without a cause hai.

Toh saal bhar koi movie nahi dekhi. But jab kuch internship stipend se paise bache, usse social network movie dekhne gaye. In that, there is this person called Peter Thiel who gives the first $100,000 check.

So, next time I go to a cybercafe…

[Speaker 3] (3:23:52 - 3:24:03)

How does that work just for people who are watching and interested? Not just Thiel Fellowship, but anything similar that they'd like to apply for. How does one find out where these scholarships are and apply for them?

[Speaker 1] (3:24:04 - 3:26:52)

Look, I found it through serendipity. But I will give a few examples that I'm aware of and some of the things that I'm also doing as an outcome. So, Thiel Fellowship is one which is a program started by Peter Thiel, where he gives $100,000 to 20 people.

Earlier, it used to be age limitation under the age of 20. Acceptance rates are lower than Ivy Leagues. But there's one condition.

You have to stop out of college. Right? If you're in college.

If you're in college. I was not in college, so it was easier. And the thesis behind it, the contract's first line says, we never let university interfere with education.

So, education is everywhere, including the WTF podcast. But you don't have to go to university

for it. But university is one of the sources of it.

You can also pursue education there. So, I was a Thiel Fellow. But there are other Thiel Fellows like the founder of Ethereum is a Thiel Fellow, which is a cryptocurrency.

Founder of Figma. Figma is a design tool, very popular over the years. So, a bunch of these people who are exceptionally successful came to the fellowship.

And everybody has very similar backgrounds, right? Young people, they were rebel without a cause, wanted to make a positive difference. But coming back, Thiel Fellowship is one.

In India, there's something called the Young India Fellowship. Very popular, YI Fellowship, I think it's called. It's very popular, great.

Not similar, it's very different. But again, something that allows young people to be able to pursue their aspirations. But this one, I think, only invites graduates, post undergrad.

So, basically, after that, if you want to sort of be a part of the fellowship. I think something very different is Teach for India. I think that's another way of making sure.

Basically, what are the communities where you can find people who are slightly rebellious, who are trying to do something new in life, who are creative, who want to do something new. It may have been art for you. It may have been being in the company of Inditex and their ecosystem.

So, I think fundamentally just finding people around you. That's education. That's education, right?

You learn from them and it also allows you to... Get it in any university. You don't get it in any university.

So, I think that's the third one. I'm doing something with something that's called the Naropa Fellowship. It started by the Drupa of Ladakh.

Again, of course, the person who's involved between Ashoka University, Naropa, Harappa is all the same. Ashish and this other person, Pramath Sinha is the person who's involved. And I think a similar fellowship.

And what I have done with them is started a Naropa Ritesh Fellowship, where we basically... These are mostly hilly terrain kids, gotten out of college, want to do something new. So, I give them equity-free, debt-free grants.

Because the Thiel Fellowship changed my life. So, I thought, can I help make difference?

[Speaker 3] (3:26:52 - 3:26:56)

Same with the Zepto kids. They got a 40 lakh grant. They built Zepto in the back of that.

[Speaker 1] (3:26:56 - 3:26:57)

Really?

[Speaker 3] (3:26:57 - 3:27:00)

Yeah. Was that the game changer after Thiel?

[Speaker 1] (3:27:00 - 3:27:02)

Thiel Fellowship was a game changer. I think that changed my life.

[Speaker 3] (3:27:02 - 3:27:06)

Were you like a great student up until that point? Like first rank types?

[Speaker 1] (3:27:07 - 3:27:11)

Not first rank. I think third, fourth, second to fourth rank in my... Until 10th grade.

[Speaker 3] (3:27:11 - 3:27:11)

Same thing.

[Speaker 1] (3:27:12 - 3:27:15)

Yeah. But 11th, 12th grade, not so much.

[Speaker 3] (3:27:15 - 3:27:15)

No? Why?

[Speaker 1] (3:27:16 - 3:28:52)

Because... So, I think until 10th grade, I was in Rayagda. Post 10th grade, most kids go outside for education, right?

So, my elder three siblings, one went to, I think, other towns in Odisha only, bigger towns. Because in our town, the only way to get that was one college. And that wasn't like most preferred route.

But parents had some savings because elder three siblings, most of them got one of their degrees through what is called scholarship. So, parents had some savings. So, I said, rebel hai.

So, I want to go to Kota, Rajasthan. Kota is much more expensive to send a child to than that of

somewhere in Odisha, right? Because you have to send three day trains both sides.

So, you are the Kota factory... I am a part of the Kota factory production. So, during those two years, I used to sort of intern in small companies and so on.

While, of course, education. Education, I was not the first, second ranker. I was still reasonably good ranker.

So, I was not like I was terrible in terms of impact. So, parents were generally comfortable. So, I was not the Kota top kids.

I was medium. So, I did all right. So, 12th grade ke beech mein hi, around right after 12th grade, jo 6 mahine hai, that is when I applied for the Thiel Fellowship and became a Thiel Fellow.

The first time, I got a call. So, I applied because I heard about Peter Thiel. How do you apply this?

I am not, where is this Thiel Fellowship?

[Speaker 3] (3:28:52 - 3:28:52)

You apply online.

[Speaker 1] (3:28:52 - 3:28:56)

Online. You apply online. And it's just online class?

Digital application.

[Speaker 3] (3:28:56 - 3:28:59)

No, no, it's not a class. What do you have to submit when you make the application?

[Speaker 1] (3:28:59 - 3:29:02)

It's just a bunch of questions. About what business do you want to build?

[Speaker 3] (3:29:02 - 3:29:04)

What did you say? OYO?

[Speaker 1] (3:29:04 - 3:33:50)

I didn't call it OYO then. But effectively, the idea was the OYO idea, which I proposed. The accommodation with some standardization that we can provide.

I think, fundamentally, post those questions, there was no other Asian resident who had become

a Fellow before me. So, I gave myself 0% chance to become a Fellow. But I enjoyed the questions.

I answered them. Then interview started. So, there were telephone interviews.

So, the product head of Twitter will get on an interview with you. For a 12th grader, to be on an interview with people like those is a big deal. And I would do it on a feature phone of one of the friends, Barsati friends, who was staying next to me.

One day, I get this call, which is you're among the top 40 candidates selected. And we'll fly you to the US. And you can pitch.

And 20 would get selected post the pitch. I was so excited about it. The reason was not because I thought I'll become a Thiel Fellow.

I still gave myself 0% chance. It was my first flight and international flight trip I would ever get. For free.

Somebody else was paying for it. So, I was so happy to go to the US that I felt that life is made. So, but again, coming back to how parents were helpful, I got like a few days.

In that period, mom got the passport made. I didn't have a passport. For the US visa, I didn't know it was so hard.

And this is an example of why I believe that genuinely, I am lucky. So, I was told, I have to do a biometric test. And they'll send a letter.

You give the letter, you get the visa. And you have to go to Delhi or Bombay. No, I was in Delhi only.

So, it was even easier. So, I got the biometric test. Next day was the interview.

Now, for the interview, I thought that you get a stamp by giving the letter. So, I basically was wearing shorts, had my hair all over. And I reached the US embassy.

And I see people are wearing jackets, ties, have big books, interviewing each other. So, I thought maybe they have come here for some job interview, some different work. My work is different.

That's the level of coming to self-confidence. Very self-confident. I reached the interview lady.

And as I get closer, if you see the line, it looks like it's from outside. So, from outside, I thought it was different. But inside, reaching the counter, we were all in the same counter.

So, I'm starting to feel that it's something different. But I was still convincing myself that Peter Thiel has given me a letter. In my mind, I thought that the visa will be given immediately.

So, the lady asked, what's your purpose of visit to the US? So, I say, I want to drop out by becoming a Thiel fellow. She listens, drop out.

And in her mind goes, this guy is going to go to the gas station. Next, that's his plan. And weirdly, he's being honest about it also.

I only learned this later. Because at that time, I thought… Then she says, do you have like…

If that's the purpose of visit, is there an education also you want to pursue? I say, yes. Thiel fellowship can be considered as education.

So, she said, do you have any documentation for it? I said, there's this letter. So, she said, unfortunately, it doesn't seem like we can give you the visa.

But we can't also return you the passport. So, typically, they reject the visa, they give you back the passport. So, I said, you can't reject the visa first off.

And second, my flight is day after tomorrow. So, to return the passport to me anyway. She says, unfortunately, that's not how it works.

And shuts down the window. I came back home, I cried like crazy. Because I thought that I would get a chance to visit the US only once in my life.

Because nothing like this was going to happen. And I wanted to learn. And before that, I had cold emailed so many people.

I had cold emailed like 100 people saying that I want to come see… Like your office or so on. Like I had cold emailed, God bless him, Tony Shea of Zappos and so on.

Saying that I want to come and see your office. So, anyway, long story short. I wrote to the Thiel Fellowship as well saying that they didn't give me the visa.

Can you write a letter to them so that there's some credibility? They wrote a letter. And the embassy was nice to later give me the visa.

I got into the flight next day. Even the flight was a weird thing. I had a Lufthansa flight.

The Lufthansa flight got cancelled. The fellowship was nice to book a British Airways right after. So, I think this fundamentally for me, I feel like this long story is just to say that anything could have gone wrong in this.

The visa could not have come. The flight could not have, you know, happened. Something could have gone wrong.

So, in life, we forget when we reach to this point, there were probably 200 things that had to go

right. And if that one thing did not go right, you'd probably be in a very different place. You say serendipity a little bit more than usual.

Yes.

[Speaker 3] (3:33:50 - 3:33:52)

True, true belief in that?

[Speaker 1] (3:33:52 - 3:34:03)

I have true belief. I have true belief in if you work hard, opportunities will come your way which otherwise would not have.

[Speaker 3] (3:34:04 - 3:34:10)

What have been the most serendipitous events that you can remember? If you were to name just two.

[Speaker 1] (3:34:10 - 3:35:24)

Just two. The US embassy, I'm guessing is one. Yes.

So, that's one. I'll try the second one. I think the second one is, actually, I'll say two, two more.

One is possibly how I met Anuj. Most people don't know Anuj. Anuj and I started OYO together.

So, before OYO, I was running Auravel for six months. And then I flipped to OYO. He joined me in Auravel.

And then we together pivoted to make it OYO. He's still with you? He's still with me.

So, at that, when I was running Auravel, it was me and one intern. Both of us used to run the company. Sahil was the intern.

Sahil, of course, had told me when he was interviewing that after two to three years, once he makes enough money, he will set up a restaurant and he'll leave me. So, true to the fact, three years later he left and now runs a fantastic couple of restaurants in Bombay. So, Anuj calls, wherever he figures about Auravel, he calls the call center.

Sahil picks up. He thinks it's a big company. So, Anuj says, can you connect me to the chairman's office?

Sahil says, I don't know who the chairman is, but Ritesh is sitting next to me. Maybe he can tell you. He hands over the phone.

All of us have gone through this story, right?

[Speaker 4] (3:35:24 - 3:35:25)

Oh, we have.

[Speaker 1] (3:35:25 - 3:37:00)

So, I get the phone and I'm telling Sahil on the side that the chairman is calling. So, let him call. It feels good.

It feels good that we can also become the chairman. But anyway… And Anuj speaks and he's opposite of me, right?

Like he went to ITBHU, built his business during school, sold it, went to UIUC for some internship, but then had come and joined a consulting company and was hating it. So, he wanted to leave it and build something. So, we speak for 50 minutes and he said, I have explored Airbnb in the US.

This is my view. So, I made as much copious notes as I could. And at the end, I said that it's been great talking to you, but I can't afford you.

But I learned so much. The day I can afford you, we'll chat again. Then he says, but I'm happy to meet you.

Let's meet once. I said, if you want to meet after hearing what you heard, be my guest. Please come.

So, he came. Again, we spent an hour. I learned more.

At the end, I again said, it felt good, but can't afford you. So, he said, there is this thing called ESOP. I don't need salary.

I'm ready to offer no salary. I'll, in fact, put some money if required. But you give me ESOPs.

So, I said, this is a great thing. Without salary, you'll work. So, I said, perfect done.

ESOPs. So, he said, I want whatever. I think, I don't remember.

Three and a half or four percent ESOP. I said, perfect done. No problem at all.

You're not taking any salary. You're so well-educated. You're coming to work with me.

So, that was my concept of learning of ESOP in the first time. Like appreciation. Yes, I mean, what is this?

[Speaker 4] (3:37:01 - 3:37:01)

Well put.

[Speaker 1] (3:37:04 - 3:38:07)

Like depreciation of yours. Correct, correct. So, I thought this is fantastic.

Later, I recognized that, you know, this is probably one of the best decisions he made. But for me, it was a… Because for the first time, I saw what working with somebody who was, who understood process, who understood systems, who could document.

What did that look like? It was before that I only worked with interns. I didn't have appreciation of anybody else outside of that.

Second is Bejul, right? Like I was in the… During the Thiel Fellowship in the US.

Bejul was also in the US because Lightspeed has a… Their main office is in the US. I met him.

And at the end of it, we said that it's been great meeting each other. We'll reconnect sometime. They kept doing their work in India.

We had one OYO hotel then. We then opened another. So, they visited those hotels.

They visited other hotels. They met the property owner. Then one day called us saying that we want to try and do something with you.

I think Bejul also… I think other than Thiel Fellowship, Peter Thiel is… Bejul changed my life.

I think he was… I think the other person who I try to emulate a lot is, I think, Bejul. I think he has a sense of calm.

[Speaker 3] (3:38:08 - 3:38:08)

He likes this.

[Speaker 1] (3:38:10 - 3:39:24)

I think so. And I think he's genuinely… Like feedback, for example, communication.

I'll give you an interesting example of an uncomfortable conversation. I brought it up, right? So, we had a call center like most companies.

And I used to be the call center person who would pick up calls. That's from call. I make the booking.

And I used to love it because you speak to customers directly. Such an amazing job, right? So, even after they invested, I kept doing that job.

So, he would invite me every month for lunch. I'd go to that lunch. So, he'd feed me very well.

At the end, he says, So, Ritesh, I hear you're loving your call center job. I said, it's great. I listen to customers and so on.

So, he says in his… Like at the end that… So, that's great.

We found the call center head of OYO. We should now start finding the CEO. Should we start a process?

And I said, look, I get it. I get it that what I'm doing is not my job. And we will recruit someone.

But I think ability to say something in such a nice, kind way that at that room, you feel like, you know, it's an objective feedback. But when you walk out, you feel that that was a pretty intense feedback is something I've learned from him, I guess.

[Speaker 3] (3:39:25 - 3:39:27)

And beyond 12th, what happened? Theo's fellowship?

[Speaker 1] (3:39:28 - 3:40:35)

Yeah, Theo's fellowship came back to India. So, I was there in the US for 4-5 months. Lived in a hacker house with other Theo fellows.

But came back to India in 2013 mid. We, that was me, Anuj and a couple of interns at that point of time. And then sort of at the similar time, Lightspeed chose to invest a few months later.

Lightspeed invested, I think, 3.5 crores at a 8 crore valuation back then. It's a huge deal for us. I think I had never seen a crore together in a bank account in my life before that.

So, it put just a sense of accountability that now you have to, like, make good that there's somebody else who's willing to commit so much capital behind. And I think this since 2013 and roughly or 2014 early is when we really started growing the business. And, you know, we've continued in that path.

We've gone through our highs and lows, as you may have observed. You read that the arbitraries, there was Ki Acha Bhi To Hoyo.

[Speaker 3] (3:40:35 - 3:40:40)

Like, I feel, what helped you deal with the lows? What personality trait?

[Speaker 1] (3:40:41 - 3:41:30)

Look, I think two things, right? Fundamentally, one, we got more love than we deserved. So, if

you remember that we were getting too much appreciation sometimes.

But sometimes we also got beaten down a lot more. I think the trait of for a 20-year-old, for them to have that one day at college when they become the superstar and next week they are considered like an outcast. I think the trait is always being an optimist about the future.

And knowing that things will change either positively or negatively, I think.

[Speaker 3] (3:41:30 - 3:41:34)

I would say optimism and coming to terms with the cyclical nature of life.

[Speaker 1] (3:41:34 - 3:41:35)

Yes, and coming to terms.

[Speaker 3] (3:41:36 - 3:41:37)

Awareness of cyclicality.

[Speaker 1] (3:41:37 - 3:43:08)

Yeah, I would say that one needs to just be aware and comfortable that if an Amitabh Bachchan was in crazy debt and everybody wrote him off, he can come back to become one of the wealthiest stars in less than 20 years. Most bankable star. One of the most bankable stars.

And that doesn't happen as an exception. That's pretty much the norm for anybody who can stick their neck out and continue. So, I think if you are a 20-year-old, and I have gone through this many times, where everybody around you thought that you are a dandy.

The seven days when I was kept out of school and I was a prefect at that point of time. So, being a prefect and being told that you're suspended from school for some time. So, that is my unique contrarian perspective that I've always had.

That I'd be a prefect, but I'd also be slightly rebellious. Which is sort of what you also mentioned earlier in the perspective of saying that you have this contrarian side to yourself. So, I think in those times, I think it's very easy to give up.

And I was told that I'll not give you the certificate of the prefect because of this. A tough time is like a messy room. You have to tidy it up again because you want to live back in this space.

So, you have to be absolutely comfortable that there will be good days in the future and there will be bad days and there will be good days. And if you're having great days, you should know that the bad days are coming. And whatever you can do to prepare for it is better to do it.

[Speaker 3] (3:43:08 - 3:43:09)

Are you guys also optimistic?

[Speaker 2] (3:43:09 - 3:43:23)

Ghazal, are you? Unreasonably optimistic? Not unreasonably optimistic.

I am optimistic because what I believe in is if it's good, it won't last. If it's bad, it won't last.

[Speaker 1] (3:43:24 - 3:44:31)

Similar. Yeah. You?

I'm very optimistic. Actually, it's also your life's own behavior which gives you this built-up factor on this. I mean, you take a loan and you think you will pay back or not.

And instead of 15 years, you pay back in four years. It's all... Every expression of your journey and everything that you've achieved and gone through gets you more and more clear sight for the next episode that you want to attack.

But I think that's a fundamental difference. I think all entrepreneurs are optimistic. And risk-taking.

And risk-taking. But I feel that the persevering optimist types are the ones who create long-term success. I think the most people I have found around myself...

Like I feel, and to your point, Nikhil, I also believe that... Not believe. I know that I am not the best engineer, best salesperson, best finance person, any of those things, right?

But I feel in our industry, all the competitors we had, whenever the tough times came, they gave up. The only thing different about us...

[Speaker 3] (3:44:31 - 3:44:37)

Funnily, this is the first thing I wrote about you when she was speaking. Relentless. Have you ever read any Machiavelli?

[Speaker 1] (3:44:38 - 3:44:39)

No.

[Speaker 3] (3:44:39 - 3:44:42)

The European Chanakya, in a way?

[Speaker 1] (3:44:42 - 3:44:44)

No. I've heard about him.

[Speaker 3] (3:44:44 - 3:44:47)

You seem to embody a lot of what he says.

[Speaker 1] (3:44:47 - 3:44:50)

You know, if you all have watched the movie, 12th Fail.

[Speaker 3] (3:44:50 - 3:44:54)

No, not yet. But I've heard something incredible. You should absolutely watch it.

It is amazing.

[Speaker 1] (3:44:55 - 3:45:27)

So, if you watch that movie, you will hear that... You will see that that kid comes from Chambal. And he had that complex, saying that nobody else from Chambal becomes an IPS officer.

Without cheating. No, no. With cheating.

With cheating, you pass the school. No one pursues an IPS officer. Right?

IPS is so far-fetched that they don't even apply to the bank. Correct. Right?

So, if you are an IPS officer from there... It's a stigma. We are from Chambal.

But as leaders, I believe personally that big heart trumps big brains.

[Speaker 3] (3:45:27 - 3:45:40)

Have you ever had Taoism? Anything on it? Again, everything you are saying.

There is a European soul in your soul. How did you deal with your father passing away?

[Speaker 1] (3:45:41 - 3:45:43)

It was... Look, I think it was...

[Speaker 3] (3:45:43 - 3:45:44)

I think I messaged you that day.

[Speaker 1] (3:45:44 - 3:45:45)

You did. You did.

[Speaker 3] (3:45:46 - 3:45:48)

It sounded like a life-changing...

[Speaker 1] (3:45:48 - 3:46:09)

I think... Look, I don't think I have fully processed it even today. So, I'm still sort of...

There's a Spanish book. It takes three years to recover for a son. So, I think nothing prepares you for a loss of somebody as close as that.

Okay.

[Speaker 3] (3:46:09 - 3:46:21)

So, you started with the Thiel Fellowship money, with your friend Anuj, Oravel, data converted to OYO. When did the scaling happen?

[Speaker 1] (3:46:22 - 3:47:16)

First year was very small. Like, I think 2014, we grew from two hotels to maybe 10-15 hotels. Still a lot, but not like massive.

I think the real growth happened from 2014 all the way to 2017, which is where we went from a few hotels in one city to becoming one of the most prominent hotel brands in India. In the economy and economy plus kind of segment. 2019 is when the scaling then happened globally.

We went from being an India brand to becoming a globally prominent brand. So, for example, just in Europe, we manage 150,000 holiday homes. So, we have a fairly large presence in Denmark, Netherlands, Germany, and a few of these geographies.

So, I can relate with getting to the cities, out of the flight, to your hotel, do your job and come back. Me and Ghazal would switch places with you guys anytime. You're talking Milan, Madrid.

[Speaker 2] (3:47:18 - 3:47:20)

Now I get to do that for my work.

[Speaker 1] (3:47:20 - 3:47:20)

All my life.

[Speaker 2] (3:47:20 - 3:47:24)

Back in the time, I would have loved to switch. I'm here only.

[Speaker 1] (3:47:25 - 3:47:32)

In terms of discipline, there's one discipline that I maintain is a holiday every month. Every month? Every month?

Every month. Amazing.

[Speaker 4] (3:47:32 - 3:47:33)

That one I can switch places.

[Speaker 1] (3:47:33 - 3:47:43)

For the last six, seven years. How long is the holiday? Weekend?

No, three days, two days, five days, whatever comes. Every month? That's amazing.

[Speaker 2] (3:47:43 - 3:47:45)

Like you go out somewhere?

[Speaker 1] (3:47:45 - 3:47:53)

Out of the city. If nothing, nothing is happening, then go to JW, Gulfshire and stay in the hotel. Yeah, it's a nice idea.

[Speaker 3] (3:47:54 - 3:47:56)

You were describing post getting funded.

[Speaker 1] (3:47:57 - 3:48:00)

Post getting funded. Yeah, yeah. So, I think 2019 was a big global growth.

[Speaker 3] (3:48:01 - 3:48:03)

How much money did you guys end up raising? A lot, right?

[Speaker 1] (3:48:03 - 3:49:41)

Yeah, we raised close to a billion and a half dollars. Overall? Overall.

A little over that. So, already I think in 2019, when we grew this global expansion and we also made a couple of acquisitions, I think we were starting to see pains of growth. Pains of growth meaning…

How many hotels did you have by then? India? You said international, you mentioned, but India?

Similar as we have today. I think the total was around 15,000 hotels. We came down in COVID,

now we are bouncing back.

So, we are a fairly sizable business. And if I add China, it was more at that point of time, right? So, what did growing pains mean?

Growing pains mean that naturally economics were bad, right? And that was bad in a very unique way. 90% of our hotels were revenue share hotels.

10% were minimum guarantee. Those 10% hotels drove most of the losses and 90% of them were highly margin accretive always. I think the management bandwidth to run a business of that spread.

And you never… In reflection, I can say that we grew more than we should have, but at that point of time, it's hard to know when you grew too much. Because there's no playbook.

Like opening 30 stores is good, 10 stores is good, 20 stores is good. There's no arithmetic to it. And it was never written by us also that this year we'll do that many.

Correct. So, how did you handle that stress of having a billion dollar plus money into the system? Someone's money, right?

And if you're a Marwadi, you know, it's a lot for the 20-year-old guy.

[Speaker 4] (3:49:41 - 3:49:42)

Yes, yes.

[Speaker 1] (3:49:42 - 3:50:51)

What's that weight on that shoulder? I mean, I can't even hold that up. Look, I think…

How do you handle this? It is more or less accountability. Because once people invest the capital, then they require the monthly update, the regular reviews.

You have any questions that can come up. I think fundamentally for me, in the early days especially, to not raise capital was not a choice. Because I had no resources.

So, initially, it was necessary to have less capital. I think India leadership sort of happened organically. After that, the global expansion that was in my view driven by my own personal belief in impact.

Like what drives me every day. One is complex problems. Second is how many people's lives I'm touching.

That fundamentally, I believe that that makes a positive difference. And good news is that also commercially has a positive impact. Because the more number of people you are basically

impacting allows you to be able to hopefully make some additional outcome.

But it came with challenges and there were mistakes made. I have no qualms about saying it. So, I started fixing and consolidating 2020 early.

[Speaker 3] (3:50:53 - 3:51:00)

You think admitting mistakes early? Sorry? Admitting mistakes early, big part of being successful?

[Speaker 1] (3:51:01 - 3:52:17)

I think so. I think admitting mistakes and saying Mia Kalpa is critical. Because a lot of times...

Early. Early. Yes.

The reason is, you know, when you're having a... You know, you effectively as a business leader or an entrepreneur, you have to be able to make decisions. To make decisions, it's critical to have conversations which are authentic and not pretentious.

The only way you can have a non-pretentious conversation is if the elephant is out of the room. If people don't talk about elephant, then you can have many conversations. The other person is always thinking, okay, but he made this mistake.

Still, these people are saying that we will bounce back. How will that happen? But if you're able to say that these are the mistakes that were made and you have to be honest about it because it is very easy to understand.

Because there is not much difference between Katni and Karni in our business. You can see it, right? Because you can just come out of this, like you can go to Indira Nagar, see an OYO hotel, and see traces of what I have said there and the other way around in some context, right?

Or it's true for all of our businesses. If mistakes are made, it will be visible at our stores.

[Speaker 2] (3:52:17 - 3:52:45)

I think this is also very true for all successful businesses because I see a lot of founders not having the courage to admit that they've made a mistake. And what happens is they try and continue to conceal it because they've pitched it in a certain way. They feel that their word is so strong, it becomes an ego problem and they don't want to, one, admit it.

And because of that, they fall into that loop where you're not correcting. The only way to figure things out is…

[Speaker 1] (3:52:45 - 3:54:45)

And you become more lonely as an outcome. Because more and more people sort of desert you. So I believe that admitting mistake early is crucial and it is also crucial to make sure that you are close to your roots.

I think if you're… When you try to run away from mistakes, it's a very easy way of running away from reality. And then you sort of build a world around yourself, which is just entirely…

But anyway, I think, long story short, I think mistakes are made. I was consolidating. By the time I could fix it, Mr. COVID knocked on the doors and said, Well, you know…

We'll do it fast. I'll make it harder for you. So imagine I had forward invested that we will…

The year before COVID, we grew 300%, right? COVID hits. So you had forward invested for growth.

You're starting to consolidate. But you're able to fund it partly through the margins you're generating from the current revenues, right? And partly through external financing.

With COVID, 65% of your revenue overnight evaporates. Right? So in effect, you have to fund 100% or majority through external financing.

There is a limit to the capital available. There's not infinite capital available with anyone. Especially for a business that is shrinking.

A business that is growing higher, slower, you can debate. But a business has shrunk during COVID. So it was hard on us.

Most digital-led brands, right? Look at e-commerce, look at gaming, look at any industry. They all saw massive ramp-up during COVID.

Now, here I am. Where my revenue has shrunk 65%. And people were basically calling right all the entire deck.

Right from my CXOs to the last person. Recruiters calling. Saying, look, we don't know what will happen to OYO's stock.

We don't know what will happen to the company. Here's 2 or 3x salary jump. And we're getting a pay cut.

[Speaker 2] (3:54:46 - 3:54:48)

And these were other travel companies?

[Speaker 1] (3:54:48 - 3:55:57)

No, no. Our people are not specialists, right? Our people are technology people.

So you basically can recruit them across... Mostly generalists, right? In terms of construct.

So the fungibility of talent is very high. With other tech companies. So, look, you get a 2x salary.

You have more stock. Lifestyle is better. You know, things will be much better as an outcome.

So I think fundamentally at that point of time, I feel like that one year was probably one of the toughest ones as an operator to drive. But I think at the same time, I feel like that one year really transformed our company as well as the way we think and operate. I think now we've become very comfortable being the 30% growth company.

We don't want to become 200-300% now. We are happy about it. I think we have a sense of semblance on what we believe is our cash flow margins.

And for us, I think, we have a consumer rating expectation below which we will not grow. We have a merchant revenue expectation below which we will not grow. And we have a margin expectation at the EBITDA and cash flow level.

As long as we want to grow as quickly as we can, if we don't, we will not grow. I think a lot of these perspectives, I think, would have come anyway over time. But I think COVID accelerated that significantly without giving a choice.

[Speaker 3] (3:55:58 - 3:56:22)

I think what you're also saying is a big determinant of success is the ability to get punched, not necessarily punch. And be sanguine about it and go about life. Big precursor to success.

Right? But I think any startup journey, you got to be okay to get beat up.

[Speaker 2] (3:56:22 - 3:56:28)

Yeah, you will definitely get beaten up. How fast are you able to bounce back? I think that's good.

[Speaker 3] (3:56:28 - 3:56:30)

And you don't kind of like react or...

[Speaker 1] (3:56:31 - 3:56:33)

Yeah, yeah. Like you would have...

[Speaker 3] (3:56:33 - 3:56:39)

I've never seen you speak back on social media, defend yourself in a weird manner, in a

defensive manner.

[Speaker 1] (3:56:40 - 3:57:41)

Right? I think, personally, I think I have learned to take criticism in a very... Like, and I believe it will be very valuable for other young people listening also.

Like, if I read some of the business leaders, some people say that I don't read news about us. Actually, I am quite the contrary. I read everything.

I have no problem reading everything. But I can read everything and feel comfortable that what is the noise and what is the signal. So I think, fundamentally, criticism can be constructive or it can be just noise.

Noise never sticks. Because it's noise by design. So if there is something that I am reading about myself that I don't know about.

Right? There'd be some news of saying that, okay, OYO is buying some business in Southeast Asia or some business in Middle East. I know there's no truth to it.

So some people speculate that it's over. It's done. Or something will come about, well, you know, Ritesh is going to do something new very soon.

So I feel like it's a noise.

[Speaker 3] (3:57:41 - 3:57:47)

What is your relationship with Masayoshi San? How did it get inculcated? Has it soured?

[Speaker 1] (3:57:49 - 3:59:33)

Look, I think you asked, I often call him Sansan given, in Japan, you typically add a San at the end, out of respect. So I think Sansan is a first generation entrepreneur. Invested in Alibaba quite early, built his own telecom business, which is now probably the most profitable business in Japan and one of the most profitable telecom business in the world in terms of construct.

And then invested in Alibaba, which did very well, and then set up multiple SoftBank vision funds and Arm and a few others. I think so that's the context behind who he is. I think I would basically correlate it as SoftBank's relationship.

And within that, of course, talk about Sansan. I think I got introduced to SoftBank first time in 2015 or 2016. And when we were in that growth phase, we were in three cities then, they're starting to take off.

So I think Nikesh introduced us. And Nikesh did the work. He's now the CEO of Palo Alto

Networks.

The deal was more or less agreed between Nikesh and the broader SoftBank team. There was a broader SoftBank and SoftBank team. At that time, they used to invest in the balance sheet.

So that's how we got introduced to each other in the first place. So before the final investment decision is made, you have to go and present to Sansan, and he approves finally. So I went to Japan.

I was again very excited to go to a new country. And so I'm generally the person who's always very happy and excited about new places and new things, right? Like, you know, now the Shark Tank episodes are airing.

So there's some trolls saying that, you know, why are you smiling all the time? I'm just generally happy being there.

[Speaker 2] (3:59:36 - 3:59:38)

You're smiling even today. That's who you are.

[Speaker 1] (3:59:38 - 4:00:15)

So I'm generally like, you know, whenever I'm in new places, I'm happy and I'm excited. So Sansan comes. I make a quick presentation.

So he explains two or three things, which is quite fascinating to me. I think first thing he mentions is that if I were you, I would go as full stack as possible rather than being more and more marketplace, which is that I do more to control the experience. Do you mean own the hotel?

No, not own the hotel. But basically sort of can you potentially like delivery companies have a service provider who goes and delivers? Can the front office manager be yours?

[Speaker 4] (4:00:16 - 4:00:16)

Right.

[Speaker 1] (4:00:16 - 4:02:27)

So that you can have slightly greater control over the experience. Of course, the economics of it which can be complicated. The second or beneficial depends.

Second thing he says is you're very early. But I think, you know, if you are in this growth path, making sure that you continuously track the consumer satisfaction loop closure will be crucial before you ramp up or down. There will be times when the consumer feedbacks will continue to be positive.

And he said it will most definitely happen. It did happen to us that the feedbacks would be great all through when you're growing. And then suddenly one day you'll see that you've grown greater than usual.

The consumer feedback is not showing that great outcomes. He said that will necessarily happen. When it does happen, you should consider pausing.

And the third, he said, is that you are the CEO. So you make the decisions. You will receive great ideas from all our advisors.

But eventually, if your company does well or not, you'll be responsible. All three made complete sense. But you only appreciate, like he said, tuition fees.

You only appreciate when you made enough mistakes. You don't listen or appreciate those just purely by words. So very wise words.

So that's how the investment happened with SoftBank. And then, of course, very quickly, Nikesh moved on. And I think ever since after that, Rajiv, Munish, and that sort of cohort became our primary partners from SoftBank over the years.

And our relationship was very much, you know, we meet in a quarter, review the business, go through. And once in a year, you know, you also get invited to go present to Sansan. And I think the one unique takeaway that I have personally about Sansan that I think most of the people have not talked about is people see Sansan primarily as an investor, financial investor, and so on.

I think he's at his heart an entrepreneur first and investor second. And the depth and the attention to detail that he has, his creativity and his sense of sort of coming up with new ideas are, in my view, what makes him special in the first place. Insane.

[Speaker 3] (4:02:28 - 4:02:29)

Insane stories.

[Speaker 1] (4:02:29 - 4:02:33)

Curious ability. Curious without an ego. That's a good way to put it.

You've given me so much.

[Speaker 3] (4:02:34 - 4:05:51)

I'll tell you from my side. I learned so much from you guys in so many different facets, some that are evident, some that are non-evident, like the father thing. My father passed away just now, 30 days, 35 days ago.

So sorry to hear. No, but your journey, one month, three months, six months, I was asking you six years, very interesting. Okay, so I'm going to put down success parameters, add to the previous two and say, admitting mistakes early, very important.

Curiosity, extremely, extremely important. Probably something I resonate with the most. Contrarian, very nature of a startup.

I think a company begins with something contrarian, especially if you're starting young. Clarity of thought, rigid, particular, all three of you said that. With you, nuance, I would add, in a very Taoist way, likability and niceness is so underrated in the world right now.

Like a lot of people I choose to work with, I choose to partner with. I think today I have the privilege and it's also such an important metric to me that I need to like hanging out with them. At the core, they need to be nice people.

So I think people undermine the importance of how likable and nice you are as a person. I think it's incredibly valuable as a business. All of you said again, you with standing outside, Ghazal stood outside a toy store, Manish was willing to bend his back and go ask somebody something that other people might not have.

No ego, which also came from you. Again, incredible. Always be selling.

Even when they were answering their questions, you were selling and plugging all your rooms. I think that again is incredibly important. Delaying ratification, indifference is cool.

Both of these again on top of the list. So what we're trying to like arrive at today is whenever a young 21-year-old boy or girl wants to know what makes startup founders, people like yourself successful, they get generic bullshit. They get hardworking, they get sell in this particular manner, use this sales strategy.

All of it, which is taking away from the core emotion of what is actually working for you guys. So intent here was to ask you non-usual questions, get non-usual answers and hopefully help that 21-year-old. I'll run through all three of your main things, starting with yours.

Optimism, aware of cyclicality, continuing from where we left off. Serendipity is again a very interesting one, right? Imposter complex is good.

A lot of us seem to have it. Insecurity is good. As long as neither of these lead to inaction, but they lead to action, right?

[Speaker 2] (4:05:51 - 4:05:53)

Yeah, that's very important.

[Speaker 1] (4:05:53 - 4:05:55)

It's called good sense of insecurity.

[Speaker 2] (4:05:56 - 4:05:56)

Yeah, yeah.

[Speaker 1] (4:05:58 - 4:05:58)

Creativity.

[Speaker 3] (4:05:59 - 4:06:13)

This is again something that is often overlooked. You defined creativity in a very nice manner. Rewarding loyalty, reprimanding disloyalty.

Very important.

[Speaker 4] (4:06:13 - 4:06:14)

Yeah, true.

[Speaker 3] (4:06:14 - 4:07:32)

Forgiving, but not forgetting. Confidence in how you look post-12. This could come via playing a sport, yoga, sleeping for eight hours.

Extremely important. Because you're confident about how you look and how you feel about yourself. You're likely more easily confident about what you're selling.

Fair? Sleep, holiday, all of this comes into the same thing. Avoidant attachment type.

Good for startups. Bad for relationships overall, but good for starting a company. I think I'm like that.

Like I have a tendency, I fear sympathy in others' eyes for me. I fear being vulnerable so much that if I am going through something, I will hide it. Like something bad happening in my life, some bad event.

I would rarely mention it. It's bad, but bad in relationships. Very unhealthy.

But for a company, maybe it's to start a company. I don't know how that's translating. But that seems to be common to a lot of people.

[Speaker 2] (4:07:35 - 4:07:39)

Even with your company, is that good?

[Speaker 1] (4:07:39 - 4:07:42)

It's healthy if you're not emotionally attached to the company.

[Speaker 2] (4:07:42 - 4:08:08)

No, but when times get tough, and I feel that I have that emotional connect with my company where I still, I'll be like, I will figure this out. But if I am, and for which I also end up being vulnerable in front of my leadership team, being open about what's happening and trying to figure it out all together because I can't do it alone. If I don't have that, I feel that...

How do you look at it?

[Speaker 3] (4:08:09 - 4:09:36)

Actually, very interesting nuance. I feel like I get stoic about things that are not working because I feel like in life, 10 things are not working at the same time. So I take that thing which is not working and my avoidant type puts it in a compartment and I come back to it after I fix 3, 4 of the 10 things.

But for that second, what works for me is compartmentalizing. It's very like stoic, nihilistic in its origin. That seems to be a common trait as well.

And what made it even more interesting is one is bootstrapped, one is a public company and one is a largely funded company. So we covered broad spectrum, what we think are the prerequisites to be successful in a startup. I think Manish had something else.

Story, very, very important. Almost as important as a product. Weave your story, even if it is embellished in the very beginning in a manner that is most appealing to the audience you're trying to cater to.

Fair? Pay attention to detail, every little detail. Perfume, music.

What else did you say? The tiny details, the horizontal stitch.

[Speaker 2] (4:09:36 - 4:09:39)

The creative of the perfume and how it's going to come to life.

[Speaker 1] (4:09:39 - 4:09:41)

Not having the logo on the chest.

[Speaker 3] (4:09:41 - 4:09:44)

Indian waist sizes are two inches higher than...

[Speaker 1] (4:09:44 - 4:09:45)

Can be rigid on that as well.

[Speaker 3] (4:09:45 - 4:09:45)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (4:09:45 - 4:09:47)

People are here to change you.

[Speaker 3] (4:09:47 - 4:10:27)

Yeah. Another big, big commonality between everybody who is a successful entrepreneur is take risk. Risk-taking ability seems to be one par higher in this crowd of successful ones versus everybody else.

Having 10 crores and taking a 37 crore loan. Leaving home and doing art, which is the most counterintuitive thing that anybody would do. Beyond a course in NIT, learning to be a computer programming teacher.

Yeah, multiple times. Going to New York in your first year of marriage.

[Speaker 2] (4:10:28 - 4:10:29)

All by myself.

[Speaker 3] (4:10:29 - 4:10:30)

All by yourself.

[Speaker 2] (4:10:30 - 4:10:33)

While I was out of Chandigarh, the only other city was Delhi.

[Speaker 3] (4:10:33 - 4:11:27)

Yeah. For Ritesh, I can't even begin. There's so much, like so much in terms of taking risk outside of what a conformist, conventional, normal 20-year-old boy of your age would have done.

What this paper misses out is once you incorporate or try to inculcate some of this, the underlying differentiator between A and B and C and D is luck at the very core of it. I think you have to come to terms. Every single entrepreneur has to come to terms with that.

But you know what I feel is a bigger challenge than going from zero to one is finding the gumption in you to reinvent yourself after the ecosystem around you has built up your ego into a bubble to come to terms with the fact that you have become complacent faster than the market tells you.

[Speaker 1] (4:11:28 - 4:11:31)

Yeah. Yeah. I think...

And that's how the incumbents lead, right?

[Speaker 3] (4:11:31 - 4:11:32)

Very true. Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (4:11:32 - 4:11:47)

Like Facebook's greatest example is... Ditching the metaverse. And then flipping back and making Instagram the heart of their business which is of course now become into...

Comes back to creativity. Last one week. Like if you look at the Facebook stock price...

Facebook looks like Nav Bharat and...

[Speaker 3] (4:11:47 - 4:11:57)

Should we add that surrounding yourself by people who are able to say outsiders often who are able to say to your face you're screwing up.

[Speaker 1] (4:11:57 - 4:11:58)

Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (4:11:58 - 4:12:01)

I think that's very important. It is very important. I think that's extremely important.

[Speaker 3] (4:12:01 - 4:12:37)

At the end of every episode we do... This one we're doing after a long time. We've not put anything out for two months.

At the end of every episode we pay forward a little bit of the good luck we've gotten and we fund someone young someone we were talking to through this episode. A 21-22 year old boy or girl. So we'll all commit a certain amount of money.

We'll have a process where we open it up like you got your Thiel fellowship. We'll try to create our own fellowship.

[Speaker 1] (4:12:37 - 4:12:38)

That's nice.

[Speaker 3] (4:12:38 - 4:12:53)

And we'll get applications. We'll share all the applications with everyone here and we arrive at who should get the fellowship or the investment from all four of us together. Perfect.

This process will take a little bit of time like 15-20 days. But we'll run it.

[Speaker 1] (4:12:53 - 4:12:56)

What if we call it WTF Founders Fellowship?

[Speaker 4] (4:12:57 - 4:12:57)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (4:12:57 - 4:12:58)

It's a nice name. Have you done this before?

[Speaker 3] (4:12:59 - 4:13:11)

WTF Fund? Yeah, yeah. We do it at the end of each episode.

We do something or the other. We did one for influencers. We did one...

We did... We paid a couple of charities. EV sector.

[Speaker 1] (4:13:11 - 4:13:21)

So how about we... Four of us. Yeah.

We all give something small like 10 lakhs each or 20 lakhs each to four founders at the end of it as a grant.

[Speaker 4] (4:13:22 - 4:13:22)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (4:13:22 - 4:13:24)

What do you think? Works. Perfect.

You guys are okay with it?

[Speaker 4] (4:13:25 - 4:13:25)

Absolutely.

[Speaker 1] (4:13:25 - 4:13:27)

Should we do 20 lakhs each? 20 lakhs each.

[Speaker 3] (4:13:28 - 4:13:40)

And we'll put like a draft application that they can put out. And we'll... All four of us review it.

However, we can find time and we can all pick one each.

[Speaker 2] (4:13:40 - 4:13:41)

Perfect. Done? Done.

[Speaker 1] (4:13:41 - 4:13:41)

Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (4:13:41 - 4:13:42)

Very nice.

[Speaker 3] (4:13:42 - 4:13:43)

Done.

[Speaker 1] (4:13:43 - 4:13:43)

Super.

[Speaker 3] (4:13:43 - 4:13:45)

Thank you guys for flying down.

[Speaker 1] (4:13:45 - 4:13:47)

And hopefully someday one of them will be a guest in your podcast.

[Speaker 3] (4:13:47 - 4:13:48)

Like Zepto guys.

[Speaker 1] (4:13:48 - 4:14:01)

Absolutely. Thiel Fellowship. It could even be you.

It could be any one of us. Yeah. Which we will help support.

Done. I'll be very happy. Thank you guys so much for coming and spending so much time.

[Speaker 2] (4:14:01 - 4:14:02)

Thank you. Thank you for having us.

[Speaker 1] (4:14:03 - 4:14:07)

Thank you. Thank you so much, Nikhil. We have to do one.

[Speaker 2] (4:14:07 - 4:14:12)

This would be the longest podcast that I would ever shoot in my life. I think.

[Speaker 3] (4:14:12 - 4:14:25)

Do you guys realize in our attempt to define the prerequisites of a successful entrepreneur that a 21-year-old can emulate. We've been speaking for eight hours without a real break, really.

[Speaker 4] (4:14:26 - 4:14:27)

Eight? Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (4:14:27 - 4:14:29)

It's 4 a.m. What?

[Speaker 2] (4:14:29 - 4:14:29)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (4:14:30 - 4:14:33)

I have to leave then. My flight is at 5.15. Oh god, seriously?

[Speaker 2] (4:14:33 - 4:14:35)

What are you saying? Really? Really.

[Speaker 4] (4:14:37 - 4:14:39)

Also, you're definitely not getting the eight-hour sleep.

[Speaker 1] (4:14:40 - 4:14:40)

But you're not getting the flight.